

Cārvāka (Lokāyata) — Revision Guide

Philosophy Optional · Paper I · Indian Philosophy · Topic 01

Formal teaching, optional advanced depth and consolidated register notes are preserved from the completed authoritative learning session. MCQs and answer practice are separated into their dedicated surfaces to prevent answer leakage.

CONTENTS

Page numbers are generated from the final layout. PDF bookmarks include finer subheadings.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION	4	CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES	88
OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER	74	Canonical authority control	110

title: "Cārvāka (Lokāyata) — Complete Learning Session" topic_key: philosophy-paper-i-indian-philosophy-01 variant: learner-v2

Cārvāka (Lokāyata) — Complete Learning Session

Syllabus, verbatim: *Carvaka : Theory of Knowledge; Rejection of Transcendent Entities* — UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section B, item 12. **Evidence discipline:** the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra* is lost and the school survives mainly in the words of its opponents, so doctrine is stated as the standard doxographical reconstruction. ✓ marks convergent doctrine, ⚠ marks analytical reconstruction and ? marks a contested attribution. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit term in IAST follows immediately in parentheses.

What this package contains

Component	Count
Progressive teaching sessions in the Basic block	9
Original diagnostic MCQs — 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full	9
Supporting routed PYQ solved in full	1
Original solved Mains models — two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6
Consolidated register parts, plus the detailed nine-subtopic register	12 (A–L)

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

CONCEPT SPINE — ENGLISH FIRST, SANSKRIT IMMEDIATELY AFTER

ONE MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE

perception (pratyakṣa)

external + internal

|

|

v

INFERENCE (anumāna) and TESTIMONY (śabda)

refused independent standing

because invariable concomitance

(vyāpti) cannot be secured

---->

ONE WORLD

four elements (bhūtas):

earth, water, fire, air

no ether (ākāśa)

|

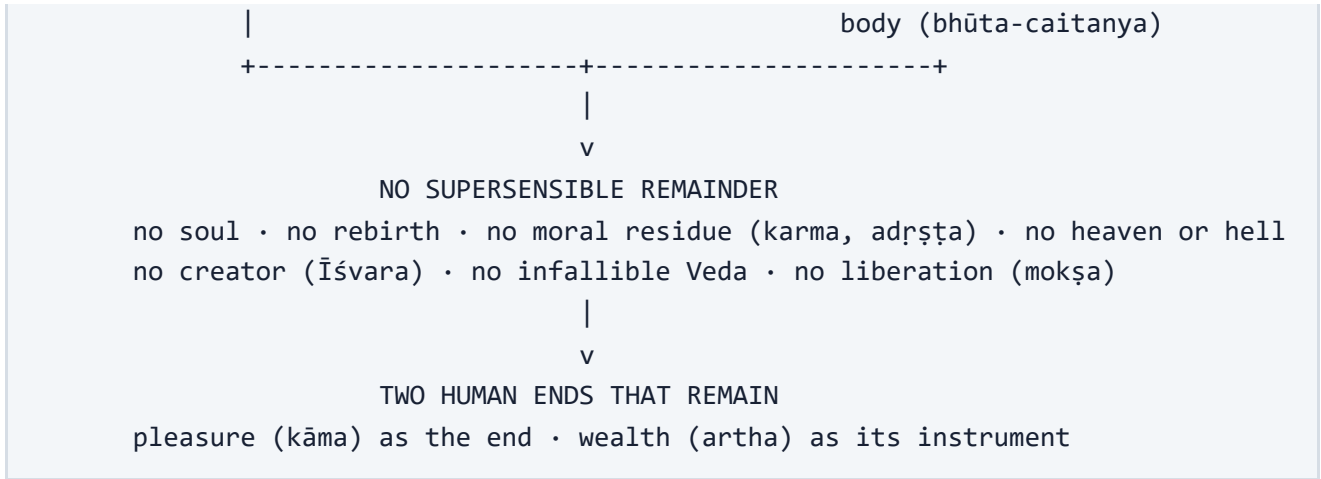
v

ONE LIFE

living body is the self

(dehātmavāda); awareness

emerges from the organised



Concept spine: the English concept leads and the Sanskrit term in IAST follows immediately. Read it downward — the epistemic rule at the top generates every denial below it.

Answer-worthiness. Perception-only epistemology, the critique of inference, four-element materialism, the body-self, emergent consciousness and the rejection of transcendent entities are **core syllabus**. Source historiography, strong versus softened readings, Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa and controlled modern comparisons are **core supporting depth**. Crude hedonist caricature and invented primary-text certainty are excluded.

HOW TO READ THIS SESSION

⚠ **Reconstruction discipline.** Contemporary labels such as empiricism, naturalism, secularism or dissent may aid comparison only when qualified; they can never replace historically controlled reconstruction from the surviving witnesses.

Complete the Basic block first. Optional interpretive depth is deliberately withheld until the clearly labelled optional block after the practice sections, so that the core doctrine stays easy to learn and immediately usable in a competent answer.

ONE-SCREEN MAP

SOURCE PROBLEM

- > PERCEPTION AS SOLE MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE (pramāṇa)
- > INFERENCE CRITIQUE
- > NYAYA DEFENCE
- > FOUR-ELEMENT MATERIALISM
- > BODY-SELF AND EMERGENT CONSCIOUSNESS
- > REJECTION OF TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES
- > THIS-WORLDLY ETHICS AND SOCIAL MEANING
- > COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS

This is a route map, not a substitute for the nine complete Basic subtopics below.

SESSION 1 — HISTORICAL RECONSTRUCTION AND THE SOURCE PROBLEM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Because Cārvāka primary texts are lost, the school must be reconstructed from quotations and opponents while separating convergent doctrine from polemical caricature.

Technical definition: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school), also called Lokāyata (worldly doctrine), is a non-Vedic and this-worldly philosophy that accepts perception (pratyakṣa) as the only independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and rejects unverifiable transcendent entities; because its primary texts are lost, its doctrines must be stated as a cautious doxographical reconstruction.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cārvāka (Indian materialist school), also called Lokāyata (worldly doctrine), is a non-Vedic and this-worldly philosophy that accepts perception (pratyakṣa) as the only independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and rejects unverifiable transcendent entities; because its primary texts are lost, its doctrines must be stated as a cautious doxographical reconstruction.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **hostile doxography**
- **lost Bṛhaspati-sūtra**
- **Lokāyata**
- **Bārhaspatya**
- **Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa**
- **source convergence**

How to use them: Use the lost primary text and hostile doxography to qualify attribution, then invoke convergent reports to defend a recoverable Cārvāka doctrinal core.

Plain-language visual - learning through an opponent's notes

```
ORIGINAL CARVAKA BOOK
|
X  lost
|
What opponents quoted ---> our main evidence
|
One surviving sceptical work (Jayarasi)
|
CAREFUL RECONSTRUCTION, not blind certainty
```

In simple words: imagine trying to understand a debater when their own notebook is lost and only the rival team's rebuttal survives. We can still recover the main position because several opponents repeat the same core claims, but we must distinguish secure doctrine from hostile caricature.

Remember first	Meaning
Cārvāka / Lokāyata / Bārhaspatya	Three names associated with the materialist tradition
Lost primary text	The <i>Bṛhaspati-sūtra</i> does not survive
Main caution	Write "on the standard doxographical reconstruction"
Why <i>Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)</i> ?	Rejection of Vedic authority, not simply disbelief in God

One-line memory: Cārvāka is known mostly through its critics, so reconstruct firmly but quote cautiously.

CORE DEFINITION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school), also called Lokāyata (worldly doctrine), is a non-Vedic and this-worldly philosophy that accepts perception (pratyakṣa) as the only independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and rejects unverifiable transcendent entities; because its primary texts are lost, its doctrines must be stated as a cautious doxographical reconstruction.

VISUAL — How we know what we know about Cārvāka

WHAT WOULD BE IDEAL =====	WHAT WE ACTUALLY HAVE =====
BRHASPATI-SUTRA (primary)	(LOST)
direct transmission	about a dozen sutras and
v	verses quoted by OTHERS
Carvaka commentaries	v
	+-----+
v	HOSTILE DOXOGRAPHY
Living school with pupils	Sarva-darsana-sangraha
	Sad-darsana-samuccaya
	Prabodhacandrodaya (play)
	Tattvasangraha (Buddhist)
	Vedantasara (Advaita)
	+-----+
	refutation-first framing:
	strongest points omitted,
	weakest points magnified
	v
	+ ONE surviving sceptical text
	TATTVOPAPLAVASIMHA
	(Jayarasi Bhatta, c. 8th c. CE)
	-- but it is MORE sceptical
	than the standard Carvaka

⚠ **Caption.** Every claim in this topic passes through a filter of refutation. That does not make reconstruction impossible; it makes *epistemic honesty about the reconstruction* itself a mark-earning move. The examiner rewards a candidate who writes "on the standard doxographical reconstruction" rather than one who quotes a lost text as though it were open on the desk.

1. The three names, and what each one tells you

Name	Literal sense	What it signals	Evidence status
Cārvāka	Possibly from <i>carv</i> , "to chew, to eat" — the doctrine of "eat, drink and be merry"; or from <i>cāru-vāk</i> , "sweet-worded / pleasant of speech"	Either a hostile nickname or a note that the doctrine is superficially attractive	✅ Both etymologies are given in Chatterjee and Datta; C. D. Sharma adds a third gloss — one who "chews up" merit and demerit
Lokāyata	<i>Lokāyata-mata</i> , "the view of the common people"; a <i>lokāyatika</i> is its holder	The school is popular, worldly, this-worldly; by implication in hostile sources, unrefined	✅ Chatterjee and Datta; Sharma adds that "commoner" carries a pejorative implication of low taste in the sources
Bārhaspatya	"Of Bṛhaspati"	Traces the school to Bṛhaspati as its traditional founder	✅ Sharma: "Bṛhaspati, a heretical teacher, is regarded as the traditional founder of this school. His <i>Sūtra</i> ... has unfortunately perished."

✅ There is a further doxographical curiosity, reported in both Chatterjee and Datta and Sharma: some accounts identify this Bṛhaspati with the *teacher of the gods*, who is said to have propagated materialism among the *asuras* precisely so that, following these attractive teachings, they would come to ruin. ? That story is polemical theology, not history; quote it only to illustrate how the tradition was framed by its enemies.

⚠ **Exam use.** The highlighted answer-grabbing line above is the preferred full opening. For a very short answer, write: "Cārvāka, also called Lokāyata and Bārhaspatya, is the materialist and *Veda-rejecting school* (*nāstika*) (non-Vedic) school of Indian philosophy."

2. The source problem, stated precisely

✅ **The facts, as the standard textbooks state them.**

1. No systematic primary work of the school survives. Chatterjee and Datta: "we do not find any systematic work on materialism, nor any organised school of followers as the other philosophical schools possess."
2. The *Bṛhaspati-sūtra* is lost. Sharma: about **a dozen** *sūtras* and verses are found quoted or referred to by other authors as the materialistic teachings of Bṛhaspati.
3. "Almost every work of the other schools states, for refutation, the materialistic views. Our knowledge of Indian materialism is chiefly based on these" (Chatterjee and Datta).
4. Sharma is blunter about the consequence: "the weak points in this school are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture."
5. Sharma adds the decisive historiographical warning: even the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* summary "seems to be based on such accounts", so it does not give independent access to the school.

⚠ **What follows philosophically.** Three consequences, each usable as a line in an answer:

- (a) MODAL CAUTION : write "on the standard reconstruction", not "Carvaka says in his text".
- (b) CHARITY : where a doctrine has a crude and a defensible version, the crude one is the one an enemy would preserve. Reconstruct the strongest available reading and SAY that you are doing so.
- (c) NON-PARALYSIS : convergence across independent hostile sources on the same doctrinal core (perceptualism, anti-inferentialism, four elements, no soul, no afterlife) is itself evidence.

3. The surviving fragments — what is actually quoted

✓ Sharma gleans the following from the *Brhaspati* material quoted across philosophical writings. These are the closest thing to primary text that exists, and they are quoted *by others*:

#	Sūtra (as transmitted)	Doctrine
1	<i>prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni</i>	Earth, water, fire and air are the elements
2	<i>tatsamudāye śāṇḍilyendriyaviśaya-saṃjñā</i>	Bodies, senses and objects are results of different combinations of the elements
3	<i>kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam</i>	Consciousness arises from matter as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents
4	<i>caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ</i>	The person is the body qualified by consciousness
5	<i>pleasure (kāma) evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ</i>	Enjoyment is the only end of human life
6	<i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>	Death alone is liberation

✓ Alongside these, the second act of Kṛṣṇamiśra's allegorical play *Prabodhacandrodaya* summarises the doctrine in a single sweep: "Lokāyata is the only *śāstra*; perception is the only authority; earth, water, fire and air are the only elements; enjoyment is the only end of human existence; mind is only a product of matter. There is no other world; death means liberation."

? **Caution to carry through the whole session.** A play written by an opponent, staged as allegory, is a *representation* of the doctrine. It is legitimate evidence of how the school was understood; it is not the school's own voice.

4. Why Cārvāka is *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)* — and the exact sense of the word

✓ This is a precision point that separates strong scripts from weak ones. Chatterjee and Datta set it out exactly:

Sense of <i>āstika</i>	Meaning in Sanskrit philosophical literature	Is Cārvāka <i>Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)</i> in this sense?
Primary, classificatory sense	One who accepts the authority of the Vedas	✓ Yes — this is the sense that generates the six- <i>āstika</i> / three- <i>Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)</i> division
Secondary sense	One who believes in life after death	✓ Yes
Modern vernacular sense	"Theist" versus "atheist"	⚠ Misleading. Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā and early Yoga-adjacent readings are non-theistic yet <i>āstika</i>

✓ Chatterjee and Datta state the consequence directly: the six orthodox schools are *āstika*, "and the Cārvāka is *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)* in both the senses". Jaina and Bauddha schools are *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)* on the first criterion but would count as *āstika* on the second, since they accept life after death.

🔑 **Trap, and it is examined:** *Cārvāka is Veda-rejecting school (nāstika) primarily because it rejects Vedic authority, not merely because it denies God.* If denial of God were the criterion, Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā would also be *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)* — and they are not.

5. Why materialism arose — the historical setting

✓ Sharma gives the standard account: the school "seems to be very old", with references in the epics and in early Buddhist literature; Garbe is quoted to the effect that "even in the pre-Buddhistic India proclaimers of purely materialistic doctrines appeared." Sharma locates its rise in the post-Upaniṣadic and pre-Buddhistic age and attributes it to:

1. protest against the excessive monkdome of the Brāhmaṇa priests;
2. the externals of ritualism, "which ignored the substance and emphasized the shadow";
3. an Upaniṣadic idealism "unsuited to the commoners";
4. political and social crises, exploitation of the masses by petty rulers, monks and the wealthy class.

✓ Early Buddhist scripture confirms an environment of such thinkers. The *Sāmaññaphala-sutta* names four contemporaries of the Buddha whom Chatterjee and Datta group as "cunning (*dhūrta*) Cārvākas":

Thinker	Position as reported
Pūraṇa Kassapa	Denies moral responsibility, virtue and vice
Makkhali Gosāla	Denies free will and the possibility of moral effort
Ajita Kesakambalī	Teaches the material origin and destructibility of man, the futility of good action, the impossibility of knowledge
Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta	Will neither affirm, nor deny, nor both, nor even admit that he neither affirms nor denies

✓ Sharma independently notes Ajita Kesakambalin in the *Majjhima Nikāya* as "a materialist ... who believed only in perception and in four elements", and records that Śāntarakṣita refers to him as *Kambalāśvatara*.

⚠ **Exam use.** Naming Ajita Kesakambalī gives you a *pre-systematic historical anchor* for four-element materialism that is independent of the hostile Brahmanical doxography — a genuinely strong evidential move in a 15- or 20-marker on sources.

6. Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa — the one surviving text, and why it must be handled carefully

✓ **The facts.** Chatterjee and Datta: the *Tattvopaplavasīṃha*, by **Jayarāśi**, "probably of the eighth century A.D.", is a "recently discovered manuscript" and "an interesting specimen of Indian absolute scepticism"; its author "is believed to be a Cārvāka (or Lokāyatika) of an **extreme type**." Sharma records the publication data: it is the "single exception" to the absence of extant works, published by the Oriental Institute of Baroda in 1940.

✓ **What Jayarāśi actually does.** He "carries the scepticism of the ordinary Cārvāka to its logical conclusion by challenging the validity of **perceptual** knowledge and refusing to accept the existence of even the physical elements. With a relentless destructive dialectic he exposes the defects of all the usually accepted sources of knowledge." His conclusion, Chatterjee and Datta note, is that of "an anti-intellectualist pragmatist": even on the denial of all theoretical principles and doctrines, practical life will go on as ever with unreflective ease.

⚠ **The distinction that must be preserved.**

STANDARD CARVAKA -----	JAYARASI'S SCEPTICISM -----
Perception is VALID	Perception is ALSO attacked
Four elements are REAL	Even the elements are not admitted
Positive materialist ontology	NO positive ontology at all
Rejects inference and testimony (pramāṇa)	Rejects EVERY means of valid knowledge
= dogmatic empiricism	= universal scepticism (tattva-upaplava, "the upsetting of all principles")

⚠ **Why this matters for the exam.** It is tempting, and wrong, to use Jayarāśi as evidence for what "the Cārvākas" held about perception. If Jayarāśi is used to establish the school's epistemology, the school's *defining* thesis — that perception alone is a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* — disappears. Use him for exactly two things: (i) as the sole surviving text-witness of the tradition, and (ii) as the internal limit-case showing where consistent Cārvāka scepticism, pressed hard, ends up.

Exam link

Source qualification improves every answer: the lost *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*, hostile doxography and contested attributions must be stated without allowing source caution to erase the convergent doctrinal core.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

1. ? Do not write that "Cārvāka wrote the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*". The text is lost; about a dozen *sūtras* survive only as quotations in other authors' works.

2. ⚠️ Do not treat the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* as an independent primary source. Sharma explicitly says its summary "seems to be based on" the same refutational accounts.
3. ⚠️ Do not use Jayarāṣi's *Tattvopaplavasīṃha* to state the Cārvāka theory of knowledge. He attacks perception too, which no standard Cārvāka does.
4. ✅ Do not say Cārvāka is *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)* "because it is atheist". It is *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)* because it rejects the authority of the Veda — and, in the second textbook sense, because it denies life after death.
5. ⚠️ Do not present the "asura-deception" story about Bṛhaspati as history.
6. ⚠️ Do not conclude from the source problem that "nothing can be known". Convergent hostile testimony still fixes a doctrinal core.
7. ⚠️ Do not confuse *Lokāyata* ("view of the common people") with "folk religion". It names a philosophical position, not a devotional practice.

Revision notes

- ✅ Three names: **Cārvāka** (*carv*, to chew / *cāru-vāk*, sweet-worded), **Lokāyata** (*lokāyata-mata*, the view of common people), **Bārhaspatya** (of Bṛhaspati).
- ✅ Bṛhaspati is the traditional founder; his *Sūtra* is lost; about a dozen *sūtras* survive as quotations.
- ✅ Knowledge of the school comes chiefly from works that state its views **in order to refute them**.
- ✅ Sharma's verdict on transmission: strong points omitted, weak points exaggerated — "a faint caricature and not a true picture".
- ✅ Six transmitted *sūtras* to memorise: four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness like intoxicating power · person = body qualified by consciousness · *pleasure (kāma)* the only end · death alone is liberation.
- ✅ *Prabodhacandrodaya* Act II gives the classic one-sentence summary of the school.
- ✅ **Veda-rejecting school (nāstika) in both senses**: rejects Vedic authority; denies life after death. Vedic authority is the primary classificatory criterion.
- ✅ *Sāmaññaphala-sutta* names Pūraṇa Kassapa, Makkhali Gosāla, Ajita Kesakambalī and Saṅjaya Belaṭṭhiputta as the environment of early scepticism and materialism.
- ✅ Ajita Kesakambalī — "believed only in perception and in four elements" — is the best independent historical anchor for the doctrine.
- ✅ **Jayarāṣi Bhaṭṭa**, *Tattvopaplavasīṃha*, c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — the single surviving text, but an extreme sceptic who attacks perception itself.
- ⚠️ Cārvāka was the **touchstone** every school had to answer; its historical value is critical rather than constructive.
- ⚠️ Two-sided verdict to carry: philosophically fertile as critique (Chatterjee–Datta), unsuccessful as a system (Sharma).

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — HISTORICAL RECONSTRUCTION AND THE SOURCE PROBLEM

SUBTOPIC: HISTORICAL RECONSTRUCTION AND THE SOURCE PROBLEM

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: hostile doxography · lost Bṛhaspati-sūtra · Lokāyata · Bārhaspatya ·

Jayarāṣi Bhaṭṭa · source convergence

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: That does not make reconstruction impossible; it makes epistemic honesty

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: One-line memory: Cārvāka is known mostly through its

critics, so

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: It is Veda-rejecting school (nāstika) because it rejects the authority

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school), also called Lokāyata (worldly

doctrine), is a non-Vedic and this-worldly philosophy that accepts perception (pratyakṣa) as

the only independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and rejects unverifiable transcendent

entities; because its primary texts are lost, its doctrines must be stated as a cautious

doxographical reconstruction.

SESSION 2 — EPISTEMOLOGY — PERCEPTION AS THE SOLE MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE (pramāṇa)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) epistemology treats perception (pratyakṣa) as the only independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), while accepting inference only as fallible practical expectation rather than certain knowledge.

Technical definition: Perception-only epistemology (pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda) treats perception as the sole independent means of valid knowledge and reduces inference and testimony to fallible practical reliance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) epistemology treats perception (pratyakṣa) as the only independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), while accepting inference only as fallible practical expectation rather than certain knowledge.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **perception (pratyakṣa)**
- **means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)**
- **perception-only doctrine (pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda)**
- **practical inference**
- **verbal testimony (śabda)**
- **certainty**

How to use them: State perception as the sole independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), then distinguish corrigible everyday expectation from the universally certain inference that Cārvāka contests.

CORE DEFINITION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) epistemology treats perception (*pratyakṣa*) as the only independent means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*), while accepting inference only as fallible practical expectation rather than certain knowledge.

Plain-language visual - the knowledge gate

Can I directly experience it?

|

YES v NO

accept inference/testimony may guide action,
as known but cannot guarantee philosophical certainty

In simple words: Cārvāka treats perception as the only secure entrance to knowledge. Inference and testimony may be useful in daily life, but their conclusions can fail; therefore they do not independently certify unseen realities.

Everyday case	Cārvāka reading
Seeing fire	Directly known through perception
Seeing smoke and expecting fire	A useful expectation, not infallible knowledge
Hearing a trustworthy person	The words are heard; their truth still needs checking
Feeling pain or pleasure	Internally experienced and therefore perceptible

One-line memory: perception gives certainty; other routes may give practical probability.

VISUAL — The means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*) ledger of Indian philosophy, and where Cārvāka stands

Legend: P = perception (*pratyakṣa*); A = inference (*anumāna*); U = comparison (*upamāna*); S = verbal testimony (*śabda*); Ar = postulation (*arthāpatti*); An = non-cognition (*anupalabdhī*).

School	P	A	U	S	Ar	An	Total
Cārvāka	Yes	No	No	No	No	No	1
Vaiśeṣika	Yes	Yes	No	No	No	No	2
Mainstream Buddhist epistemology *	Yes	Yes	No	No	No	No	2
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	No	No	3
Nyāya	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No	4

School	P	A	U	S	Ar	An	Total
Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	5
Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	6
Advaita Vedānta*	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	6

Takeaway: Cārvāka alone recognises perception as the sole independent *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*) in this standard comparison.

This is the standard pedagogical ledger. Buddhist classifications vary by school and period; Advaita's standard later account admits six. Cārvāka may use inference as fallible practical expectation while denying it independent status as a means of valid knowledge.

⚠️ **Caption.** This ledger is worth reproducing from memory in any *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*) question in Paper I. It shows at a glance that the Cārvāka position is not an eccentric outlier but the **lower bound** of a shared Indian debate about how many independent sources of knowledge there are. Nyāya sits at four; Cārvāka drives the number down to one and forces every other school to justify its additions.

1. The core thesis, stated exactly

✅ **Thesis (*pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*).** Perception alone is a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*) — an independent, dependable source of valid knowledge (*pramā*).

✅ Chatterjee and Datta frame the architecture of the whole system on this thesis: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend **logically** on their epistemology." Every later denial — of soul, God, *action and moral consequence* (*karma*), rebirth, heaven and liberation — is a consequence drawn from this one epistemic restriction, not a separate act of unbelief.

✅ The vocabulary must be precise:

Term	Meaning	Why the exam cares
Valid cognition (<i>pramā</i>)	Valid cognition; knowledge of reality	The thing to be explained
Means of valid knowledge (<i>pramāṇa</i>)	The <i>means</i> by which <i>valid cognition</i> (<i>pramā</i>) arises	The disputed list
Perception (<i>pratyakṣa</i>)	Perception	The only item Cārvāka admits
Inference (<i>anumāna</i>)	Inference	Rejected as uncertain
Verbal testimony (<i>śabda</i>)	Verbal testimony, including scripture	Rejected as derivative
Comparison (<i>upamāna</i>)	Comparison / analogy	Rejected with the rest

⚠️ **The condition Cārvāka imposes.** Chatterjee and Datta state it as a conditional test: "If inference is to be regarded as a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*), it must yield knowledge **about which we can have no doubt** and **which must be true to reality**." Note the strength of the demand. This is not "usually

reliable"; it is indubitability plus correspondence. Every subsequent Cārvāka argument is an application of this standard.

2. Two kinds of perception, and why the Cārvāka needs both

✓ Cārvāka accepts perception in both its classical forms, and the second is often forgotten by candidates:

PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa)

```
|
+--- BAHYA (external) : through the five external senses --
|   sight, hearing, touch, taste, smell                       |
|                                                                 | > both admitted
+--- ANTARA / MANASA (internal) : the mind's immediate        |
|   awareness of pleasure, pain, desire, and                  |
|   consciousness itself                                     -----
```

✓ This is not a decorative detail. Chatterjee and Datta present the strongest objection to Cārvāka materialism precisely through internal perception: "do we not have a kind of perception, called internal, which gives an immediate knowledge of our mental states? And do we not perceive in these consciousness which is nowhere to be perceived in the external material objects?" The objector's aim is to force the admission of an immaterial substrate.

✓ **The Cārvāka answer, and it is subtle.** "The Cārvākas admit that the existence of consciousness is proved by perception. But they deny that consciousness is the quality of any unperceived non-material or spiritual entity." Consciousness is *given*; a soul is *not* given. What internal perception delivers is a state of the living body, not evidence of a separate substance.

⚠ **Exam-critical inference.** Cārvāka is therefore **not** a denier of consciousness. It is a denier of the *inference* from consciousness to an immaterial bearer of consciousness. A script that writes "Cārvāka denies consciousness" has confused materialism with eliminativism and has thrown away the 2024 twenty-marker.

3. Certainty versus practical belief — the distinction that saves the position

⚠ The most common failure in this topic is to write that "Cārvāka says nobody ever infers anything." That is not the doctrine, and the texts themselves block it.

✓ Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's own concession: "It is true that in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference. But that only shows that we act **uncritically** on the wrong belief that our inference is true. It is a fact that sometimes our inference comes true and leads to successful results. But it is also a fact that sometimes inference leads to error as well. **Truth is not then an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a separable one**, that we find only in some inferences."

⚠ **Unpack that last sentence, because it is the philosophical hinge of the whole topic.**

For inference to be a MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE (pramāṇa), truth would have to be an

ESSENTIAL and INSEPARABLE character of the inferential process.

But truth attaches to SOME inferences and not to others.

=> truth is ACCIDENTAL (agantuka) to inference, and SEPARABLE from it.

=> inference is not a truth-GUARANTEERING instrument.

...and yet people go on inferring, and often succeed.

The Carvaka does not deny THAT. He denies that success confers PRAMANA-STATUS.

✓ The authored knowledge file records the same distinction under the heading *lokasiddha* or *laukika* inference: practical, corrigible, worldly inference tied to future perceptual confirmation is tolerated; **transcendental** inference — from ritual to unseen merit, from world to God, from body to soul — is the real target, because nothing could ever check it perceptually.

Axis	Everyday (<i>laukika</i> / <i>vyāvahārika</i>) inference	Transcendental (<i>alaukika</i> / <i>pāramārthika</i>) inference
Example	Smoke on a hill, so probably fire; dark clouds, so probably rain	Ritual now, so heaven later; world exists, so God made it
Corrigibility	✓ Can be checked by later perception	⚠ In principle uncheckable
Cārvāka attitude	⚠ Tolerated as practical habit; denied <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i> -status	✓ Rejected outright
What the exam wants	The distinction stated in one sentence	The target of the critique identified correctly

4. Why *verbal testimony (śabda)* falls — the argument in five steps

✓ Chatterjee and Datta give a compact and precise argument, worth reproducing as numbered steps:

1. Testimony consists of **words (śabda)**. Insofar as words are heard through our ears, they are **perceived** — and knowledge of words is therefore perceptual and quite valid.
2. But insofar as those words *suggest or mean* things not within our perception, and aim at giving knowledge of unperceived objects, "they are not free from error and doubt."
3. Reliance on an authority always proceeds through a suppressed inference. The believer's mind runs: "This authority should be accepted because it is reliable, and all reliable authority should be accepted."
4. That is an inference. "Being based on inference, knowledge derived from verbal testimony or authority is **as precarious as inference**."
5. Therefore testimony is not an *independent* source of knowledge.

✓ **The special case of the Veda.** Chatterjee and Datta report the Cārvāka verdict without softening: "The authority of the Vedas ... is held in high esteem by many. But in reality the Vedas are the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous. With false hopes and

promises the Vedas persuade men to perform Vedic rites, the only tangible benefit of which goes to the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

⚠️ Two distinctions to keep clean.

- (1) WORDS AS SOUNDS : perceived, and therefore fine.
 WORDS AS EVIDENCE : not perceived, and therefore suspect.
- (2) REJECTING TESTIMONY $\neq$ REJECTING COMMUNICATION.
 Language can guide action; it cannot CERTIFY what it reports
 until perception catches up with it.

✓ Sharma adds the reinforcing point that testimony cannot be used to rescue inference either: "if testimony proves *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*), inference would become dependent on testimony, and then **none would be able to infer anything by himself**." That *reductio* is worth a line in any answer on the rejection of inference.

5. Why *comparison* (*upamāna*), *postulation* (*arthāpatti*) and *non-cognition* (*anupalabdhi*) fall too

⚠️ Cārvāka's argument is a single template applied repeatedly, and stating the template is more impressive than listing the *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇas*).

Means of valid knowledge (<i>pramāṇa</i>)	Its claim	The Cārvāka template applied
Comparison (<i>upamāna</i>) (Nyāya)	From "the <i>gavaya</i> resembles the cow" plus later sight of the animal, one knows the word's referent	⚠️ The similarity is perceived; the <i>linkage of name to kind</i> is a generalisation reaching beyond what is perceived, hence inferential and insecure
Postulation (<i>arthāpatti</i>) (Mīmāṃsā)	Devadatta is fat, yet does not eat by day; therefore he eats by night	⚠️ A postulation to remove an inconsistency — but the postulated fact is unperceived, and the necessity of the postulation is itself a generalisation
Non-cognition (<i>anupalabdhi</i>) (Bhāṭṭa, Advaita)	Non-apprehension of the jar yields knowledge of its absence	⚠️ Requires the rule "if it existed here it would have been perceived", which is a universal not given in any single perception

⚠️ **The template in one line, for the answer script:** *every candidate means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) other than perception depends on a universal proposition, and no universal proposition is perceived.* That single sentence disposes of the whole list and shows the examiner you understand the structure rather than the catalogue.

6. What the position buys, and what it costs

	Strength ✓	Cost ⚠️
Epistemic	An austere, honest criterion; no unfalsifiable postulates	Knowledge shrinks to the present-and-perceived; science and history become impossible as <i>knowledge</i>

	Strength ✓	Cost ⚠
Ontological	No inflated metaphysics; explanatory economy	Cannot account for micro-entities, other minds or the past
Religious	Immunity to priestly manipulation and unverifiable promises	Loses any account of moral order beyond prudence
Dialectical	Forces every rival to justify each additional <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i>	Invites the self-refutation charge (Subtopic 3)

Exam link

Route this foundation into 2019 Q5(c), 2021 Q5(e) and 2025 Q5(a): define *pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*, distinguish certainty from practical expectation, and derive the rejection of testimony and transcendence.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

- ⚠ Do not write "Cārvāka accepts only perception **and** ordinary experience" as if these were two things. Ordinary experience is admitted *as* perception.
- ✓ Do not forget internal perception. Its admission is what makes Cārvāka a materialist about consciousness rather than a denier of consciousness.
- ⚠ Do not say Cārvāka rejects language or communication. It rejects testimony's claim to *independent pramāṇa-status*.
- ⚠ Do not list the rejected *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)* without giving the single template that rejects them all: each rests on an unperceived universal.
- ⚠ Do not attribute the *vyāvahārika / pāramārthika* level-distinction to Cārvāka as a historical doctrine. Sharma's point is precisely that Cārvāka lacks it; offering it is a philosophical *repair*, and it must be labelled as such.
- ⚠ Do not confuse the Cārvāka's demand ("no doubt whatever, and true to reality") with modern fallibilist standards. The strength of the demand is what drives the entire critique.
- ⚠ Do not say the Vedas are rejected "because they are old" or "because they are religious". They are rejected because their authority cannot be perceptually certified and their content promises the unperceivable.

Revision notes

- ✓ *Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*: perception alone is a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*; everything else in the system follows logically from this.
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology."
- ✓ The Cārvāka's test for *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*-hood: knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".
- ✓ Both **external** and **internal** perception are admitted; consciousness is perceived, an immaterial soul is not.
- ✓ Cārvāka denies the *inference* from consciousness to a soul, not consciousness itself.
- ✓ "Truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a **separable** one."

- ⚠️ Distinguish *laukika* (corrigible, practical) from *pāramārthika* (uncheckable, transcendental) inference; the second is the real target.
- ✅ Verbal testimony (*śabda*) in five steps: words heard are perceived → what they *mean* is unperceived → acceptance runs through a reliability inference → inference is precarious → testimony is not independent.
- ✅ Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*), "none would be able to infer anything by himself".
- ✅ The Veda is rejected as the work of "cunning priests" whose promises benefit only the officiants — an epistemic charge with a sociological edge.
- ⚠️ The single template that kills *comparison* (*upamāna*), *postulation* (*arthāpatti*) and *non-cognition* (*anupalabdhi*): each needs an unperceived universal.
- ⚠️ Sharma's charge: Cārvāka accepts perception and rejects inference **from the same standpoint**, lacking the *saṃvṛti/paramārtha* or *vyāvahārika/pāramārthika* distinction that saves Śūnyavāda and Advaita.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — EPISTEMOLOGY — PERCEPTION AS THE SOLE MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE (*pramāṇa*)

SUBTOPIC: EPISTEMOLOGY — PERCEPTION AS THE SOLE MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE (*pramāṇa*)

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: perception (*pratyakṣa*) · means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*) ·

perception-only doctrine (*pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*) · practical inference · verbal testimony (*śabda*) · certainty

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: *Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*: perception alone is a means of valid knowledge

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Chatterjee and Datta frame the architecture of the whole system on

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Chatterjee and Datta present the strongest objection to Cārvāka

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) epistemology treats perception

(*pratyakṣa*) as the only independent means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*), while accepting

inference only as fallible practical expectation rather than certain knowledge.

SESSION 3 — THE CRITIQUE OF INFERENCE — INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (*vyāpti*), HIDDEN LIMITING CONDITION (*upādhi*), THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM AND SELF-REFUTATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Cārvāka challenges inference by asking how a universal relation between reason and conclusion can be known from only finitely observed cases.

Technical definition: Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is decisive; against the softened formulation it loses its force but so does the doctrine, which becomes a fallibilist warning rather than a denial of a means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) critique argues that inference cannot establish certainty because invariable concomitance (vyāpti) cannot be universally known without circular inference and may always be defeated by an undiscovered hidden limiting condition (upādhi).

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **invariable concomitance (vyāpti)**
- **hidden limiting condition (upādhi)**
- **induction**
- **circularity**
- **Socrates syllogism**
- **self-refutation**

How to use them: Reconstruct the attack on invariable concomitance (vyāpti) through finite observation and hidden conditions, illustrate it with the Socrates syllogism, and finish with the self-refutation objection.

CORE DEFINITION: The Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) critique argues that inference cannot establish certainty because invariable concomitance (vyāpti) cannot be universally known without circular inference and may always be defeated by an undiscovered hidden limiting condition (upādhi).

Plain-language visual - why smoke may mislead

```
Observed many times: SMOKE -> FIRE
      |
      v
Hidden condition may exist: wet fuel / special cause
      |
      v
So "all smoke has fire" is not guaranteed merely by past cases
```

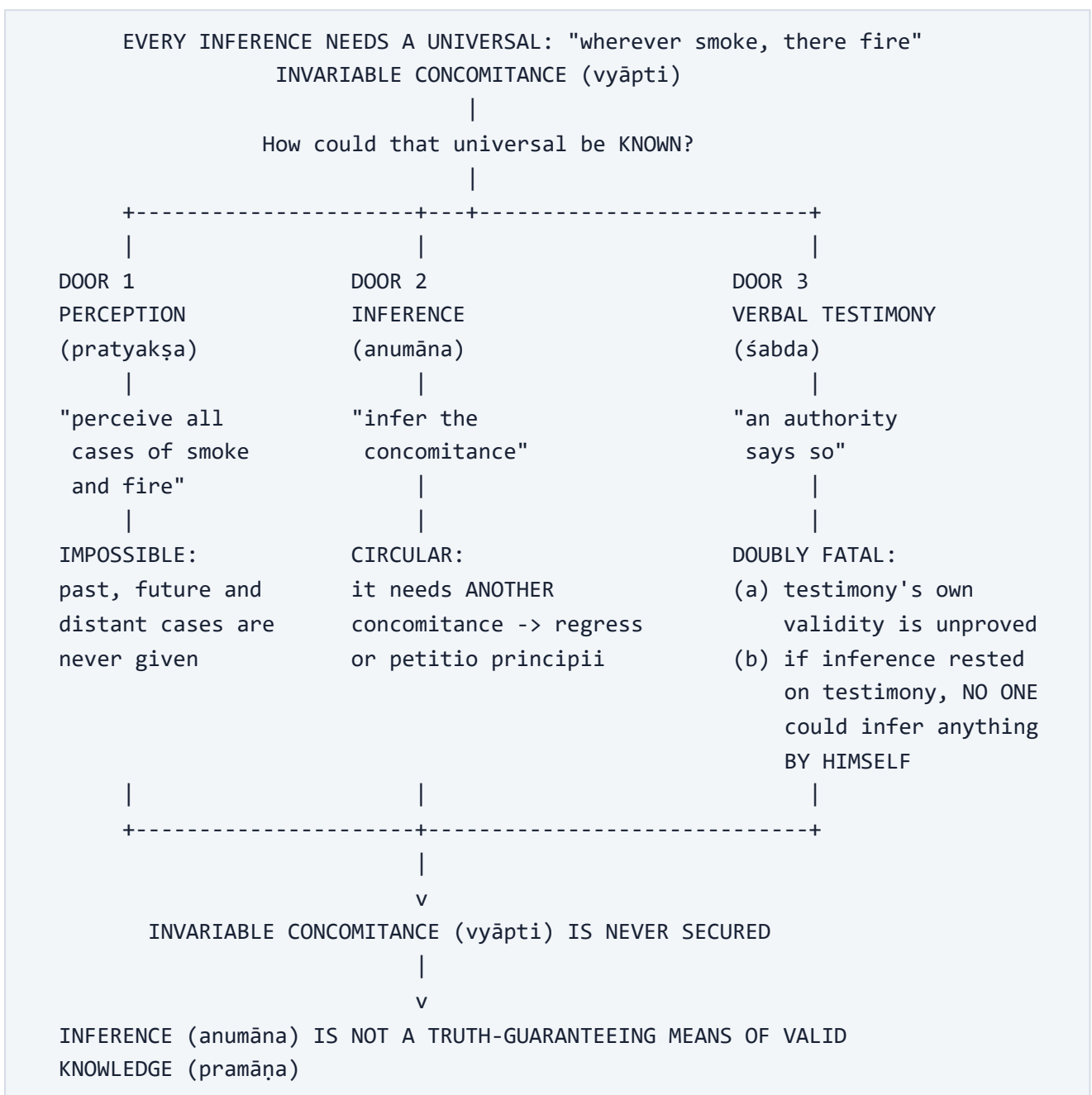
In simple words: inference needs a universal link called *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)*. Cārvāka asks how anyone can inspect every past, present, future and distant case. A hidden condition (*upādhi*) may explain why the relation held in observed cases but fail elsewhere.

Term	Easy meaning
<i>Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)</i>	Exceptionless relation used by inference
<i>Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)</i>	Hidden condition that limits an apparently universal rule

Term	Easy meaning
Induction	Moving from observed cases to a universal rule
Deduction	Applying that universal rule to a particular case

One-line memory: if induction cannot secure the universal premise, deduction cannot rescue the conclusion.

 VISUAL — The three-door trap: how *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* is cornered



 **Caption.** Draw this in the answer booklet. Three doors, all shut — that is the entire 2025 ten-marker, and the spine of the 2018, 2019 and 2022 questions. Notice that Door 3 is shut *twice*, and the second bolt (Sharma's "none would be able to infer anything by himself") is the one most candidates miss.

1. The doctrine, stated exactly

✓ **Thesis.** *Inference (anumāna)* is not a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*, because inference is "a mere leap in the dark" (Sharma): we proceed from the known to the unknown, and there is no certainty in this, "though some inferences may turn out to be **accidentally** true."

✓ **The structural point.** Inference is a movement from a perceived mark (*liṅga*, e.g. smoke) to an unperceived *sādhya* (e.g. fire), licensed by an invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) between them. Chatterjee and Datta present the Naiyāyika's own fuller statement of the inference — "all cases of smoke are cases of fire; this mountain is a case of smoke; therefore this is a case of fire" — and then locate the Cārvāka attack precisely: the argument "would be acceptable only if the **major premise**, stating the invariable relation between the middle term and the major, were beyond doubt."

⚠ **The move to memorise.** The Cārvāka never attacks the *form* of the inference. He grants that if the major premise were secure the conclusion would follow. He attacks the **licence** — the universal proposition that makes the movement legitimate. This is why the correct one-line statement of the doctrine is: *the Cārvāka critique of inference is a critique of the grounding of invariable concomitance (vyāpti), not of syllogistic validity.*

2. Door 1 — *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* cannot be established by perception

✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "this invariable relation (*vyāpti*) can be established only if we have a knowledge of **all** cases of smoke and presence of fire. This, however, is not possible, as we cannot perceive even all the cases of smoke and fire existing **now** in different parts of the world, to speak nothing of those which existed in the **past** or will exist in the **future**."

OBSERVED SET

[kitchen fire]

[hill fire]

[hearth fire]

[...n cases]

finite, present,

local, contingent

|

+--> the gap here is not a gap of DEGREE. It is a gap of KIND.

UNIVERSAL CLAIMED

ALL smoke, everywhere,

at every time, past,

present and future

infinite, temporally

unbounded, exceptionless

✓ **The class-character (*sāmānya*) rejoinder, and the Cārvāka's answer.** This is the sharpest exchange in the topic and almost no candidate reproduces it. The Naiyāyika-style objector says: granted we cannot perceive all individual smokes, but can we not perceive the **class-characters** "smokeness" (*dhūmatva*) and "fireness" (*vahnitva*), and perceive a relation *between the universals*, and thereby license the inference?

✓ Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's two-part reply verbatim in substance:

1. Even granting perception of a relation between smokeness and fireness, "we cannot know therefrom any invariable relation between **all individual cases** of smoke and fire. To be able to infer a **particular** fire, we must know that it is inseparably related to the **particular** smoke perceived."

2. Worse, "it is not possible even to **know by perception** what 'smokeness' ... is, because we do not perceive all cases of smoke."

⚠️ **What this exchange really shows.** The Cārvāka refuses to let the Naiyāyika escape the particular–universal gap by relocating it in the universals: the same finitude that blocks the enumeration of instances blocks the perceptual grasp of the class-character. Chatterjee and Datta conclude for him: "the difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal, therefore, remains here as before."

3. Door 2 — *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* cannot be established by inference

✅ Chatterjee and Datta: "Neither can it be said to be based on another inference, because it will involve a **petitio principii**, since the validity of that inference again has to be similarly proved."

✅ Sharma sharpens the same point into a pair:

DEDUCTION : "All men are mortal; Socrates is a man; so Socrates is mortal."
The conclusion is ALREADY CONTAINED in the major premise.
=> petitio principii, an argument in a circle.

INDUCTION : offered to establish the major premise.
But induction "proceeds unwarrantedly from the known to the unknown."
=> the major premise is never secured.

RESULT : "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle.
The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference." (Sharma, quoting the Carvaka gibe)

⚠️ **Why this is not merely a dilemma but a trap.** Each horn is repaired only by the other. Deduction's circularity is cured by grounding the major premise inductively; induction's insecurity is cured by grounding it deductively. The Cārvāka's point is that the two cures are the same wound seen from two directions.

✅ Chatterjee and Datta add the causal variant, which candidates often think is a way out: "can we not base our knowledge of the invariable relation between smoke and fire on a **causal** relation between them?" The Cārvāka reply: "a causal relation, being only a kind of invariable relation, cannot be established by perception owing to the same difficulties."

4. Door 3 — *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* cannot be established by testimony

✅ Two independent bolts, and both should appear in a 15-marker:

1. ✅ "Nor can this *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* be based on the testimony (*śabda*) of reliable persons ... For, the validity of testimony **itself requires to be proved by inference**" (Chatterjee and Datta). Grounding inference in testimony and testimony in inference is a closed circle.
2. ✅ "Besides, if inference always depended on testimony, **no one could infer anything by himself**" (Chatterjee and Datta; Sharma states the same reductio). Inference is manifestly a first-person cognitive capacity; making it parasitic on the word of another misdescribes what inference is.

5. The *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* problem — the deepest cut

✓ **Statement.** Even where two things are repeatedly observed together, an unnoticed condition (*upādhi*) may be doing the work; so observed constancy never establishes *unconditional* concomitance.

✓ **The textbook example, exactly as Chatterjee and Datta give it** — and note that it runs in the direction most candidates get backwards:

A man perceives fire accompanied by smoke, many times.
On another occasion he perceives FIRE and infers SMOKE.

^^^^ ^^^^^^

He is liable to ERROR.
Why? Because he failed to notice a CONDITION (*upādhi*):
WETNESS OF FUEL -- on the presence of which ALONE fire is
attended with smoke.

The relation "fire -> smoke" holds only ARDRENDHANA-SAMYOGA-SAHITE,
i.e. where fire is joined with wet fuel. A red-hot iron ball is
fire WITHOUT smoke.

✓ Chatterjee and Datta draw the general conclusion: "So long as the relation between two phenomena is not proved to be **unconditional**, it is an uncertain ground for inference. And unconditionality or **absence of conditions cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden and escape notice**. Inference or testimony cannot be used for proving this unconditionality without a *petitio principii*, because its validity also is being questioned here."

⚠ **Why the *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* argument is stronger than the enumeration argument.** The enumeration argument says: you have not checked enough cases. The *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* argument says: **even if you had checked every case you can check, you could not know that you had identified the right property as the ground of the relation**. The first is a problem of quantity; the second is a problem of the *identification of the relevant variable*. Nyāya can answer the first with more observation. It cannot answer the second with more observation alone — which is why it must bring in *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* (Subtopic 4).

7. The self-refutation charge (2018, 2019, 2022) — and the Cārvāka's replies

✓ **The charge, in its strongest form.** Sharma states it without mercy: "To refuse the validity of inference from the empirical standpoint is to refuse to think and discuss. All thoughts, all discussions, all doctrines, all affirmations and denials, all proofs and disproofs are made possible by inference. The Cārvāka view that perception is valid and inference is invalid **is itself a result of inference**. The Cārvāka can understand others only through inference and make others understand him only through inference. Thoughts and ideas, not being material objects, cannot be perceived; they can only be inferred. Hence the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy."

⚠ Reconstructed as numbered steps, because the examiner wants the logic and not the invective:

1. The Carvaka asserts: "No inference is a valid source of knowledge."
2. That assertion is UNIVERSAL. It quantifies over all inferential acts,

past, present and future.

3. No universal proposition is given in any single perception.
4. Therefore the thesis is either (a) itself inferential -- and so self-defeating -- or (b) not knowledge by its own standard.
5. Further: to REFUTE Nyaya, the Carvaka must reason. To be UNDERSTOOD, he must rely on his hearers inferring his meaning from his words.
6. Further still: other MINDS are never perceived. The Carvaka's very act of arguing with an opponent presupposes an inference to another mind.

⚠ **The Cārvāka's three available replies — a strong answer gives all three and grades them.**

Reply	Formulation	Assessment
R1 — The "no thesis" or <i>vitaṇḍā</i> reply	The Cārvāka advances no positive doctrine; he only <i>destroys</i> the opponent's claim to certainty, using the opponent's own standards. A purely destructive dialectic incurs no commitments.	⚠ Coherent, but it converts Cārvāka from a philosophy into a method — and Cārvāka <i>does</i> assert four elements, a body-self and <i>pleasure (kāma)</i> as the end, so it cannot be a global reply.
R2 — The softened-thesis reply	The thesis is not "no one ever infers" but "inference never yields apodictic certainty beyond what perception can check". As a claim about certainty rather than usability, it is not refuted by the fact that the Cārvāka reasons.	⚠ The strongest reply. It is the reading the authored knowledge file endorses, and it rescues consistency at the price of weakening the doctrine into radical fallibilism.
R3 — The level-distinction reply	Concede <i>vyāvahārika</i> validity to inference and deny only <i>pāramārthika</i> validity.	⚠ Effective against Sharma's "same standpoint" charge, but the level-distinction is, as Sharma says, "unknown to the Cārvāka" — so it is a repair offered by the interpreter, and must be labelled as such.

⚠ **The verdict to write.** *Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is decisive; against the softened formulation it loses its force but so does the doctrine, which becomes a fallibilist warning rather than a denial of a means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa). The Cārvāka can be consistent or radical, but not both.* That sentence answers 2019 Q5(c) almost by itself.

8. Sharma's counter-attack on perception — the tu quoque

✓ Sharma turns the Cārvāka's weapon around: "Perception itself which is regarded as valid by the Cārvāka is **often found untrue**. We perceive the earth as flat but it is almost round. We perceive the earth as static but it is moving round the sun. We perceive the disc of the sun as of a small size, but it is much bigger than the size of the earth. Such perceptual knowledge is **contradicted by inference**."

✓ And the constructive half, which is really a Kantian point made in an Indian idiom: "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless conception or thought has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data." Sharma cites the Buddhist *Tattvasaṅgraha* for this line of attack.

⚠ **Why this is devastating and must be handled, not avoided.** If perception is fallible *and* is corrected by inference, then the very hierarchy Cārvāka asserts is inverted: inference becomes the tribunal before which perception is judged. A 15- or 20-mark answer that reproduces the Cārvāka case without meeting

this rejoinder is one-sided.

⚠️ **Best Cārvāka response available:** the errors Sharma lists are corrected by **further perception plus practical checking**, not by pure inference — and a fallibilist Cārvāka can concede correction within perception while still denying that any *unperceivable* entity is established by it. That reply is decent for the flat-earth case and weak for the heliocentric case, and you should say so.

Exam link

Primary routes: 2019 Q5(c), 2019 Q6(c) and 2025 Q5(a). Reconstruct *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*) through the three-door argument, add *hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*), then face self-refutation.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

- ⚠️ Do not write that the Cārvāka says the syllogism is **invalid**. He says the major premise is ungrounded, and that deduction is therefore circular.
- ✅ Do not give the *hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*) example backwards. The standard case is inferring **smoke from fire**, which fails because the *hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*) of **wet fuel** was unnoticed.
- ⚠️ Do not omit the *sāmānya* / class-character exchange. It is the difference between a textbook answer and a top answer.
- ⚠️ Do not present the self-refutation charge without the Cārvāka's replies. A one-sided demolition scores poorly on "critically examine".
- ⚠️ Do not claim all inference is literally impossible for the Cārvāka. Distinguish *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*)-status from everyday expectation and practical action.
- ⚠️ Do not forget Door 3's second bolt: if inference rested on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself.
- ⚠️ Do not ignore Sharma's *tu quoque* about perceptual error. Meeting it is what "critically evaluate" means.
- ⚠️ Do not treat the causal-relation escape as untouched. A causal relation is itself a species of invariable relation and inherits the same problem.

Revision notes

- ✅ Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".
- ✅ The attack is on the **major premise** (*vyāpti*), never on syllogistic form.
- ✅ **Door 1 (perception):** all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.
- ✅ **Class-character reply:** even *dhūmatva* and *vahnitva* cannot be perceptually known, since all instances are not perceived; and universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference.
- ✅ **Door 2 (inference):** *petitio principii* or infinite regress; deduction is circular, induction unwarranted.
- ✅ Causal relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.
- ✅ **Door 3 (testimony):** testimony's validity is itself inferred; and "if inference always depended on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself."

-  **Hidden limiting condition (upādhi):** the wet-fuel condition; unconditionality can never be perceptually certified because conditions may remain hidden.
-  *Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* is a problem of the *right variable*, not merely of *sample size* — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it.
-  **Self-refutation:** the universal denial of inference is itself a universal; and other minds, thoughts and ideas are never perceived.
-  **Three replies:** no-thesis (*vitaṇḍā*) · softened certainty-thesis · level-distinction. The second is strongest; the third is a repair, not a historical doctrine.
-  **Sharma's *tu quoque*:** flat earth, static earth, small sun — perception errs and is corrected *by inference*.
-  **Verdict formula:** the Cārvāka may be consistent or radical, but not both.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — THE CRITIQUE OF INFERENCE — INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (vyāpti), HIDDEN LIMITING CONDITION (upādhi), THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM AND SELF-REFUTATION

SUBTOPIC: THE CRITIQUE OF INFERENCE — INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (vyāpti), HIDDEN LIMITING

CONDITION (upādhi), THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM AND SELF-REFUTATION

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: invariable concomitance (vyāpti) · hidden limiting condition (upādhi) ·

induction · circularity · Socrates syllogism · self-refutation

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: This is why the correct one-line statement of the doctrine is: the

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) critique argues that

inference cannot establish certainty because invariable concomitance (vyāpti) cannot be

universally known without circular inference and may always be defeated by an undiscovered

hidden limiting condition (upādhi).

SESSION 4 — THE NYĀYA DEFENCE OF INFERENCE — AND A CRITICALLY BALANCED VERDICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Answer all three limbs: rejection by other schools, their reasons, and a criterion-named verdict on whether they are justified.

Technical definition: The question says "the other systems" — plural — and asks for your own verdict as a third limb.  Do not present Advaita as agreeing with Cārvāka about inference.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Answer all three limbs: rejection by other schools, their reasons, and a criterion-named verdict on whether they are justified.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **repeated observation (bhūyodarśana)**
- **agreement in presence (anvaya)**
- **agreement in absence (vyatireka)**
- **hypothetical reasoning (tarka)**
- **counterexample**
- **defeasible warrant**

How to use them: Present Nyāya's combined method of positive and negative instances, removal of defeating conditions and hypothetical reasoning (tarka), then evaluate whether it yields certainty or only rational defeasibility.

EXAM-READY LINE: Nyāya (school of logic and realism) replies that repeated observation, agreement and difference, hypothetical reasoning (tarka) and the elimination of hidden limiting condition (upādhi) (hidden limiting conditions) justify defeasible but rationally warranted inference.

Plain-language visual - Nyaya's repair workshop

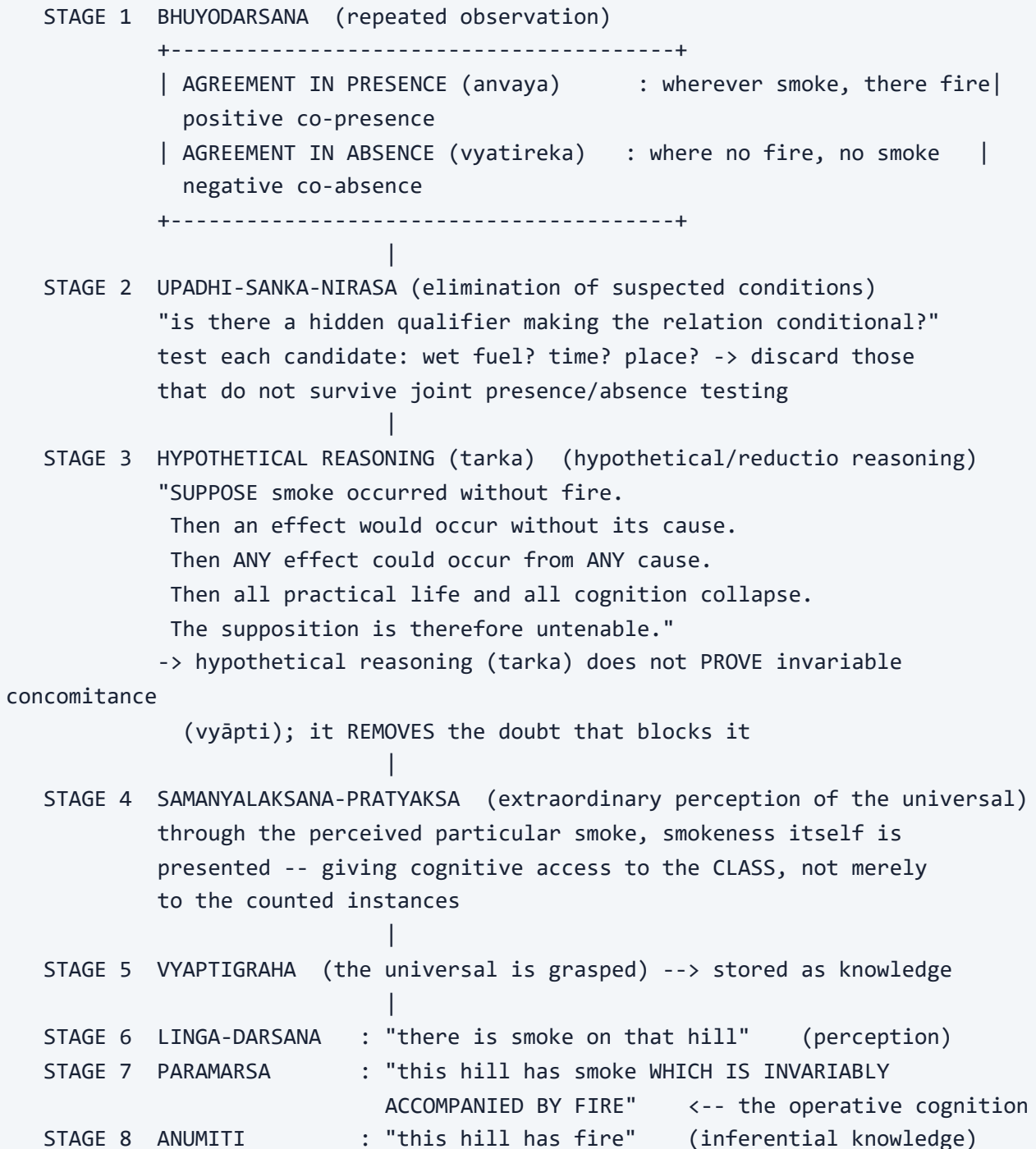
Repeated agreement: where smoke, there fire	(anvaya)
Repeated absence: where no fire, no smoke	(vyatireka)
Search for hidden conditions	(upadhi test)
Reject absurd alternatives	(tarka)
Apply the tested rule to this hill	(paramarsa)

In simple words: Nyāya does not claim that one casual observation proves a universal rule. It builds confidence through positive cases, negative cases, elimination of hidden conditions and rational testing. The final inference occurs when the tested universal relation is applied to the present case.

Cārvāka challenge	Nyāya reply
You have not seen every case	Universal features and systematic observation matter
A hidden condition may exist	Actively search for and eliminate <i>upādhis</i>
Inference is circular	<i>Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)</i> and repeated agreement/disagreement support <i>invariable concomitance (vyāpti)</i>

One-line memory: Nyāya answers "blind generalisation" with a disciplined method of testing.

 VISUAL — How Nyāya actually builds a *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)*, step by step



 **Caption.** The Cārvāka argues as if *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* had to be acquired in one impossible act of total enumeration. Nyāya's reply is architectural: *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* is **assembled** through five distinguishable operations, and the burden of certainty is distributed across them. Reproducing this eight-stage ladder is the single most effective way to show an examiner that you understand what Cārvāka is actually up against.

1. Why Nyāya cannot simply concede

⚠️ Nyāya is the school of *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*-theory. If inference falls, then *comparison (upamāna)* falls with it, *verbal testimony (śabda)* loses its warrant, the proofs of God (*kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt/śruteḥ*) collapse, the atomic theory becomes unstateable, and the Nyāya proofs of the self go with them. The Cārvāka attack is therefore not a peripheral irritant but an existential threat, which is why the Naiyāyika reply is so highly developed.

2. Agreement in presence (anvaya) and agreement in absence (vyatireka) — the joint method

✅ **The doctrine.** *Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* is established by **bhūyodarśana**, repeated observation, but of a particular disciplined kind:

Method	Sanskrit	Form	Function
Method of agreement	agreement in presence (anvaya)	Wherever <i>hetu</i> , there <i>sādhya</i>	Establishes positive co-presence across varied cases
Method of difference	agreement in absence (vyatireka)	Wherever <i>sādhya</i> is absent, <i>hetu</i> is absent	Rules out cases where the mark occurs without the probandum
Joint method	anvaya-vyatireka	Both together	The absence of a single counter-instance across wide, varied observation

⚠️ **The philosophical point to make explicit.** The Cārvāka treats repeated observation as mere counting. Nyāya treats it as **structured testing**: it is not the number of positive cases that matters but the survival of the relation through deliberate search for **negative** cases. A relation that survives systematic attempts to find *hetu*-without-*sādhya* has a warrant that a mere tally does not.

3. Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)-elimination — meeting the Cārvāka's strongest weapon

✅ **The Nyāya procedure.** An *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* is defined technically as a condition that pervades the *sādhya* but does not pervade the *hetu*. To test a suspected relation, the Naiyāyika asks whether any such condition can be found; where one is found, the *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* is reformulated to include it.

```
BAD INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (vyāpti) : "wherever fire, there smoke"
HIDDEN LIMITING CONDITION (upādhi) FOUND: wet fuel (ardra-indhana)
REPAIR      : "wherever fire joined with wet fuel, there smoke"
RESULT      : the conditional relation is not abandoned -- it is
              RESTATED at the correct level of generality.
```

⚠️ **The concession Nyāya must make, and an honest answer states it.** Nyāya can eliminate *suspected* and *known upādhis*. It cannot demonstrate that **no hidden limiting condition (upādhi)** whatever remains undetected. What it claims instead is that a relation which survives systematic testing, negative-case search and *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* is **rationally warranted**, not that it is guaranteed by an omniscient survey.

⚠ **The move that decides the debate.** Nyāya shifts the standard from **impossible omniscience** to **disciplined rational warrant**. The Cārvāka has set a bar — indubitability plus correspondence — that nothing except present perception could clear, and even present perception clears it only if perceptual error is ignored. Nyāya's reply is that this bar is not a criterion of knowledge but a recipe for its abolition.

4. *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* — the argument the Cārvāka has no answer to

✅ **What *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* is.** *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* is hypothetical reasoning, *reductio ad absurdum*: it assumes the contradictory of the proposed relation and exhibits the unacceptable consequence. It is expressly **not** an independent *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* in Nyāya; it is a *pramāṇa-anugrāhaka* — an auxiliary that removes doubt so that *vyāptigraha* can occur.

```
SUPPOSE : smoke without fire
THEN    : an effect exists without its cause
THEN    : the causal order is arbitrary
THEN    : no expectation, no action, no discourse, no refutation
BUT     : the Carvaka HIMSELF acts, expects, argues and refutes
THEREFORE: the supposition is untenable (anista-prasanga)
```

⚠ **Why this is so powerful against Cārvāka specifically.** The Cārvāka concedes that people act on inference and that action often succeeds. *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* converts that concession into a premise: the intelligibility of the Cārvāka's own practice — including the practice of arguing against Nyāya — presupposes the very regularities he refuses to certify. The Cārvāka can escape only by retreating to the softened thesis (Subtopic 3, reply R2), at which point the dispute becomes verbal rather than doctrinal.

5. *Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* — Nyāya's direct answer to the class-character objection

✅ **The doctrine.** Nyāya admits an extraordinary (*alaukika*) perception in which, through a perceived particular, the **universal** itself is presented — smokeness through this smoke. The authored Nyāya file records the trap explicitly: it is an error to say that universals are not perceived in Nyāya; they are, through *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*.

⚠ **The exchange, laid out for the answer script:**

Move	Claim
Cārvāka	✅ You cannot perceive all smokes; therefore you cannot perceive smokeness; therefore you have no universal
Nyāya	✅ The universal is not reached by adding up particulars; it is presented in any particular through extraordinary perception
Cārvāka rejoinder	⚠ <i>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i> is a technical device invented precisely to plug the hole; it is theory-laden, not independently attested
Assessment	⚠ Honest verdict: the device does real work inside Nyāya's realism about universals, but it will not convince anyone who does not already accept that realism. The debate here bottoms out in ontology, not in epistemology

6. *Parāmarśa* — what actually generates the inferential cognition

✓ **The doctrine.** In Nyāya, inferential knowledge (*anumiti*) is produced by a specific operative cognition (*karṇa*) called **parāmarśa**: the cognition of the mark *as qualified by* its invariable concomitance — "this hill possesses smoke, which is invariably accompanied by fire."

⚠ **Why this matters against Cārvāka.** The Cārvāka pictures inference as a **leap** across a gap: from perceived smoke, jump to unperceived fire. Nyāya's analysis denies that there is any leap at all. What produces the conclusion is a single complex cognition in which the mark is *already* apprehended under the concomitance. There is no moment at which the mind is stranded between premises with a chasm to cross.

⚠ **A memorable line for the answer:** *For Cārvāka, inference is a jump in the dark; for Nyāya, it is a step taken in the light of a concomitance already grasped.*

7. The Nyāya counter-attack on perception

✓ Sharma reports this as the decisive counter-move, and it was set out in Subtopic 3 §8: perception itself errs — the flat earth, the static earth, the small solar disc — "such perceptual knowledge is contradicted by **inference**." And, following the *Tattvasaṅgraha*, "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless **conception or thought** has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data."

⚠ **The structural result, and it is a genuine reversal:**

CARVAKA'S PICTURE	NYAYA'S CORRECTED PICTURE
-----	-----
perception = certain	perception = fallible, and CORRECTED by inference
inference = derivative	inference = the tribunal that corrects perception
hierarchy: P > I	hierarchy: neither is self-sufficient; perception supplies content, inference supplies order and correction

⚠ **Note the Nyāya distinction that keeps this honest:** Nyāya distinguishes **nirvikalpaka** (indeterminate, pre-predicative) from **savikalpaka** (determinate, qualified) perception. Only determinate perception is judgemental — and determinate perception already involves conceptual qualification. The Cārvāka's "pure given" is therefore, on the Nyāya analysis, either pre-cognitive and useless, or already conceptually shaped and therefore not the innocent bedrock he supposes.

Exam link

Primary route: 2018 Q8(b); cross-link 2022 Q7(c). Answer all three limbs: rejection by other schools, their reasons, and a criterion-named verdict on whether they are justified.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

1. ⚠️ Do not say Nyāya "proves" *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* with certainty. It claims disciplined warrant and eliminates *suspected* conditions.
2. ⚠️ Do not call *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*. It is *pramāṇa-anugrahaka*, an auxiliary that removes doubt.
3. ✅ Do not write that Nyāya denies the perception of universals. It affirms it through *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*.
4. ⚠️ Do not omit *parāmarśa*. Without it, you cannot explain why Nyāya denies that inference is a "leap" at all.
5. ⚠️ Do not answer 2018 Q8(b) with only one school. The question says "the other systems" — plural — and asks for your own verdict as a third limb.
6. ⚠️ Do not present Advaita as agreeing with Cārvāka about inference. Advaita's denial is at the *pāramārthika* level and applies to perception equally.
7. ⚠️ Do not forget Nyāya's *nirvikalpaka* / *savikalpaka* distinction when replying to the "pure given" assumption.

Revision notes

- ✅ *Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* is built by **bhūyodarśana**, disciplined as **agreement in presence (anvaya)** (co-presence) and **agreement in absence (vyatireka)** (co-absence).
- ✅ **Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)**-elimination repairs a defective universal by restating it at the correct level of generality — "fire **with wet fuel**, there smoke".
- ✅ **Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)** is hypothetical *reductio* reasoning; it is not a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* but removes the doubt blocking *vyāptigraha*.
- ✅ *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)*'s force against Cārvāka: his own acting, expecting and arguing presuppose the regularities he refuses to certify.
- ✅ **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa** answers the class-character objection by presenting the universal through the particular.
- ✅ **Parāmarśa** — the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance — is the *karaṇa of anumiti*; hence no "leap".
- ✅ The eight-stage ladder: *bhūyodarśana* → *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)*-elimination → *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* → *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* → *vyāptigraha* → *liṅga-darśana* → *parāmarśa* → *anumiti*.
- ✅ Sharma's counter-attack: perception errs (flat earth, static earth, small sun) and is corrected **by inference**.
- ✅ *Tattvasaṅgraha* point: mere sensation is not knowledge until conception orders "the loose threads of sense-data".
- ⚠️ Nyāya's decisive move: replace **omniscient certainty** with **disciplined warrant** as the standard for *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*-hood.
- ⚠️ Honest residue: *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* proves nothing alone; *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* presupposes realism about universals; undetected *upādhis* cannot be excluded in principle.
- ⚠️ 2018 Q8(b) has **three** limbs — is it accepted, why not, and are the objectors justified. Answer all three.
- ⚠️ Verdict formula: Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as warranted, not as indubitable.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — THE NYĀYA DEFENCE OF INFERENCE — AND A CRITICALLY BALANCED VERDICT

SUBTOPIC: THE NYĀYA DEFENCE OF INFERENCE — AND A CRITICALLY BALANCED VERDICT

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: repeated observation (bhūyodarśana) • agreement in presence (anvaya) •

agreement in absence (vyatireka) • hypothetical reasoning (tarka) • counterexample •

defeasible warrant

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Nyāya's reply is architectural: invariable concomitance (vyāpti) is

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The question says "the other systems" – plural – and asks for your own

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Invariable concomitance (vyāpti) is established by bhūyodarśana,

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Answer all three limbs: rejection by other schools, their reasons,
and a criterion-named verdict on whether they are justified.

SESSION 5 — METAPHYSICS AND MATERIALISM — FOUR BHŪTAS, THE REJECTION OF ĀKĀŚA, AND EXPLANATION THROUGH NATURAL PROPERTIES (svabhāvavāda)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The elemental ledger is therefore the neatest possible demonstration that Cārvāka metaphysics is epistemology applied.

Technical definition: Cārvāka materialism recognises earth, water, fire and air, rejects inferred ether, and explains bodies and consciousness through material combination and natural properties.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) materialism holds that perceptible bhūtas (material elements) combine according to svabhāva (inherent nature) to produce the world, without requiring ākāśa (ether), a creator, or a supersensible cause.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **four material elements (bhūtas)**
- **ether (ākāśa)**
- **natural properties (svabhāva)**
- **material combination**
- **emergence**
- **fermentation analogy**

How to use them: Derive the four-element ontology from perceptualism, explain emergent consciousness through the fermentation analogy, and note that emergence is asserted more clearly than mechanistically explained.

CORE DEFINITION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) materialism holds that perceptible bhūtas (material elements) combine according to svabhāva (inherent nature) to produce the world, without requiring ākāśa (ether), a creator, or a supersensible cause.

Plain-language visual - matter first

```

EARTH + WATER + FIRE + AIR
      |
    organised combinations
      |
body + senses + mind-like functions
      |
consciousness emerges
  
```

AKASA is excluded because it is not directly perceived.

In simple words: Cārvāka accepts four perceptible elements and explains bodies and consciousness through their combinations. Consciousness need not exist separately before matter, just as an intoxicating power appears when ingredients ferment together.

Claim	Simple analogy
Consciousness emerges from matter	Red colour appears when betel ingredients combine
No separate soul-substance is needed	The living body itself is conscious
No creator is needed	Natural properties and combinations explain formation
No <i>ākāśa</i>	It is inferred from sound rather than directly perceived

One-line memory: organised matter produces life and consciousness; do not add an unseen substance without evidence.

VISUAL — The elemental ledger, and the one cell that is empty

	PR̥THIVĪ (earth)	AP (water)	TEJAS (fire)	VĀYU (air)	ĀKĀŚA (ether / space)

NYĀYA-VAIŚEṢIKA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
plus time (kāla), direction (dik), self (ātman) and mind (manas)					
= nine substances (dravyas)					

SĀṂKHYA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y (from the tanmātras)
JAINISM	matter is pudgala; ether (ākāśa) is a separate substance				
MĪMĀṂSĀ / VEDĀNTA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y

CĀRVĀKA	Y	Y	Y	Y	-- NO -- ^^^^^^^^ the empty cell that carries the whole epistemology

⚠ **Caption.** One empty cell, and it is not an accident of cosmology. *Ākāśa* is refused for exactly the reason inference and testimony are refused: it is not perceived, it is **inferred**. The elemental ledger is therefore the neatest possible demonstration that Cārvāka metaphysics is epistemology applied. This visual answers the first half of the 2020 fifteen-marker on its own.

1. The bridging principle — ontology follows epistemology

✓ Chatterjee and Datta state the derivation in a single sentence: "The Cārvāka theory of reality **follows from** the epistemological conclusion just discussed. If perception is the only reliable source of knowledge, we can rationally assert only the reality of perceptible objects. God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

⚠ **The principle, formalised for the answer script:**

P1. Only perception is a means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).
(epistemology)
P2. Ontological commitment should not outrun the
reach of the means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) one accepts.
(bridging principle)

C. Only perceptible entities may be admitted as real. (ontology)

⚠ **P2 is doing enormous work and is rarely noticed by candidates.** It is not a truth of logic. An opponent could accept P1 and yet hold that reality exceeds knowledge — that there are unknowable realities. Cārvāka refuses that gap: for him, what cannot in principle be presented in perception has no claim to be admitted. Naming P2 explicitly, and observing that it is a *presupposition* rather than a proof, is exactly the kind of move that separates a 60% script from an 80% script.

2. The four *bhūta*

✓ **The transmitted *sūtra*:** *pṛthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — "earth, water, fire and air are the elements." And the second: *tatsamudāye śāñrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — "bodies, senses and objects" are the results of the different combinations of these elements.

✓ Chatterjee and Datta add the biological consequence explicitly: "Not only non-living material objects but also **living organisms**, like plants and animal bodies, are composed of these four elements, by the combination of which they are produced and to which they are **reduced on death**." There is no separate

vital principle and no separate psychic substance.

✓ Sharma adds the ontological refinement that many candidates miss: "**The elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution.**"

⚠ **This is a significant doctrinal point.** Cārvāka is not a philosophy of universal flux. The material elements are permanent; only configurations arise and perish. That gives Cārvāka a stable ontological substrate — and it is why the school is classified as a **realist** materialism rather than as a scepticism. It also sharpens the contrast with Buddhism (Subtopic 6) and with Jainism (Subtopic 8).

3. Why *ākāśa* is rejected — the 2020 question's first half

✓ **The argument, in four steps.**

1. Earth, water, fire and air are each **perceptible**: they present themselves through manifest sensible qualities — solidity, fluidity, heat and light, motion and touch.
2. *Ākāśa* is **not** perceived as an entity. Chatterjee and Datta: the Cārvākas "reject ether, because its existence cannot be perceived; **it has to be inferred.**" Sharma: "he rejects the fifth, the ether, because it is not perceived but inferred."
3. The inference in question is the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika one: sound (*śabda* as a quality) is a quality; every quality must inhere in a substance; sound is not a quality of earth, water, fire, air, *enduring self* (*ātman*), *sensory mind* (*manas*), time or space; therefore there is a ninth-listed substance, *ākāśa*, as its unique substrate.
4. Since inference is not a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*), that argument cannot establish anything. Hence the world is composed of **four** elements.

⚠ **The exchange in table form**, which is what a 15-marker needs:

Move	Position
Vaiśeṣika	✓ Sound is heard; qualities require substrates; by elimination the substrate is <i>ākāśa</i> , which is one, eternal, all-pervading and imperceptible
Cārvāka	✓ The hearing of sound is perceptual; the <i>substrate</i> is not. The move from quality to imperceptible substance is an inference and inherits the whole <i>invariable concomitance</i> (<i>vyāpti</i>) problem
Vaiśeṣika rejoinder	⚠ Then sound is left without a bearer, and the doctrine that qualities inhere in substances is broken
Cārvāka reply	⚠ Either sound is a state of the perceptible air-medium, or the demand for a bearer is itself a metaphysical prejudice; positing an imperceptible substrate is an unnecessary multiplication
Assessment	⚠ The Cārvāka is consistent, and the cost is real: he must either naturalise sound into the air or abandon the substance–quality framework that his own four-element realism assumes

⚠ **The self-critical point that earns the highest marks on this question.** The Cārvāka accepts the four elements as *substances*. But if he accepts the substance–quality scheme for earth, water, fire and air, he cannot simply refuse it for sound without argument. His most defensible line is therefore **not** "qualities

need no substrates" but "sound is a modification of perceptible air", which is a naturalising move rather than a sceptical one. Saying this shows you have thought past the textbook.

4. Consciousness from matter — *emergent consciousness from material elements (bhūta-caitanya-vāda*

✓ **The transmitted *sūtra*:** *kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — "consciousness [arises] from matter as the intoxicating power [arises] from fermenting agents."

✓ **The problem the doctrine answers.** Chatterjee and Datta pose the objection sharply: "we do not perceive consciousness in **any** of the four material elements. How can it then come to qualify their product, the body?"

✓ **The Cārvāka reply — the emergence thesis and its two canonical analogies.**

Analogy	The ingredients	The novel property	The point made
Betel (<i>tāmbūla</i>)	Betel leaf, lime and areca nut — "none of which is originally red"	A reddish tinge, "when chewed together"	A property may appear in a combination that is present in no ingredient separately
Fermentation	Molasses (<i>guḍa</i>), "originally non-intoxicant"	Intoxicating power, "when allowed to ferment"	The same substance under a different condition may develop qualities originally absent

✓ Chatterjee and Datta draw the conclusion: "In a similar way, it is possible to think that the material elements combined in a particular way give rise to the conscious living body. **Consciousness is an epiphenomenon or bye-product of matter**; there is no evidence of its existence independent of the body." Sharma reports the same doctrine and quotes the striking Western formulation used of it: "Matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."

⚠ **Read the two analogies carefully, because they are not the same argument.**

BETEL : combination of DIFFERENT ingredients -> new quality
(structural / compositional emergence)

FERMENTATION: the SAME ingredient under a NEW CONDITION -> new quality
(processual / transformational emergence)

Together they block two different objections:

(i) "consciousness is in none of the elements" -> betel answers it

(ii) "the elements are the same before and after" -> fermentation answers it

⚠ **The explanatory gap, stated honestly — and this is what distinguishes a philosophical answer from a report.** Both analogies establish that **novel observable qualities** can arise from combination. Consciousness, however, is not an observable third-person quality like redness or intoxicating power. It is the *condition of observation itself* — subjective, first-personal, and, as Sharma notes, **private** in a way redness is not: consciousness "is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard", and "consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others". The analogies therefore establish emergence of the wrong logical type.

⚠️ **The Cārvāka's best available reply**, which a fair answer must supply: positing an immaterial soul does not close the gap either — it **renames** it. To say "consciousness arises because there is a conscious substance" explains nothing that "consciousness arises from a specifically organised living body" does not; the dualist has bought a word, not an explanation. ⚠️ **Assessment:** the reply neutralises the dualist's claim to explanatory superiority without discharging the Cārvāka's own explanatory debt. Both sides face the gap; only one side pretends to have crossed it.

5. Why no God is needed — the pot-and-potter exchange and *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)*

✅ **The objection, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact form.** "Can the material elements by themselves give rise to this wonderful world? We find that even the production of an object like an earthen jar requires, in addition to **clay** which is its **material cause**, a **potter** who is the **efficient cause**, that shapes the material into the desired form. The four elements supply only the material cause of the world. Do we not require an efficient cause, like God, as the shaper and designer?"

✅ **The Cārvāka reply.** "The material elements themselves have got each its **fixed nature (svabhāva)**. It is by the natures and laws inherent in them that they combine together to form this world. There is thus no necessity for God. **There is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design.** They can be explained more reasonably as the fortuitous products of the elements."

✅ Chatterjee and Datta then supply the three technical labels, all of which should appear in a 10-marker on Cārvāka metaphysics:

Label	Sanskrit	Meaning	Textbook wording
Naturalism	<i>explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)</i>	The world is explained "only by nature"; things behave by their own inherent natures	✅ "Insofar as this Cārvāka theory tries to explain the world only by nature, it is sometimes called naturalism"
Mechanism / accidentalism	<i>yadr̥cchāvāda</i>	Denies conscious purpose behind the world; explains it as "a mere mechanical or fortuitous combination of elements"	✅ "It is also called mechanism (<i>yadr̥cchā-vāda</i>)"
Positivism	—	Believes "only in positive facts or observable phenomena"	✅ "The Cārvāka theory on the whole may also be called positivism "

⚠️ **Note carefully for the 2024 question:** the label "positivism" is not an examiner's invention or a modern imposition. It is applied to Cārvāka **by the standard textbook itself**, and with a stated reason. That is a decisive evidential point for Subtopic 9 and for the workbook's 2024 answer — although, as we shall see, the label still needs heavy qualification.

⚠️ **A refinement on *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* that strengthens any answer.** *Svabhāva* is invoked twice in Cārvāka, at two different points, and they must not be confused:

(1) EPISTEMOLOGICAL USE : "why is fire always hot and water cool?"
 -> because of their inherent natures; no supernatural principle is needed, AND "there is neither any guarantee that uniformity

perceived in the past would continue in future."
(Chatterjee & Datta)

(2) COSMOLOGICAL USE : "who arranged the world?"
-> nothing did; the elements combine by their own natures;
no designer is required.

⚠ Use (1) is a **deflationary** appeal: "nature" is a label for observed regularity, deliberately not an explanatory power, and the Cārvāka refuses to guarantee its persistence. Use (2) is a **substantive** appeal: nature is doing real cosmological work in place of God. The obvious objection — that "nature" is an empty word unless analysed — bites hard on use (2) and hardly at all on use (1). Separating them is the most sophisticated move available in this subtopic.

6. How many materialisms? Sadānanda's fourfold classification

✓ Sharma records, from Sadānanda's *Vedāntasāra*, that **four** different materialist schools were distinguished by their identification of the self:

Variant	The self is identified with	Sanskrit
1	The gross body	<i>sthūla śarīra</i>
2	The senses	<i>indriya</i>
3	The vital breaths	<i>prāṇa</i>
4	The mental organ	<i>sensory mind (manas)</i>

✓ Sharma adds: "All the schools agree in regarding the soul as a **product of matter**." He also records Śāntarākṣita's report that the materialist *Kambalāśvatara* held that consciousness arises out of the material body **associated with vital breaths**.

⚠ **Exam value.** This single table shows that "Cārvāka" names a **family** of materialist positions, not a monolith. It supports the source-caution of Subtopic 1, it forestalls the objection that the school was crude and undifferentiated, and it gives you a precise, citable internal differentiation almost no other candidate will have.

Exam link

Primary route: the first half of 2020 Q6(b). Derive four-element materialism and the rejection of *ākāśa* from the epistemic rule, then evaluate emergence without calling it modern science.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

- ✓ **Four elements, not five.** This is the single most examined factual trap in the topic.
- ✓ Do not say Cārvāka "does not know of" *ākāśa*. He knows the Vaiśeṣika argument for it and rejects it, precisely because it is inferential.
- ⚠ Do not say Cārvāka denies the reality of sound. He denies the inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate.

4. ⚠ Do not say the elements are impermanent. Sharma: "the elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution."
5. ⚠ Do not present the betel and fermentation analogies as one analogy. They answer two different objections — compositional and transformational emergence.
6. ⚠ Do not claim the analogies solve the problem of consciousness. State the explanatory gap **and** the Cārvāka's reply that dualism merely renames it.
7. ⚠ Do not translate *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* as "scientific naturalism". It is a metaphysical refusal of teleology, not an experimental programme.
8. ⚠ Do not forget *yadṛcchāvāda*. The denial of purpose is a distinct thesis from the affirmation of inherent natures, and the two sit together somewhat uneasily.
9. ⚠ Do not treat "Cārvāka" as one uniform doctrine. The *Vedāntasāra* records four materialist identifications of the self.

Revision notes

- ✓ **Bridging principle:** ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)*. Name it as a presupposition, not a proof.
- ✓ *prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — four elements; and *tatsamudāye śaīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.
- ✓ Living bodies too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.
- ✓ **The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish** (Sharma).
- ✓ *Ākāśa* is rejected "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika sound-to-substrate inference is refused.
- ✓ *kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.
- ✓ **Betel** = compositional emergence (leaf, lime, nut → red). **Fermentation** = transformational emergence (*guḍa* → intoxicant).
- ✓ Consciousness is an "epiphenomenon or bye-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."
- ⚠ **Explanatory gap:** redness and intoxication are third-person properties; consciousness is private and first-personal. The Cārvāka's best reply is that the soul-hypothesis renames the gap rather than closing it.
- ✓ **Pot-and-potter:** the objector needs an efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with *svabhāva* and denies that design is proved.
- ✓ Three labels from the textbook: **naturalism (svabhāvavāda)**, **mechanism (yadṛcchāvāda)**, and **positivism** ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").
- ⚠ Separate the **deflationary** use of *svabhāva* (regularity, with no guarantee of future uniformity) from the **substantive** cosmological use (nature in place of God).
- ✓ *Vedāntasāra*: four materialist schools identify the self with gross body, senses, vital breaths, or *sensory mind (manas)*.
- ⚠ Cārvāka's materialism is anti-inferential; modern materialism is thoroughly inferential. Same conclusion, opposite method.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — METAPHYSICS AND MATERIALISM — FOUR BHŪTAS, THE REJECTION OF ĀKĀŚA, AND EXPLANATION THROUGH NATURAL PROPERTIES (svabhāvavāda)

SUBTOPIC: METAPHYSICS AND MATERIALISM — FOUR BHŪTAS, THE REJECTION OF ĀKĀŚA, AND EXPLANATION

THROUGH NATURAL PROPERTIES (svabhāvavāda)

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: four material elements (bhūtas) · ether (ākāśa) · natural properties

(svabhāva) · material combination · emergence · fermentation analogy

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Cārvāka's best reply is that the soul-hypothesis renames the gap

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The elemental ledger is therefore the neatest possible demonstration

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: State the explanatory gap and the Cārvāka's reply that dualism merely

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) materialism holds that

perceptible bhūtas (material elements) combine according to svabhāva (inherent nature) to

produce the world, without requiring ākāśa (ether), a creator, or a supersensible cause.

SESSION 6 — SELF, BODY AND CONSCIOUSNESS — CONSCIOUS BODY AS SELF (dehātmavāda), AND CĀRVĀKA VERSUS BUDDHIST ANĀTMAN (2024, 20 MARKS)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda) (doctrine that the body is the self) explains consciousness as an emergent property of the living body, whereas Buddhist anātmā (no-permanent-self doctrine) analyses the person as a causal continuum without identifying self and body.

Technical definition: ✓ The transmitted formula: caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ — "the person is the body qualified by consciousness"; and, in Chatterjee and Datta's rendering of the Cārvāka position, "What people mean by a soul is nothing more than this conscious living body (caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā)".

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda) (doctrine that the body is the self) explains consciousness as an emergent property of the living body, whereas Buddhist anātmā (no-permanent-self doctrine) analyses the person as a causal continuum without identifying self and body.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)**
- **emergent consciousness**

- **body-property**
- **enduring self (ātman)**
- **Buddhist no-self (anātman)**
- **causal stream**

How to use them: Contrast Cārvāka's identity of self with the living conscious body against Buddhism's analysis of the person as a dependently arisen causal stream.

CORE DEFINITION: Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda) (doctrine that the body is the self) explains consciousness as an emergent property of the living body, whereas Buddhist anātman (no-permanent-self doctrine) analyses the person as a causal continuum without identifying self and body.

Plain-language visual - two different denials of a permanent soul

CARVAKA	BUDDHISM
living body = conscious self	changing five aggregates
continuity of body explains "I"	causal continuity explains "I"
no body-independent enduring self (ātman)	no permanent substance at all

In simple words: Cārvāka does not deny the everyday person; it identifies the person with the conscious living body. Buddhism also rejects a permanent *enduring self (ātman)*, but analyses the person as a changing causal stream rather than as one material body.

Test	Cārvāka answer
What is the self?	The body qualified by consciousness
Why say "I am strong"?	The first-person predicate applies directly to the body
What happens at death?	The organised body dissolves; consciousness ends
Main difficulty	Explaining memory, unity and personal identity fully

One-line memory: Cārvāka is body-self theory; Buddhism is no-substance process theory.

VISUAL — Three ways of denying the transcendental self (they are not the same denial)

THE QUESTION: what am I?

NYĀYA / VEDĀNTA (the target)

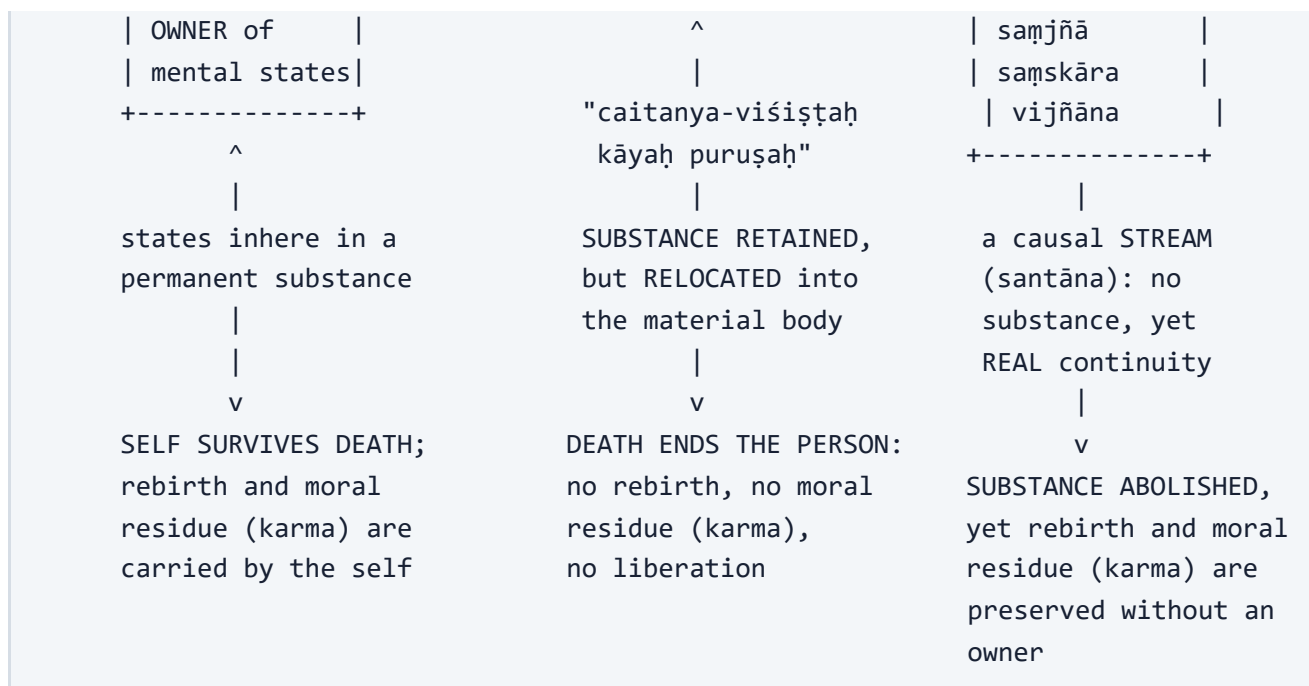
CĀRVĀKA

BUDDHISM

+-----+
 | ENDURING |
 | SELF (ātman) |
 | permanent |
 | substance, |

+-----+
 | LIVING BODY |
 | qualified by |
 | consciousness |
 +-----+

+-----+
 | NO OWNER |
 | five |
 | aggregates: |
 | rūpa vedanā |



⚠ **Caption.** This single diagram is the answer to the 2024 twenty-marker. Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into a process. One keeps a bearer and changes its nature; the other removes the bearer altogether. The moral and soteriological consequences then diverge completely: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral story at death, while Buddhism's denial is designed precisely to keep the moral story running without an owner.

1. *Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)* — the doctrine stated exactly

✅ **The transmitted formula:** *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ* — "the person is the body qualified by consciousness"; and, in Chatterjee and Datta's rendering of the Cārvāka position, "What people mean by a soul is nothing more than this **conscious living body** (*caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā*)."

⚠ **Read the formula carefully — every word is load-bearing:**

CAITANYA-VISISTA	: QUALIFIED BY CONSCIOUSNESS
	-> not any body; the LIVING body
KAYAH	: THE BODY
	-> the perceptible material organism
PURUSAH / ATMA	: IS the person / IS the self
	-> identity, not correlation

⚠ **Three misreadings to avoid**, each of which has sunk otherwise good answers:

1. It is **not** "the self is the corpse". The self is the *living, conscious* body; consciousness is the qualifier that makes a body a self.
2. It is **not** "there is no self". There is a self; it is material. Cārvāka is not an eliminativist about persons.
3. It is **not** "consciousness is identical with any one element". Consciousness belongs to the **organised** body-complex, as the emergence analogies establish.

2. The argument for *conscious body as self* (*dehātmavāda*)

✅ **Step 1 — the negative argument.** "The non-material soul is **never perceived**" (Chatterjee and Datta). What internal perception delivers is a state, not a substance behind the state.

✅ **Step 2 — the positive argument from ordinary first-person judgements.** This is the Cārvāka's most distinctive and most quotable move: "we have **direct evidence of the identity of the self with the body** in our daily experiences and judgments like, '**I am fat**,' '**I am lame**,' '**I am blind**.' If the 'I', the self, were different from the body, these would be **meaningless**."

⚠️ **The logic of the argument from first-person statements, reconstructed:**

1. In ordinary speech, bodily predicates are attached directly to "I":
I am fat; I am lame; I am blind; I am hungry; I am tall.
2. Predication of this kind is intelligible only if the SUBJECT and the BEARER of the predicate are the same thing.
3. If "I" named an immaterial soul, "I am fat" would be a CATEGORY MISTAKE -- as odd as "the number seven is blue".
4. But these statements are not category mistakes; they are the ordinary currency of self-description.
5. Therefore "I" refers to the body.

⚠️ **The dualist's standard reply, and the Cārvāka's rejoinder.** The dualist answers that such expressions are **figurative** — the soul speaks of *its* body as a person speaks of "my house". The Cārvāka's rejoinder is that the figurative reading is a **theory-driven reinterpretation** of language, adopted only to save a doctrine that has no independent perceptual support; and that "my body" and "I am lame" are not on a par, since no one says "my body is lame, therefore I am figuratively lame" in the natural course of speech.

⚠️ **Assessment:** the argument does not *prove* materialism, but it correctly shifts the burden onto the dualist to explain why ordinary self-ascription runs the way it does.

✅ **Step 3 — the argument from covariation.** The authored knowledge file records the standard supporting evidence: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness. Consciousness tracks the states of the body with a fidelity that would be inexplicable if it belonged to something else.

✅ **Step 4 — the consequence.** Chatterjee and Datta: "If the existence of a soul apart from the body is not proved, there is no possibility of proving its immortality. On the contrary, **death of the body means the end of the individual**. All questions about previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell, therefore, become **meaningless**."

⚠️ Note the word Chatterjee and Datta use twice: *meaningless*, not merely false. That is a quasi-verificationist register, and it is a genuine evidential asset for the 2024 "positivism" question — though it must be used carefully, since the Cārvāka has no explicit theory of meaning.

3. The objections — Sharma's full battery, and the Cārvāka's replies

⚠️ This is the richest objection-set in Indian philosophy, and reproducing four or five of these with replies is what turns a 12/20 into an 16/20. Sharma sets them out at length; each is paired below with the best available Cārvāka answer.

#	Objection (Sharma)	Best Cārvāka reply	Residual pressure
1	Self-consciousness. If consciousness means <i>self</i> -consciousness, it cannot be identified with the living body, since animals have living bodies without rational consciousness	⚠️ Only a particular combination of elements, obtaining in the human body, produces consciousness; so no counter-example arises from animals	⚠️ Sharma calls this "wrong": it makes consciousness essential to a specific organisation, which invites objection 2
2	Separability. If consciousness were an essential property of the living body it would be inseparable from it. But "in swoons, fits, epilepsy, dreamless sleep etc. the living body is seen without consciousness"	⚠️ These are states in which the relevant <i>organisation</i> is disrupted; the property is essential to the organisation, not to bare bodily existence	⚠️ Strong reply, but it moves the doctrine from "body" to "functional organisation", which is a real concession
3	Dream-consciousness. "In dreams, consciousness is seen without the living body"; the dreamer on waking disowns the dream-body but owns the dream-consciousness	⚠️ The dreaming subject is the sleeping physical body; the dream-body is imagined content, not a second body	⚠️ The reply is decent; Sharma's inference that consciousness therefore "persists through" waking, dream and deep sleep already presupposes the Vedāntic three-state argument
4	Subject-object asymmetry. "The subject, the knower, cannot be reduced to the object, the known, since all objects presuppose the existence of the subject"; the subject is enjoyer, the object enjoyed	⚠️ A material organism can be both knower and known, as a hand can touch itself; asymmetry of <i>role</i> does not entail difference of <i>substance</i>	⚠️ This is the deepest objection and it is not fully answered; it is the ancestor of the modern subjectivity problem
5	Co-existence is not causation. "The eye cannot see in darkness. Sight is not possible without light, yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight"; "the two horns of a bull which are always found together cannot be regarded as causally related." The body may be the instrument of consciousness, not its cause	⚠️ Correct as logic — but the instrument-hypothesis needs an independent user, and no such user is perceived; the materialist hypothesis is the more economical of two unproven options	⚠️ Genuinely undecided; both sides are arguing from the same evidence to different best explanations
6	Imperceptibility of the alleged property. "If consciousness is a property of the body, it must be perceived like other material properties. But it is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard "	⚠️ It is perceived — by internal perception, which Cārvāka admits	⚠️ But then the Cārvāka's own criterion has been stretched: internal perception delivers something with no external sensory mode, which is precisely the anomaly the dualist is pointing at

#	Objection (Sharma)	Best Cārvāka reply	Residual pressure
7	Privacy. A material property "should be known by all in the same manner and should not be private. But we find that consciousness is intimately private and consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others"	⚠ Privacy is explained by the <i>locality</i> of the organism: each body has its own internal states, as each fire has its own heat	⚠ The reply confuses <i>causal locality</i> with <i>epistemic inaccessibility</i> ; the objection retains real force
8	Self-manifestation regress. If consciousness is a property of the body, "why should the body, qualified to produce consciousness, itself stand in need of being manifested by consciousness?"	⚠ Being a producer of awareness and being an object of awareness are different roles, and one thing may play both	⚠ A fair reply, though it again concedes a role-distinction that dualists exploit
9	Symmetry of ignorance. "If the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its non-existence too cannot be so demonstrated"	⚠ The Cārvāka's principle is asymmetrical by design: the burden lies on the one who <i>posits</i> an entity, not on the one who withholds assent	⚠ This exposes the difference between <i>not asserting</i> and <i>denying</i> , and most doxographies attribute outright denial rather than agnosticism to Cārvāka

⚠ **The single most useful evaluative sentence to carry from this table:** *Sharma's objections 2, 3 and 5 show that the Cārvāka's evidence establishes at most a dependence of consciousness on the body, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause — so the materialist conclusion is under-determined by the materialist's own evidence.* That sentence is worth reproducing in any answer on the Cārvāka self.

4. Memory and personal identity

⚠ **The objection.** Memory reaches across time: I remember what I did. What sustains the "I" through the constant replacement of bodily material? A permanent substance seems required.

⚠ **The three answers on the table, and the exam requires you to distinguish them:**

School	What secures the identity of the rememberer
Nyāya / Vedānta	✅ A permanent <i>enduring self</i> (<i>ātman</i>) which is the single owner of past experience and present memory
Cārvāka	⚠ Bodily-psychological continuity: the same living organism persists, so the same organism that experienced now recalls. Memory is a bodily-mental trace in a continuing body
Buddhism	✅ <i>Santāna</i> , the causal stream; memory belongs to the same causal continuum, reinforced by <i>pratisandhāna</i> (relinking), and in Yogācāra by <i>ālaya-vijñāna</i> carrying <i>bījas</i>

⚠ **The comparative point that examiners reward.** Cārvāka and Buddhism both reject the permanent owner, but they replace it with different things: Cārvāka with a **material continuant** (a body that endures), Buddhism with a **causal continuant** (a stream in which nothing endures). The Cārvāka answer is

metaphysically cheaper and psychologically thinner; the Buddhist answer is metaphysically subtler and must work much harder, which is why it develops *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and eventually *ālaya-vijñāna*.

Exam link

Primary route: 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks. Use shared denial but different reconstruction: Cārvāka relocates self into body; Buddhism dissolves self into a causal process.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

1. ✅ **Never write that Cārvāka and Buddhism deny the self "in the same way"**. This is the exact error the 2024 question was designed to catch.
2. ⚠️ Do not say Cārvāka denies the self *simpliciter*. He denies a transcendental self and affirms a material one.
3. ⚠️ Do not say Buddhism reduces the person to the body. *Rūpa* is only one of five *skandhas*, and is itself denied selfhood.
4. ⚠️ Do not say Cārvāka denies consciousness. He denies that consciousness needs an immaterial bearer.
5. ⚠️ Do not omit *santāna* when handling memory in Buddhism; and do not smuggle a soul into it.
6. ⚠️ Do not present Sharma's objections as unanswerable. Give the Cārvāka's reply and *then* assess.
7. ⚠️ Do not miss the asymmetry point: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral narrative; Buddhism's denial is constructed to continue it.
8. ⚠️ Do not forget the first-person statements — "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind". They are the Cārvāka's own positive argument and are frequently omitted.
9. ⚠️ Do not treat "death alone is liberation" as a serious soteriology. It is a *rejection* of soteriology expressed in soteriological vocabulary.

Revision notes

- ✅ *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ* / *caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā* — the person is the **living** body qualified by consciousness.
- ✅ Negative argument: "the non-material soul is **never perceived**."
- ✅ Positive argument: "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — bodily predicates attach directly to "I"; on dualism they would be meaningless.
- ✅ Covariation: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease alter awareness.
- ✅ Consequence: death of the body is the end of the individual; questions of rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- ✅ **Sharma's objections**: swoon and dreamless sleep (body without consciousness) · dreams (consciousness without body) · subject cannot be reduced to object · co-existence is not causation (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is neither smelt, tasted, seen, touched nor heard · consciousness is **private** · non-existence of the soul is equally undemonstrable.
- ⚠️ Best evaluative line: the evidence establishes **dependence**, and dependence is compatible with the body being the **instrument** rather than the cause.
- ✅ Memory: Nyāya/Vedānta invoke *enduring self* (*ātman*); Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity; Buddhism invokes *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and *ālaya-vijñāna*.

-  **2024 contrast in one line:** Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into process.
-  Cārvāka's ground is epistemic; Buddhism's is ontological (*pratītyasamutpāda*, *kṣaṇikavāda*) and soteriological (self-belief breeds craving).
-  Cārvāka rejects rebirth, action and moral consequence (karma) and *liberation* (*mokṣa*); Buddhism retains rebirth, action and moral consequence (karma) and *cessation of conditioned suffering* (*nirvāṇa*) without a self.
-  *Rūpa* is one of the five *skandhas* — so Buddhist *anātman* refutes the Cārvāka body-self **by name**.
-  **Puggalavāda** (Vātsīputrīya) is the internal Buddhist foil; **Sadānanda's four materialisms** are the internal Cārvāka foil.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — SELF, BODY AND CONSCIOUSNESS — CONSCIOUS BODY AS SELF (dehātmavāda), AND CĀRVĀKA VERSUS BUDDHIST ANĀTMAN (2024, 20 MARKS)

SUBTOPIC: SELF, BODY AND CONSCIOUSNESS – CONSCIOUS BODY AS SELF (dehātmavāda), AND CĀRVĀKA

VERSUS BUDDHIST ANĀTMAN (2024, 20 MARKS)

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: conscious body as self (dehātmavāda) • emergent consciousness •

body-property • enduring self (ātman) • Buddhist no-self (anātman) • causal stream

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ / caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā – the

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Use shared denial but different reconstruction: Cārvāka relocates self

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: He denies a transcendental self and affirms a material one.  Do not

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda) (doctrine that the body is the

self) explains consciousness as an emergent property of the living body, whereas Buddhist

anātman (no-permanent-self doctrine) analyses the person as a causal continuum without

identifying self and body.

SESSION 7 — THE REJECTION OF TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES — GOD, SOUL, ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE (karma), REBIRTH, HEAVEN, LIBERATION (mokṣa), VEDA AND RITUAL

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) rejects God, an immortal soul, action and its moral consequence across lives (karma), rebirth and liberation (mokṣa) because none is established by perception, and it rejects Vedic ritual authority as epistemically unsupported.

Technical definition: ✅ Chatterjee and Datta name adr̥ṣṭa explicitly among the casualties: "God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like adr̥ṣṭa) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) rejects God, an immortal soul, action and its moral consequence across lives (karma), rebirth and liberation (mokṣa) because none is established by perception, and it rejects Vedic ritual authority as epistemically unsupported.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **creator God**
- **immortal soul**
- **action and moral consequence (karma)**
- **rebirth**
- **Vedic authority**
- **ritual efficacy**

How to use them: Show how the perception criterion removes each transcendent entity in sequence, while distinguishing denial of Vedic authority from the narrower modern meaning of atheism.

CORE DEFINITION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) rejects God, an immortal soul, action and its moral consequence across lives (karma), rebirth and liberation (mokṣa) because none is established by perception, and it rejects Vedic ritual authority as epistemically unsupported.

Plain-language visual - one rule removes seven unseen claims

Only perception is certain

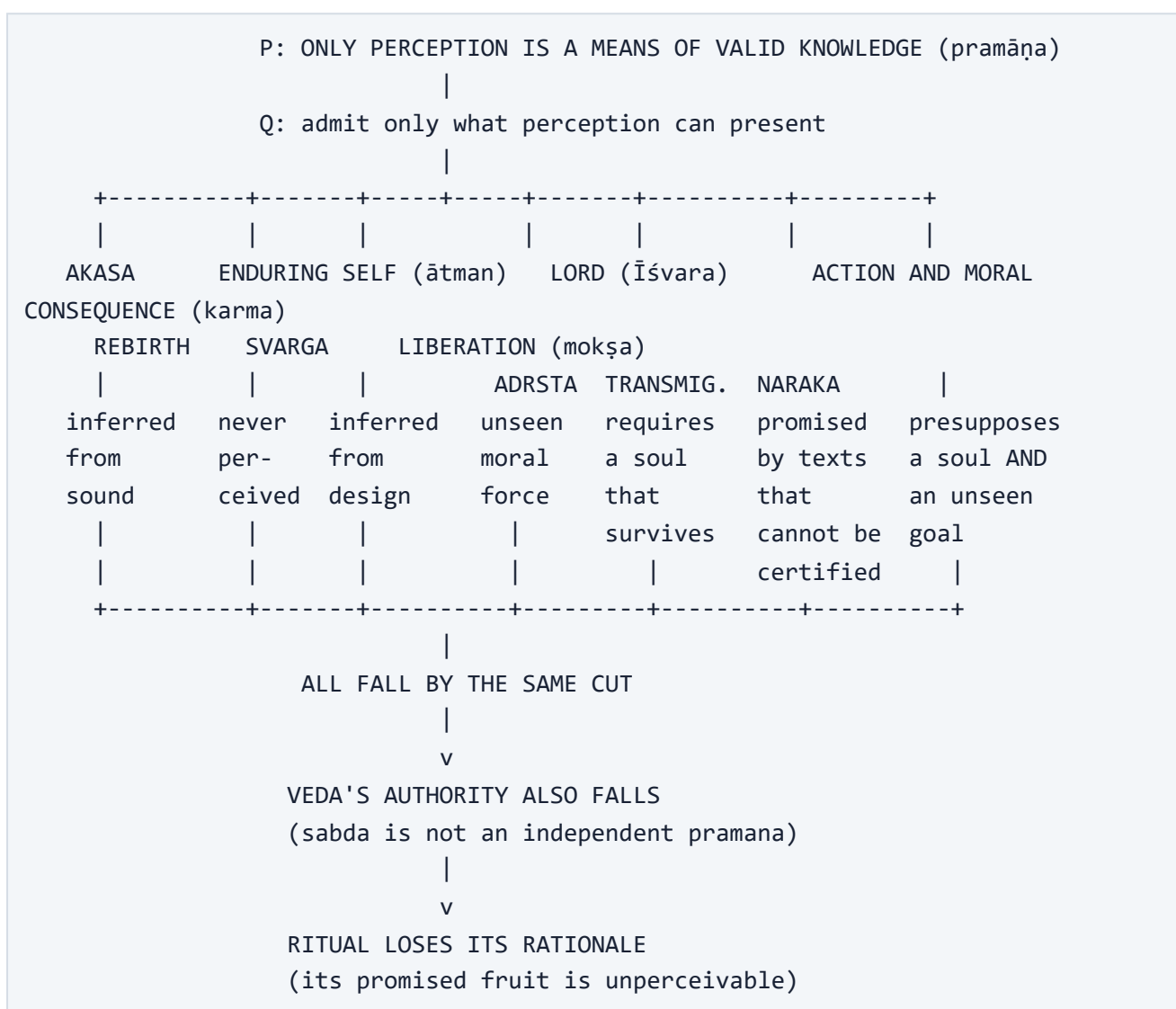
```
|
+--> no separate soul
+--> no God
+--> no unseen action and moral consequence (karma)/adr̥ṣṭa
+--> no rebirth
+--> no heaven or hell
+--> no liberation (mokṣa) after death
+--> no infallible Vedic authority
```

In simple words: these denials are not seven unrelated opinions. Each follows from the same rule: if an entity can be reached only through inference or testimony, Cārvāka does not accept it as established knowledge.

Unseen claim	Why it falls
God	Known through design inference, which Cārvāka rejects
Action and moral consequence (karma) and rebirth	Require an unseen moral force and a surviving carrier
Heaven, hell and liberation	Post-mortem states are not perceived
Vedic ritual	Scriptural testimony has no independent authority

One-line memory: epistemology is the root; rejection of transcendence is the branch.

VISUAL — The demolition tree: one premise, seven casualties



⚠️ Caption. This tree is the answer to the 2021 ten-marker in diagram form. The examiner's phrase — "the **bearing** of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities" — asks for exactly this: not a list of denials, but the demonstration that a single epistemic cut severs them all at once.

1. The general form of every Cārvāka denial

⚠ Every denial in this subtopic instantiates one template. Learn the template, not the list.

1. X is claimed to exist.
2. X is not, and cannot in principle be, presented in perception.
3. The only routes to X are inference or scriptural testimony.
4. Neither inference nor testimony is an independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).
5. Therefore there is no valid means by which X could be known.
6. Therefore X should not be admitted into our ontology.

⚠ **The precision point at step 6.** There is a real difference between *withholding assent* (agnosticism) and *denying* (atheism, in the broad sense). ? The doxographical sources overwhelmingly present Cārvāka as **denying** — "the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism" (Chatterjee and Datta) — but the argument as stated licenses only the weaker conclusion. Sharma records the opposing school's exploitation of exactly this gap: "if the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its **non-existence** too cannot be so demonstrated." A first-class answer notes the gap and states which reading it is defending.

2. God — and why *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* is the operative reason

✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "God, whose existence cannot be perceived, **fares no better than the soul**. The material elements produce the world, and the supposition of a creator is unnecessary."

⚠ **Two distinct arguments are at work, and separating them is worth marks:**

Argument	Form	Force
Epistemic	God is imperceptible; the only routes to God are inference (the design and causal arguments) and <i>verbal testimony (śabda)</i> ; both are denied <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i> -status	✓ Removes the warrant for theism
Explanatory (<i>svabhāvavāda</i>)	Even granting the explanatory question, the fixed natures of the elements suffice; "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design"	✓ Removes the need for theism

⚠ Note that the second argument is logically independent of the first, and is the more interesting one, because it engages Nyāya on Nyāya's own ground. Nyāya's *kāryāt* inference argues from the world as a composite **effect** to an intelligent efficient cause. The Cārvāka's *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* rejoinder does not merely say "you cannot know that"; it says "the explanandum is discharged without you". ⚠ Chatterjee and Datta record the further Cārvāka move: the objects of the world "can be explained more reasonably as the **fortuitous** products of the elements" — which is *yadṛcchāvāda*, and which sits in some tension with a strong *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* that grounds regularity in fixed natures. Noting that internal tension is a genuinely advanced observation.

3. Action and moral consequence (karma), adṛṣṭa and the moral order

✓ Chatterjee and Datta name *adṛṣṭa* explicitly among the casualties: "God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and **any unperceived law (like *adṛṣṭa*)** cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

⚠ **Why *adṛṣṭa* is the decisive test case.** *Adṛṣṭa* — "the unseen" — is by its own definition imperceptible. It is the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and Mīmāṃsā device for connecting an act performed now with a fruit enjoyed later, sometimes in another life. The Cārvāka's objection is therefore not incidental but **definitional**: an entity whose name announces its imperceptibility is precisely what an epistemology of perception must refuse.

✓ **The objection from moral order, and the Cārvāka's reply.** The authored knowledge file records the exchange: without *action and moral consequence (karma)* and rebirth, moral order is said to collapse. The Cārvāka answer is that "morality need not be underwritten by cosmic bookkeeping; human pain, pleasure, prudence, and social consequences are enough for practical conduct."

⚠ **Assessment to write.** The reply establishes that a *this-worldly* account of moral motivation is available; it does not establish that such an account can support obligations that run against self-interest with no observer. This is the enduring weak point of Cārvāka ethics and connects directly to Subtopic 8.

4. Rebirth and transmigration — the 2020 question's second half

✓ **Exact question (2020, Q6(b), 15 marks).** "*Critically evaluate Cārvākas' rejection of Ākāśa as one of the elements of reality and examine their criticism of transmigration of Soul.*"

⚠ **What transmigration requires, and where Cārvāka cuts each requirement:**

Requirement of transmigration	Cārvāka's cut
(a) A self distinct from the body	✓ <i>Conscious body as self (dehātmanvāda)</i> : the self is the living body; no separable subject exists to migrate
(b) Survival of that self after bodily death	✓ "Death of the body means the end of the individual"; the elements disperse, and the combination that carried consciousness is dissolved
(c) A carrier of moral desert across the gap	✓ <i>Action and moral consequence (karma)</i> and <i>adṛṣṭa</i> are unperceived and hence unwarranted
(d) Knowledge that any of (a)–(c) obtains	✓ Only scripture and inference could supply it; both are denied <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i> -status
(e) Meaningfulness of the claim	⚠ Chatterjee and Datta report that questions about "previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell" become meaningless — a quasi-verificationist step

⚠ **The critical evaluation the question explicitly demands.** A "critically evaluate" question is not answered by exposition. Supply both sides:

STRENGTHS of the Carvaka position

(i) consistency: the same criterion cuts akasa, enduring self (ātman) and rebirth alike

- (ii) economy: nothing unobservable is posited
- (iii) anti-exploitation: it removes the machinery on which ritual prescription and priestly authority rested
- (iv) it forces every rival school to say HOW an unseen bearer of desert is known -- a demand Nyaya answers only inferentially

WEAKNESSES

- (i) the argument rests on the rejection of inference, which is itself vulnerable (Subtopics 3-4)
- (ii) dependence of consciousness on the body does not entail production by the body (Sharma's instrument objection)
- (iii) "not established" is slid into "does not exist"
- (iv) the disappearance of moral continuity leaves desert and obligation without any ground beyond prudence
- (v) Sharma: the non-existence of a surviving soul is as undemonstrable as its existence

⚠ **Verdict formula for this question:** *The rejection of ākāśa and of transmigration are the same argument applied twice — once to cosmology and once to soteriology — and their force is exactly the force of the underlying epistemology. Where that epistemology is defensible, as a demand that metaphysical postulates earn their keep, the rejection is powerful; where it over-reaches, in converting "unestablished" into "unreal", the rejection outruns its warrant.*

5. Heaven, hell and liberation (*mokṣa*)

✅ **Heaven.** Chatterjee and Datta: the Mīmāṃsakas hold that the highest goal is heaven (*svarga*), "a state of unalloyed bliss that can be attained hereafter by performing here the Vedic rites. **The Cārvāka rejects this view, because it is based on the unproved existence of a life after death.** 'Heaven' and 'hell' are the **inventions of the priests** whose professional interest lies in coaxing, threatening and making people perform the rituals. Enlightened men will always refuse to be duped by them."

✅ **Liberation.** The Cārvāka argument is a dilemma, and it is elegant:

What could "liberation" mean?

HORN 1: freedom of the SOUL from bondage to physical existence
-> "absurd, because there is no soul"

HORN 2: attainment, IN THIS LIFE, of a state free from ALL pain
-> "an impossible ideal. Existence in this body is bound up with pleasure as well as pain."

RESIDUE: "Liberation in the sense of complete cessation of sufferings can only mean DEATH." -> maranam eva apavargah

✅ Both horns and the residue are given verbatim in substance by Chatterjee and Datta, and the residue is one of the six transmitted *Bṛhaspati sūtras*.

⚠ **How to present *marāṇam eva apavargaḥ* without caricature.** It is not a recommendation of death and it is not nihilism. It is a **reductio of the concept of liberation**: if *liberation (mokṣa)* means the total cessation of suffering, then the only state that satisfies the definition is the one no wise person would work for. The verse is a critique of the *coherence* of the goal, not an endorsement of dying. Saying this in one sentence is worth a mark and protects you from the commonest misreading in the topic.

6. The Veda, priestcraft and the ritual reductions

✓ **The epistemic charge.** *Verbal testimony (śabda)* is not an independent *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* (Subtopic 2); Vedic authority therefore has no certified standing. Claims of authorlessness or infallibility are not perceptually available.

✓ **The sociological charge.** Chatterjee and Datta report it plainly: "in reality the Vedas are the works of some **cunning priests** who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous", and the tangible benefit of the rites goes to "the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

✓ **The *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* summary**, as reproduced by Sharma, is the sharpest form of the polemic and should be used with an explicit source-caution: "There is no heaven, no final liberation, nor any soul in another world; nor do the actions of the four castes, orders etc. produce any real effect. The **Agnihotra**, the three Vedas, the ascetic's three staves and smearing one's self with ashes, were made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness... **(All the ceremonies are) a means of livelihood (for) Brāhmaṇas. The three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons.**"

✓ **The three ritual reductions** — each is a genuine argument, not merely abuse, and each has the same logical shape: *take the ritual's own premise seriously, and derive an absurdity the practitioner will not accept.*

#	The reductio	The premise it tests	The absurdity generated
1	The śrāddha argument. If the food offered at the funeral ceremony can appease the hunger of the departed, "what is the use of a traveller's taking food with him? Why should not his people make some offerings in his name at home to satisfy his hunger?"	That an offering here nourishes a person elsewhere	⚠ Nourishment at a distance would make travel provisions pointless — a consequence no one accepts
2	The upstairs argument. "Food offered on the ground floor should satisfy a person living upstairs."	The same, in miniature	⚠ A vivid <i>reductio</i> of action-at-a-distance nourishment
3	The jyotiṣṭoma argument. "If the priests really believe, as they say, that the animals killed at a sacrifice are sure to reach heaven, why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents instead of animals and make heaven sure for them?"	That ritual slaughter secures heaven for the victim	⚠ The priest's refusal reveals that he does not believe his own premise — an argument from revealed preference

⚠️ **The philosophically important observation to add.** The *jyotiṣṭoma* argument is not a joke; it is an early and powerful use of **revealed preference** as evidence about belief. It says: your unwillingness to apply your doctrine where it would cost you shows that you do not hold it in the way you profess. That is a serious epistemic argument and deserves to be presented as one.

⚠️ **The balance an answer must strike.** Chatterjee and Datta themselves describe the Cārvākas as raising "cheap laughter at the customary rites". An answer that reproduces only the abuse looks unserious; an answer that reproduces only the epistemology misses the school's historical bite. Present the polemic **and** extract the argument inside it.

Exam link

Primary routes: 2020 Q6(b) on transmigration and 2021 Q5(e) on the bearing of epistemology. Show one premise generating each denial rather than listing conclusions.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

- ⚠️ Do not present the denials as a list. Show the **derivation** from the single epistemic premise — that is what "bearing" means in 2021 Q5(e).
- ⚠️ Do not slide from "not established" to "does not exist" without noticing. Sharma exploits exactly that slide.
- ⚠️ Do not read *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ* as a recommendation of death. It is a *reductio* of the concept of liberation.
- ⚠️ Do not reduce the ritual criticisms to abuse. The *śrāddha* and *jyotiṣṭoma* arguments are genuine *reductios*, and the second is an argument from revealed preference.
- ⚠️ Do not quote the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* invective without a source-caution; it is a summary preserved by an opponent.
- ⚠️ Do not say "Cārvāka is the only atheist school in India". Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are all non-theistic. Cārvāka is the only school whose atheism follows from its **epistemology** and which also discards action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth and liberation.
- ⚠️ Do not forget *adr̥ṣṭa* by name. It is the perfect test case, since its name means "the unseen".
- ⚠️ Do not miss the internal tension between *explanation through natural properties* (*svabhāvavāda*) (fixed natures grounding regularity) and *yadr̥cchāvāda* (fortuitous combination). Noting it is a mark of independent thought.

Revision notes

- ✓ **The template:** X is imperceptible → only inference or testimony could reach X → neither is a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*) → X is unwarranted → X is rejected.
- ⚠️ Note the gap between withholding assent and denying; the doxographies attribute denial, the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
- ✓ God falls twice over: **epistemically** (no *pramāṇa*) and **explanatorily** (*svabhāva* suffices; "no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design").
- ✓ *Adr̥ṣṭa* is named explicitly among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*)".

-  Transmigration requires a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three; Cārvāka cuts every one.
-  Heaven and hell are "the inventions of the priests"; *svarga* is rejected because it rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
-  **The liberation dilemma:** freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) or freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain); residue — *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ*.
-  **Three ritual reductions:** *śrāddha* and the traveller's food · food downstairs for a person upstairs · *jyotiṣṭoma* and "why not sacrifice their own old parents".
-  *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*: Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes are "the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons" — quote with a source-caution.
-  The *jyotiṣṭoma* argument is an argument from **revealed preference** about what the priest actually believes.
-  Cārvāka is not the only non-theistic Indian school; it is the only one whose atheism is generated **epistemologically**, and the only one that also discards action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth and *liberation (mokṣa)*.
-  Internal tension worth noting: *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* grounds regularity in fixed natures, while *yadr̥cchāvāda* calls the world's objects "fortuitous products".

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — THE REJECTION OF TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES — GOD, SOUL, ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE (karma), REBIRTH, HEAVEN, LIBERATION (mokṣa), VEDA AND RITUAL

SUBTOPIC: THE REJECTION OF TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES – GOD, SOUL, ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE

(karma), REBIRTH, HEAVEN, LIBERATION (mokṣa), VEDA AND RITUAL

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: creator God · immortal soul · action and moral consequence (karma) ·

rebirth · Vedic authority · ritual efficacy

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The template: X is imperceptible → only inference or testimony could

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Cārvāka is the only school whose atheism follows from its epistemology

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction:  The Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) rejects God, an immortal soul,

action and its moral consequence across lives (karma), rebirth and liberation (mokṣa) because none is established by perception, and it rejects Vedic ritual authority as epistemically unsupported.

SESSION 8 — ETHICS AND THE POLITICAL-SOCIAL MEANING — AND CĀRVĀKA VERSUS JAINA REALITY (2020, 15 MARKS)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) ethics is best read as prudent this-worldly well-being rather than crude hedonism: pleasure is valuable, pain is a cost, and action requires intelligent calculation within embodied social life.

Technical definition: Cārvāka ethics prioritises attainable goods in embodied life and criticises unseen ritual rewards, while its social significance lies in challenging priestly and metaphysical authority.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) ethics is best read as prudent this-worldly well-being rather than crude hedonism: pleasure is valuable, pain is a cost, and action requires intelligent calculation within embodied social life.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **this-worldliness**
- **pleasure (kāma)**
- **material well-being (artha)**
- **prudential hedonism**
- **ritual critique**
- **Jaina plural realism**

How to use them: Frame Cārvāka ethics as embodied this-worldliness rather than reckless indulgence, then contrast its materialism with Jaina souls, action and moral consequence (karma) and liberation.

CORE DEFINITION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) ethics is best read as prudent this-worldly well-being rather than crude hedonism: pleasure is valuable, pain is a cost, and action requires intelligent calculation within embodied social life.

Plain-language visual - the purpose-of-life filter

DHARMA -> rejected as scripture-dependent
MATERIAL WELL-BEING (artha) -> accepted as a means
PLEASURE (kāma) -> accepted as the final this-worldly end
LIBERATION (mokṣa) -> rejected as an unproved post-mortem ideal

MATERIAL WELL-BEING (artha) -----> PLEASURE (kāma)
means end

In simple words: because this life is the only life securely known, Cārvāka values attainable well-being here. Wealth matters as a tool for enjoyment, not as an end by itself. The tradition must not be reduced automatically to reckless pleasure: sources distinguish crude and cultured forms.

Crude reading	Refined reading
Immediate sensual gratification	Intelligent enjoyment shaped by skill and self-control
Ignores social discipline	Recognises that society requires restraint
Common hostile caricature	Supported by the <i>dhūrta</i> / <i>suśikṣita</i> distinction

One-line memory: this-worldly enjoyment is central, but intelligent enjoyment is not identical with reckless indulgence.

VISUAL — The *puruṣārtha* ledger, and the two axes of the Cārvāka position

THE FOUR PURUSARTHAS		CARVAKA'S VERDICT	
-----		-----	
DHARMA	(virtue / duty)	----->	REJECTED : "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted"
MATERIAL WELL-BEING (artha)	(wealth)	----->	ACCEPTED as MEANS, not as end
PLEASURE (kāma)	(enjoyment)	----->	ACCEPTED as THE END
liberation (mokṣa)		----->	REJECTED : obtainable "only by death, and no wise man would work for that"
+-----+			
(kāma)	MATERIAL WELL-BEING (artha)	---- means ---->	PLEASURE
			(ultimate)
+-----+			
AND WITHIN "PLEASURE (kāma)" THERE ARE TWO CARVAKAS:			
DHURTA (cunning/crude)		SUSIKSITA (cultured/refined)	
-----		-----	
gross sensual pleasure		pleasure disciplined by the	
immediate gratification		sixty-four fine arts, self-	
egoistic hedonism		control and urbanity	
the caricature the		Vatsyayana's Kama-sutra as the	
opponents preserved		"best positive evidence"	
		(Chatterjee & Datta)	

⚠️ Caption. Two axes, not one. The first axis is which *puruṣārthas* survive; the second is *what kind of* hedonist is doing the surviving. Almost every weak answer collapses the second axis and presents only the *dhūrta*. The textbooks themselves refuse that collapse.

1. The doctrine, stated exactly

✓ **The transmitted *sūtra*:** *pleasure (kāma) evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — "enjoyment is the only end of human life."

✓ **The four-fold verdict**, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact terms: "Of these four, the Cārvāka rejects the last two. Liberation in the sense of destruction of all sufferings can be obtained only by death and no wise man would willingly work for that end. **Virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted.** Therefore neither liberation nor virtue should be our end. Wealth and enjoyment are the only rational ends that a wise man can toil to achieve. But **enjoyment is the ultimate end; wealth is not an end in itself, it is good only as a means to enjoyment.**"

⚠ **Two things to notice, both examinable.**

1. The rejection of *dharma* is **epistemically** driven, not merely appetitive. *Dharma* is rejected because it is a *scriptural* category and *verbal testimony (śabda)* is not a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* — the same cut that removed *ākāśa* and *enduring self (ātman)*. Writing "Cārvāka rejects virtue because he loves pleasure" reverses the direction of the argument.
2. *Material well-being (artha)* is subordinated, not co-ordinate. Cārvāka is not a materialist about *wealth*; wealth is instrumental. That is a real ethical thesis and it separates Cārvāka from mere acquisitiveness.

2. The standard of right action, and its consequentialist form

✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "A **good action** is one which leads to a **balance of pleasure** and a **bad action** is one which brings about **more pain than pleasure**. This Cārvāka ethics may be called, therefore, **hedonism** or the theory that pleasure is the highest goal."

⚠ **The structure of the criterion, made explicit:**

VALUE THEORY	: pleasure is the sole intrinsic good; pain the sole intrinsic evil
NORMATIVE THEORY	: the right action is the one whose balance of pleasure over pain is greatest
SCOPE	: the doxographies present the scope as EGOISTIC -- "pleasure of the senses in this life and that too of the individual is the sole end" (Sharma)
BUT	: Chatterjee & Datta explicitly deny that ALL materialists were egoistic hedonists

⚠ **The scope question is where the real philosophy is.** Egoistic hedonism and universalistic hedonism share a value theory and differ entirely in their normative consequences. Chatterjee and Datta record the decisive consideration: "**Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline. Life in society is impossible if man does not sacrifice a part of his pleasures for others.**" And they immediately supply the evidence that some Cārvākas saw this: "Some Cārvākas, we are told, regard the **king as God**. This implies their great faith in the necessity of society and its head."

3. Refined hedonism — the evidence, and why it matters

✓ **The *dhūrta* / *suśikṣita* distinction.** Chatterjee and Datta: "a distinction found sometimes between the **cunning (*dhūrta*)** and **cultured (*suśikṣita*)** Cārvākas makes it likely that the Cārvākas were **not all of the same gross, uncultured type**." Sharma records the same twofold division of "Crude and Refined Materialists".

✓ **The evidence for refinement**, as Chatterjee and Datta present it:

Evidence	Detail
The fine arts	Materialists "devoted themselves also to the pursuit of more refined pleasures by cultivating, for example, the fine arts, the number of which is as large as sixty-four (<i>catuḥ-śaṣṭi-kalāḥ</i>), according to Vātsyāyana"
Political philosophy and economics	" Political philosophy and economy (<i>daṇḍanīti</i> and <i>vārttā</i>) came to be incorporated at some stage in the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas "
The king as God	Reported of some Cārvākas — implying "great faith in the necessity of society and its head"
Vātsyāyana's <i>Kāma-sūtra</i>	"The best positive evidence of refined hedonism is found in the ethical philosophy propounded by Vātsyāyana in the second chapter of the <i>Kāma-sūtra</i> "

✓ **Vātsyāyana's position, stated precisely — and note the important qualification.** Chatterjee and Datta are careful: "Though Vātsyāyana **believes in God and in life after death** and, therefore, is **not a materialist in the ordinary sense**, yet he may be regarded as one, according to a **wider** sense of the term, namely, one who tries to explain 'higher phenomena by lower ones'." His materialist tendency "consists in holding that *dharma* and *material well-being* (*artha*) are to be treated only as **means** to enjoyment, which is therefore the supreme end."

✓ **The content of the refinement**, which is the material that rescues Cārvāka ethics from caricature:

1. Emphasis on **self-control (*brahmacarya*)**, spiritual discipline (*dharma*) and **urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*)**, "without which human enjoyment of pleasure is reduced to the level of beastly enjoyment."
2. All *pleasure* (*kāma*) is "ultimately reducible to the gratification of the five senses"; the satisfaction of the senses is "necessary for the very existence of the body (*śāñra-sthiti*)", like the satisfaction of hunger.
3. The senses "must be **educated, disciplined and cultured** through a training in the sixty-four fine arts", given only after "absolute self-continenence and study" in the earlier part of life.
4. Against the impatient hedonist who will not "forgo present comfort" or "undergo any toil for future enjoyment", Vātsyāyana argues that such an attitude "would be **suicidal**", since it "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds in the hope of the future enjoyment of a crop."
5. "**Inordinate desire, inconsistent with the principles of *dharma* and wealth, leads to ruin and annihilates the chances of all enjoyment.**"
6. He argues, "like a modern scientific man, that some science is at the root of every successful practice."

⚠ **The philosophical upshot, and it is important.** Point 4 is a **prudential** argument *internal* to hedonism: unregulated present gratification is self-defeating **on hedonistic grounds**. That is exactly the structure of Epicurus' argument in the West, and it means that the refined Cārvāka position is not a compromise with morality imported from outside — it is what consistent hedonism requires of itself. Chatterjee and Datta conclude that Vātsyāyana "represents Indian hedonism at its best", and that the name *suśikṣita-cārvāka* was "perhaps" applied to thinkers of this kind.

⚠ **The honest counterweight.** Sharma's verdict is far harsher and must be carried too: "The ethics of the Cārvāka is a **crude individual hedonism**"; "All values are mere phantoms created by a diseased mind"; and he locates the school's downfall not in its atheism or its materialism — which it shares with respected schools — but in "the Cārvāka's **denial of all human values** which make life worth living... Sensual pleasure is a very faint shadow of the supreme pleasure. There is a qualitative difference in pleasure. **The pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher.**"

⚠ **How to adjudicate in an answer.** The two verdicts are about different things and both are usable:

SHARMA'S TARGET	: the doctrine as transmitted in the doxographies -- gross, egoistic, quantitative hedonism
CHATTERJEE & DATTA'S TARGET	: the historical breadth of the movement -- the susikṣita strand, the fine arts, dandaniti and varta, the king-as-God report, Vatsyayana's discipline
VERDICT TO WRITE	: the transmitted doctrine is vulnerable to Sharma's "pleasure of the pig" objection because it offers no QUALITATIVE distinction among pleasures; the refined strand supplies a PRUDENTIAL and CULTURAL regulation of pleasure but still no independent standard of value. Carvaka can be made prudent; it cannot easily be made moral.

4. The "debt and ghee" verse — and the source caution

? **The verse**, as preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* and reproduced by Sharma: "**While life remains let a man live happily, let him feed on ghee (clarified butter) even though he runs in debt; when once the body becomes ashes, how can it ever return here?**"

⚠ **The source caution, which must accompany every use of this verse.** This is:

1. A verse preserved in a **fourteenth-century doxography** compiled by **Mādhava**, a Vedāntin — that is, by an opponent;
2. Presented in a chapter whose purpose is refutation;
3. Not attributable to any surviving primary Cārvāka text;
4. Frequently paraphrased in exam scripts as *yāvaj jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet*, which the authored knowledge file itself flags as a **doxographical verse associated with the tradition, not a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text**.

⚠️ **How to use it correctly in an answer:** *"The often-quoted verse — live happily, feed on ghee even in debt, for the body once turned to ashes does not return — is preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha, an opponent's compendium, and should be treated as a doxographical characterisation of the school's spirit rather than as its own scripture."* That single sentence signals scholarly care and forestalls the examiner's objection.

⚠️ **The philosophical point beneath the rhetoric.** Strip away the polemic and the verse encodes a real argument: *if there is no post-mortem accounting, then the discounting of present goods in favour of future or other-worldly ones is irrational*. That is an argument about the **rationality of deferral under a finite horizon**, and it is answerable — Vātsyāyana himself answers it, in point 4 above, by observing that a refusal to defer would prevent even sowing a crop. Presenting the verse *with* its internal rebuttal is far better than quoting it as a slogan.

5. Positivistic, naturalistic, secular — a first pass at the 2024 label

⚠️ Full treatment belongs to Subtopic 9 and the workbook, but the ethical material contributes three of the strongest points:

Label	Why it fits ✓	Why it must be qualified ⚠️
Naturalistic	<i>Explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda); value grounded in embodied pleasure and pain; no supernatural sanction</i>	The notion of "nature" is descriptive, not analysed into laws
Secular	Morality is detached from scripture and priesthood; <i>daṇḍanīti</i> and <i>vārttā</i> enter the school; the king, not God, is the guarantor of order	The detachment is polemical rather than institutional; no political theory survives
Positivistic	✓ Chatterjee and Datta apply the word themselves: the theory "may also be called positivism, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena "; they add that the Cārvāka view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the pragmatists and logical positivists "	⚠️ Positivism venerates science , which is built on inference; Cārvāka attacks inference. Positivism has a constructive programme; Cārvāka has a polemical minimalism. And Comte's positivism carries a philosophy of history and a sociology entirely absent here

Exam link

Primary routes: 2020 Q7(c) and 2024 Q5(a). Keep ethics source-critical, separate prudence from morality, and compare Cārvāka with Jainism or positivism only on named axes.

Traps and recap

UPSC traps

- ⚠️ Do not reduce Cārvāka ethics to reckless sensualism. The textbooks themselves distinguish *dhūrta* from *suśikṣita* Cārvākas.
- ⚠️ Do not say Cārvāka rejects *dharma* because he prefers pleasure. He rejects it because it is a **scriptural** category, and *verbal testimony (śabda)* is not a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*.

3. ⚠ Do not treat *material well-being (artha)* as a second end. It is explicitly a **means** to *pleasure (kāma)*.
4. ? Do not quote the "ghee and debt" verse as Cārvāka scripture. It is preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*, an opponent's compendium.
5. ⚠ Do not call Vātsyāyana a Cārvāka without qualification. He "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term".
6. ⚠ Do not omit *daṇḍanīti*, *vārttā* and the king-as-God report if the question touches the school's social or political meaning.
7. ⚠ Do not answer the 2020 Jainism comparison with "materialism versus spirituality". Run the axes: *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)*, definition of the real, constituents, *ākāśa*, soul, substance—mode, standpoint, action and moral consequence (karma), liberation.
8. ⚠ Do not forget that Jainism holds consciousness to be the soul's **inseparable essence**, expressly denying the Cārvāka view that it is "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions".
9. ⚠ Do not present Sharma's harsh verdict and Chatterjee and Datta's sympathetic one as a contradiction. They target different objects — the transmitted doctrine and the historical movement.

Revision notes

- ✓ *pleasure (kāma) evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — enjoyment is the only end; *material well-being (artha)* is its **means**; *dharma* and *liberation (mokṣa)* are rejected.
- ✓ *Dharma* is rejected on **epistemic** grounds: virtue and vice are "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- ✓ Criterion of right action: a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- ✓ **Dhūrta** (cunning/crude) versus **suśikṣita** (cultured/refined) Cārvākas — the textbooks refuse a single, gross portrait.
- ✓ Evidence for refinement: the sixty-four fine arts (*catuḥ-śaṣṭi-kalāḥ*); *daṇḍanīti* and *vārttā* incorporated into Lokāyata; some Cārvākas regard the **king as God**.
- ✓ **Vātsyāyana** is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism" — but he believes in God and an afterlife and so is a materialist only "in a wider sense".
- ✓ Vātsyāyana's regulation: *brahmacarya*, urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*), education of the senses, and the argument that refusing to defer would prevent even sowing a crop.
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline."
- ⚠ Sharma's counterweight: "crude individual hedonism"; the school fell through "the denial of all human values"; "the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher."
- ? The "ghee and debt" verse comes from the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* — an opponent's compendium; quote with caution, and extract the argument about deferral under a finite horizon.
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta apply the word **positivism** to Cārvāka themselves — "because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena" — and compare its view of inference to the pragmatists and logical positivists.
- ✓ **2020 comparison**: one *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* versus five kinds of knowledge · four *bhūtas* versus six *dravyas* · *ākāśa* rejected versus accepted · no soul versus infinite *individual self (jīvas)* with consciousness as inseparable essence · single standpoint versus *anekāntavāda* and

syādvāda · no action and moral consequence (karma) versus **material** action and moral consequence (karma) · no liberation versus *liberation (mokṣa)* and *kevala-jñāna*.

- ⚠ Shared ground with Jainism: both *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)*, both realist about the perceptible world, both reject a creator God.
- ⚠ Verdict: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of **prudence** and an incomplete theory of **morality**.

COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS AND ANSWER-WRITING ARCHITECTURE

EXAM-READY LINE: Final verdict: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) is philosophically strongest as a critique of dogmatism and weak inference, but its restriction of knowledge to perception is too narrow to explain science, ordinary reasoning and its own universal claims.

Plain-language visual - the complete answer spine

```

PERCEPTION ONLY
|
INFERENCE / TESTIMONY REJECTED
|
FOUR-ELEMENT MATERIALISM
|
BODY-SELF + NO TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES
|
MATERIAL WELL-BEING (artha) AS MEANS + PLEASURE (kāma) AS END
|
BALANCED VERDICT: critical empiricism, but too narrow for science
  
```

In simple words: every Cārvāka answer should show a chain, not a list. Begin with the epistemic rule, derive the metaphysics and ethics, then evaluate both the achievement and the cost.

Marks	Fast structure
10	Define -> derive -> one objection -> verdict
15	Reconstruct -> example -> criticism/reply -> evaluation
20	Full dialectic -> comparison -> graded conclusion

One-line memory: ONE *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*, FOUR elements, TWO accepted aims, ZERO transcendent entities.

MASTER CONCEPT MAP — the whole syllabus item on one page

```

+=====+
|               C Ā R V Ā K A   /   L O K Ā Y A T A               |
  
```

[1] SOURCES	[2] EPISTEMOLOGY	[3] ANTI-INFERENCE
Bṛhaspati-sūtra LOST	perception (pratyakṣa)	invariable
concomitance		
hostile doxography	alone is a means of	(vyāpti) is
unprovable:		
quoted fragments only	valid knowledge	- not by perception
Jayarāśi = limit-case	external (bāhya) +	- not by inference
Veda-rejecting (nāstika)	internal (mānasa)	- not by testimony
		hidden condition
(upādhi)		
		defeats hasty
universals		
+-----+-----+-----+		
[4] NYĀYA REPLY		SELF-REFUTATION CHARGE
anvaya-vyatireka		"the denial is itself
upādhi-elimination		a universal"
tarka (auxiliary)		replies: no-thesis /
sāmānyalakṣaṇa		softened / level-
distinction		
parāmarśa		
warrant, not		
omniscience		
v		v
[5] METAPHYSICS ----->	[7] TRANSCENDENT DENIALS	
four elements, NO ether (ākāśa)	soul · creator (Īśvara) ·	
elements eternal, combinations not	moral residue (karma, adṛṣṭa) ·	
awareness emerges from the organised	rebirth · heaven · hell ·	
body (bhūta-caitanya)	liberation (mokṣa) · Vedic	
authority		
betel = compositional emergence	ritual reductio: the sacrificial	
fermentation = transformational	victim and the sacrificer's	
father		
own nature (svabhāvavāda) [attested]	"death itself is liberation"	
chance (yadṛcchāvāda) [contested]	(maraṇam eva apavargaḥ)	
v		v
[6] SELF	[8] ETHICS	
the living body is the self	pleasure (kāma) = the end	
(dehātmavāda)	wealth (artha) = the means	
"I am stout / I am thin"	scriptural duty (dharma) rejected	
vs BUDDHISM: relocation, not	liberation (mokṣa) rejected	
dissolution of the self	crude (dhūrta) vs refined	

vs NYĀYA: no enduring self at all
four self-models: body, senses,
vital processes, mind [contested]

(suśikṣita) [contested]
statecraft (daṇḍanīti) and
livelihood (vārttā); king-as-God



[9] SYNTHESIS : positivistic? • vs Jainism • vs Buddhism • vs Nyāya
graded verdict • 10/15/20 architecture • PYQ routing

1. The master comparison table

Axis	Cārvāka	Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika	Buddhism	Jainism
Means of valid knowledge (<i>pramāṇas</i>)	✓ 1 — perception	✓ 4 — perception, inference, comparison, testimony	✓ 2 — perception, inference	✓ Fivefold knowledge; inference admitted
Elements / substances	✓ 4 <i>bhūtas</i> , no <i>ākāśa</i>	✓ 9 <i>dravyas</i> , including <i>ākāśa</i> , enduring self (<i>ātman</i>), sensory mind (<i>manas</i>)	⚠ <i>Dharmas</i> , momentary	✓ 6 <i>dravyas</i> , including <i>ākāśa</i> and <i>kāla</i>
Self	✓ Living body (<i>dehātmavāda</i>)	✓ Eternal substantial enduring self (<i>ātman</i>)	✓ No self; five <i>skandhas</i> , <i>santāna</i>	✓ Infinite <i>individual self</i> (<i>jīvas</i>); consciousness their inseparable essence
Consciousness	✓ Emergent by-product of matter	✓ Adventitious quality of enduring self (<i>ātman</i>)	✓ <i>Vijñāna</i> , one conditioned <i>skandha</i>	✓ Essence of the soul, obscured by action and moral consequence (<i>karma</i>)
God	✓ Rejected; <i>svabhāva</i> suffices	✓ Proved by <i>kāryāt</i> , <i>āyojanāt</i> , <i>dhṛtyādeḥ</i> , <i>padāt/śruteḥ</i>	✓ Rejected; conditions suffice	✓ No creator; godhood attained by the <i>siddha</i>
Action and moral consequence (<i>karma</i>)	✓ Rejected as unseen	✓ Accepted; <i>adrṣṭa</i> , God as dispenser	✓ Accepted; causal-moral continuity	✓ Accepted; action and moral consequence (<i>karma</i>) as subtle matter
Rebirth	✓ Rejected	✓ Accepted	✓ Accepted, without a self	✓ Accepted
Liberation	✓ None; <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>	✓ Release (<i>apavarga</i>) as cessation of pain	✓ Cessation of conditioned suffering (<i>nirvāṇa</i>)	✓ Liberation (<i>mokṣa</i>); <i>kevala-jñāna</i>
Vedic authority	✓ Rejected — hence <i>Veda-rejecting school</i> (<i>nāstika</i>)	✓ Accepted	✓ Rejected	✓ Rejected
Standpoint theory	⚠ None; single standpoint	⚠ None	✓ <i>Samvṛti</i> / <i>paramārtha</i>	✓ <i>Anekānta</i> , <i>naya</i> , <i>syādvāda</i>

2. Criticisms and replies — the consolidated grid

#	Criticism	Cārvāka's best reply	Residual assessment
1	✅ Self-refutation: the universal denial of inference is itself inferential; other minds and ideas are never perceived	⚠️ Soften the thesis to a denial of <i>apodictic certainty</i> , or restrict it to transcendental inference; or advance no thesis at all (<i>vitaṇḍā</i>)	⚠️ Decisive against the strong form; the softened form survives but is a much weaker doctrine
2	✅ Science becomes impossible: without induction, no stable knowledge beyond isolated perceptions	⚠️ Practical expectations remain available, tied to future perceptual check	⚠️ Saves practice better than theory; narrows Cārvāka into radical empiricist caution
3	✅ Perception itself errs (flat earth, static earth, small sun) — and is corrected <i>by inference</i>	⚠️ The corrections are ultimately perceptual and practical; and fallibility about <i>how</i> things appear does not license unperceivable entities	⚠️ Adequate for the flat-earth case, weak for heliocentrism; the hierarchy P over I is genuinely threatened
4	✅ Emergence does not explain subjectivity: redness and intoxication are public; consciousness is private, and "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard"	⚠️ Positing an immaterial soul renames the gap rather than closing it	⚠️ Both sides face the gap; the Cārvāka at least does not claim to have crossed it
5	✅ Dependence is not production: light is necessary for sight but is not its cause; the two horns of a bull are constantly conjoined but not causally related	⚠️ The instrument-hypothesis needs a user, and no user is perceived; materialism is the more economical of two unproven options	⚠️ Genuinely undecided; an honest answer says so
6	✅ Crude hedonism: no qualitative distinction among pleasures — "the pleasure of the pig"	⚠️ The <i>suśikṣita</i> strand, the sixty-four arts, and Vātsyāyana's prudential regulation of desire	⚠️ Supplies prudence and culture, not an independent standard of value
7	? Hostile sources make fair reconstruction impossible	⚠️ Convergence across Buddhist, Advaita, Jaina and Vedāntic doxographies fixes a doctrinal core	⚠️ Use caution without abandoning content
8	⚠️ Same-standpoint inconsistency (Sharma): perception is accepted and inference rejected at the same level, with no <i>vyāvahārika</i> / <i>pāramārthika</i> distinction available	⚠️ Adopt the level-distinction as a repair	⚠️ Effective, but the repair is the interpreter's, not the school's

Exam link

Use the complete 2018–2025 routing matrix and the 10/15/20-mark architecture. Every answer must end in a graded verdict tied to a named criterion.

Traps and recap

The synthesis-stage diagnostic questions are retained in the next section so that the complete Basic teaching remains separate from objective retrieval practice.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — ETHICS AND THE POLITICAL-SOCIAL MEANING — AND CĀRVĀKA VERSUS JAINA REALITY (2020, 15 MARKS)

SUBTOPIC: ETHICS AND THE POLITICAL-SOCIAL MEANING — AND CĀRVĀKA VERSUS JAINA REALITY (2020, 15 MARKS)

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: this-worldliness · pleasure (kāma) · material well-being (artha) ·

prudential hedonism · ritual critique · Jaina plural realism

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Hence hedonism. ✓ Dhūrta (cunning/crude) versus suśikṣita

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: This Cārvāka ethics may be called, therefore, hedonism or the theory

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: He "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Cārvāka (Indian materialist school) ethics is best read as prudent

this-worldly well-being rather than crude hedonism: pleasure is valuable, pain is a cost, and

action requires intelligent calculation within embodied social life.

SESSION 9 — ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVE DECODING AND THE GRADED VERDICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: answer architecture is the fixed route by which the Cārvāka material is converted into a script — epistemic rule first, ontology derived from it, one comparison, and a verdict tied to a named criterion.

Technical definition: a Cārvāka answer is an *epistemically generated* answer: the perception-only criterion is the premise, the four-element ontology, the body-self, the emergent account of awareness and the rejection of every supersensible entity are its consequences, and the evaluation therefore has to be conducted at the level of the criterion rather than at the level of the individual denials.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Cārvāka is best judged as a single argument rather than as a list of denials: restrict valid knowledge to perception, and the soul, moral residue (karma), rebirth, heaven, the creator and liberation follow out of the world together — which is why the school stands or falls with its epistemology and not with its reputation for pleasure.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- epistemically generated ontology
- standing opponent's position (pūrvapakṣa)
- criterion-named verdict
- warrant versus entailment
- doxographical reconstruction
- graded, not flat, evaluation

How to use them: open by naming the criterion, derive at least two denials from it, concede the strongest objection, then deliver a verdict that says *by which standard* Cārvāka succeeds and *by which standard* it fails.

Plain-language visual — one route, three lengths

ROUTE (same for every question)	LENGTH CONTROL
define + flag reconstruction	10 marks -> define -> derive ->
	one objection -> verdict
perception-only criterion	(about 150 words)
	15 marks -> reconstruct -> named
three doors + hidden condition	example -> criticism and
	reply -> evaluation
Nyāya reply, honestly stated	(about 250 words)
	20 marks -> full dialectic -> ONE
derived ontology and ethics	school comparison ->
	graded conclusion
ONE comparison, not four	(about 250-340 words)
verdict naming its criterion	

In simple words: the same spine carries every question; only the number of stops changes with the marks. Candidates lose marks by changing the route, not by writing too little.

Directive decoder — what each command word is actually testing

Directive	What is being tested	Structural move	Closing verdict to adapt
Discuss	Breadth with balance	Doctrine → basis in the means of valid knowledge → metaphysical consequences → one criticism	"Radical epistemic economy, not mere denial."
Examine	Internal logic	Trace how perception-only generates anti-inference and anti-transcendence	"The conclusion follows once the strict perceptual premise is granted."
Critically examine	Doctrine plus objections	Argument → Nyāya, Vedānta and Mīmāṃsā objections → replies	"Powerful as critique, unstable as a complete system."

Directive	What is being tested	Structural move	Closing verdict to adapt
Analyse	Component-wise logic	Break into means of knowledge, concomitance, hidden condition, testimony, ontology, ethics	"Its metaphysics is generated by its epistemology."
Evaluate	A final judgement	Weigh strengths, weaknesses and the contested source history	"Valuable negative philosophy; limited positive account."
Compare / Distinguish	Relation to another school	Fixed axes: knowledge, self, consciousness, moral residue, liberation	"Similarity at one point must not hide doctrinal difference."
Do you think / Do you agree?	A reasoned personal verdict	Doctrinal exposition first, qualified agreement second	"Agree with the critique of unwarranted transcendence, not with the total restriction."

How to write the paragraph — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Cārvāka's rejection of transcendent entities is not an independent metaphysical preference but the ontological consequence of a prior epistemic rule. **Named evidence.** The same template is applied to every item: the soul, moral residue (karma), heaven and the creator are all imperceptible, and the only routes to them — inference (anumāna) and testimony (śabda) — have already been refused independent standing, the first because invariable concomitance (vyāpti) cannot be secured and the second because it collapses into an inference about a speaker. **Analysis.** Because one criterion does all the work, the denials cannot be evaluated piecemeal; an opponent who saves inference recovers the whole supersensible order at once, which is exactly what Nyāya attempts by replacing omniscient certainty with disciplined warrant. **Qualification.** The verdict must therefore be graded: judged as a demand for indefeasible certainty the Cārvāka critique still stands, while judged as an account of how knowledge is actually secured it is too narrow to license even the reasoning by which it is defended.

Named evidence to keep in the memory bank

- **Chatterjee and Datta:** the school made itself a **touchstone** on which every other Indian system tested its theories.
- **C.D. Sharma:** "Materialism in Indian Philosophy has never been a force. Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought."
- **Sharma's other-minds point:** thoughts and ideas are never perceived, so the Cārvāka "can understand others only through inference".
- **The level-distinction Sharma denies him:** the everyday/ultimate (*vyāvahārika* / *pāramārthika*) contrast is "unknown to the Cārvāka".

The graded verdict — ready to adapt at three lengths

- **10 marks:** ⚠ Cārvāka is strongest as an epistemological protest against unverifiable metaphysics and weakest when the rejection of inference is made absolute.

- **15 marks:** ⚠ The perception-only principle explains the rejection of the soul, moral residue (karma), the creator and liberation with real economy, yet the self-refutation charge and the Nyāya reconstruction of concomitance show why it cannot stand as a complete theory of knowledge.
- **20 marks:** ⚠ The best verdict is layered: the dogmatic wing is vulnerable, the refined (*suśikṣita*) wing is a coherent empiricist restriction on supersensible inference, and Jayarāśi's wing is a serious destructive dialectic rather than crude materialism.

UPSC traps for this session

- ❌ Ending with a flat "Cārvāka is wrong" or "Cārvāka is right"; the marks live in the criterion that grades the judgement.
- ❌ Comparing with three or four schools in a 15-marker; one comparison argued properly beats four listed.
- ❌ Opening with the pleasure verse; the epistemology, not the ethics, is what generates the system.
- ❌ Treating the source problem as a disclaimer to be dropped after the first line rather than as a live control on what may be asserted.

Mini recap

One criterion → four elements → a body-self → no supersensible remainder → two human ends. Concede the Nyāya reply honestly, then grade the verdict by naming the standard you are using.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW — ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVE DECODING AND THE GRADED VERDICT

SUBTOPIC: ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVE DECODING AND THE GRADED VERDICT

KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS: epistemically generated ontology · standing opponent's position

(pūrvapakṣa) · criterion-named verdict · warrant versus entailment

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: one criterion generates every denial, so evaluation must be pitched at

the criterion and not at the individual denials

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Nyāya rescues the supersensible order in one move by exchanging

omniscient certainty for disciplined warrant

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: a flat verdict earns little; name the standard by which Cārvāka

succeeds and the standard by which it fails

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Cārvāka should be judged as a single argument rather than as a

list of denials, because restricting valid knowledge to perception removes the soul, moral

residue (karma), rebirth, heaven, the creator and liberation from the world together.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Enrichment only. A competent core answer does not require this block. Use it selectively for qualification, comparison, objections/replies and a higher-quality verdict after the Basic doctrine and answer structure are secure. Every substantive legacy Layer 3 point is retained below under the same nine subtopics.

1. Historical Reconstruction and the Source Problem

Advanced refinement

⚠ **Cārvāka was not marginal to Indian philosophy; it was structural.** Chatterjee and Datta make the point in their concluding section and it is worth reproducing as an evaluative sentence: "every system of Indian thought tried to meet the Cārvāka objections and made the Cārvāka a **touchstone** of its theories." They add that its value "lies directly in supplying fresh philosophical problems and indirectly in compelling other thinkers to give up dogmatism, and become critical and cautious in speculation as well as in the statement of views" — and they compare this to Kant's admission that "the scepticism of Hume roused me from my dogmatic slumber."

⚠ **Sharma's counterweight, which a balanced answer should also carry:** "Materialism in Indian Philosophy has never been a force. Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought." The two verdicts are not contradictory: Cārvāka failed as a *positive system* while succeeding as a *critical function*. That two-sided judgement is exactly the graded verdict UPSC rewards.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 The reconstruction problem here belongs to a general class: how to state fairly a position preserved only in the words of those who rejected it. The same methodological question arises in reading the Greek Sophists through Plato, or the Presocratics through Aristotle. ⚠ Use this as a *methodological* remark of one sentence. It is a conceptual parallel, **not** a dated development, and it must never be written as though it were news.

2. Epistemology — Perception as the Sole *Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*

Advanced refinement

⚠ **Cārvāka's scepticism is *selective*, and Sharma turns that selectivity into an objection.** Śūnyavāda Buddhism and Advaita Vedānta also reject the *ultimate* validity of inference — but, as Sharma notes, "the Śūnyavādin and the Advaitin reject the ultimate validity of **all** means of knowledge as such **including perception**, though they insist on the empirical validity of all means of knowledge. The distinction between ultimate and empirical knowledge is **unknown to the Cārvāka**. To accept the validity of perception and, at the same time and from the same standpoint, to reject the validity of inference is a thoughtless self-contradiction."

⚠ This gives you a **three-way comparison** that very few candidates will produce:

School	Perception	Inference	Level-distinction available?
Cārvāka	✅ Valid, full stop	❌ Rejected, full stop	❌ None — hence Sharma's charge of "same standpoint" inconsistency
Śūnyavāda	⚠ Empirically valid, ultimately not	⚠ Empirically valid, ultimately not	✅ <i>Samṃṛti</i> / <i>paramārtha</i>
Advaita	⚠ <i>Vyāvahārika</i> validity only	⚠ <i>Vyāvahārika</i> validity only	✅ <i>Vyāvahārika</i> / <i>pāramārthika</i>

⚠ **The Cārvāka's best available repair**, and you should offer it before evaluating: *adopt the level-distinction*. If the Cārvāka says "inference has *vyāvahārika* usefulness but no *pāramārthika* validity", Sharma's charge of same-standpoint inconsistency loses its grip — at the price of conceding that the doctrine is a thesis about certainty rather than about usability. That is precisely the softened reading defended in Subtopic 3.

🔗 Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

🔗 The Cārvāka analysis of *verbal testimony* (*śabda*) — that a hearer's acceptance of testimony always runs through a suppressed premise about the speaker's reliability — is the ancestor of the modern **reductionist** position in the epistemology of testimony, and it is the exact point at issue in contemporary debates about credibility and misinformation. ⚠ Label it as a conceptual parallel in a single clause if at all; do not import modern examples into a Paper I answer in place of *perception* (*pratyakṣa*), *inference* (*anumāna*) and *verbal testimony* (*śabda*), and do not present it as a dated event.

3. The Critique of Inference — *Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)*, *Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)*, the Socrates Syllogism and Self-Refutation

📚 Advanced refinement

⚠ **Distinguish two Cārvāka claims that are constantly run together in scripts:**

```
CLAIM A (epistemic) : inference does not GUARANTEE truth
                      -> defensible; almost universally granted today
CLAIM B (semantic/  : the words "wherever smoke, there fire" express
ontological)        no knowable proposition at all
                      -> far stronger; hard to hold while doing philosophy
```

⚠ Most of the force of the Cārvāka critique lives in Claim A. Most of the vulnerability to self-refutation lives in Claim B. A first-class answer separates them and says which one it is defending.

⚠ **A further refinement on the target.** The Cārvāka's practical inferences are always **perceptually redeemable**: I infer fire, I climb the hill, I see fire. Transcendental inferences are **structurally unredeemable**: I infer heaven from *agnihotra*, and no perception could ever cash the claim. The Cārvāka's

position becomes far more defensible when stated as: *an inference is worth something to the extent that its conclusion is in principle perceptually checkable* — which is a verificationist criterion in Indian dress, and is exactly the material needed for the 2024 "positivism" question.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 The *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*) argument is a strikingly early and complete statement of what Western philosophy calls **the problem of induction**: that no finite set of observations entails an unrestricted universal, and that attempts to justify induction inductively are circular. The *hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*) argument anticipates the modern problem of **confounding variables** — the possibility that an observed regularity tracks an unnoticed third factor. ⚠️ These are conceptual parallels for one clause of comparative colour, not dated developments, and they must never displace the Indian vocabulary in a Paper I script.

4. The Nyāya Defence of Inference — and a Critically Balanced Verdict

Advanced refinement

⚠️ **What the debate is really about, stated at the highest level.** Both sides agree that finite observation cannot logically entail an unrestricted universal. They disagree about what follows.

CARVAKA	:	entailment fails	=>	no knowledge	=>	no pramana-status
NYAYA	:	entailment fails	=>	but WARRANT does not require entailment		
			=>	disciplined procedure yields knowledge		
			=>	pramana-status is preserved		

⚠️ The disagreement is therefore about the **concept of knowledge**, not about the logic of induction, on which the two are in near-agreement. Writing that sentence identifies the true locus of the dispute and is the mark of a top script.

⚠️ **The honest residue against Nyāya**, which a balanced answer must supply so as not to look partisan: (i) *hypothetical reasoning* (*tarka*) is admittedly not a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*) and cannot by itself establish anything; (ii) *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* is defensible only inside Nyāya's realism about universals, so it is not a neutral answer; (iii) the elimination of *upādhis* is always elimination of **suspected** conditions, never a proof that none remains. Nyāya's inference is therefore highly disciplined but not indefeasible — which is precisely what a fallibilist Cārvāka wanted to hear.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 Nyāya's replacement of certainty by disciplined warrant, with negative-case testing and the systematic elimination of confounders, is conceptually parallel to modern accounts of **inference under uncertainty** — controlled comparison, elimination of alternative explanations, and degrees of confirmation rather than proof. ⚠️ Use at most one clause of this in an answer, explicitly as a conceptual analogy, never as a dated development or as authority.

5. Metaphysics and Materialism — Four *Bhūtas*, the Rejection of *Ākāśa*, and Explanation through natural properties (*svabhāvavāda*)

Advanced refinement

⚠️ **Cārvāka materialism is not modern scientific materialism, and saying why is worth marks.**

Axis	Cārvāka	Modern scientific materialism
Basic entities	✅ Four perceptible gross elements	Unobservable micro-entities: fields, particles, forces
Attitude to inference	✅ Denies it <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i> -status	Depends on it absolutely — theory is inference from data
Attitude to unobservables	✅ Refuses them as unwarranted	Admits them freely when they earn their explanatory keep
Method	⚠️ Polemical minimalism	Experiment, prediction, controlled testing, revision
Status of laws	⚠️ <i>Svabhāva</i> , with no guarantee of future uniformity	Law-like regularities, projectible and quantified

⚠️ **The resulting paradox, which is the best single sentence in this subtopic:** *Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas modern materialism reaches a materialist conclusion by a thoroughly inferential route. The agreement in ontology conceals a total disagreement in method.* That sentence is the pivot of any good answer on whether Cārvāka is "scientific" or "positivistic".

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 *Emergent consciousness from material elements (bhūta-caitanya-vāda)* is an early statement of what is now called **emergent physicalism**, and the objection pressed above — that redness and intoxicating power are third-person properties whereas consciousness is first-personal — is recognisably the modern **explanatory gap** objection. ⚠️ This is a conceptual parallel offered for one clause of comparative framing. It is not a dated development, it carries no authority, and in a Paper I script it must never displace *bhūta*, *caitanya*, *svabhāva* and the betel and fermentation analogies.

6. Self, Body and Consciousness — *Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)*, and Cārvāka versus Buddhist *Anātman* (2024, 20 marks)

Advanced refinement

⚠️ **The point almost no candidate makes, and it is decisive.** Buddhism's *anātman* is **not** a weaker version of Cārvāka's denial; it is a **wider** one. *Rūpa* — material form — is itself one of the five *skandhas*, and is expressly declared not to be self. The Buddhist analysis therefore rules out the Cārvāka's body-self *by name*. Writing this sentence demonstrates that you understand the doctrines rather than the labels: *for the Buddhist, "I am this body" is one of the very identifications that anātman is formulated to dismantle.*

⚠️ **A second refinement: the Puggalavāda foil.** The authored Buddhism file records that some Buddhists, associated with the Vātsīputrīyas, posited a *pudgala* "neither the same as nor different from the *skandhas*", and that the mainstream criticised this as a relapse towards self-theory. ⚠️ Use this to show that the pressure to preserve a bearer of moral continuity was felt *inside* Buddhism, and was refused — which makes the contrast with Cārvāka, who simply keeps a bearer and makes it material, doubly instructive.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 The Cārvāka–Buddhist–Nyāya triangle is the Indian version of the contemporary three-cornered debate between **substance dualism**, **reductive physicalism** and **bundle or process theories of the self**.

 Note it in a clause if it helps frame the answer; it is a conceptual parallel only, not a dated development, and the Sanskrit vocabulary must carry the answer.

7. The Rejection of Transcendent Entities — God, Soul, Action and moral consequence (karma), Rebirth, Heaven, Liberation (mokṣa), Veda and Ritual

Advanced refinement

 Cārvāka's atheism is structurally different from every other Indian denial of God, and this comparison is high-value in Paper I and Paper II alike.

School	Denies a creator God because	Accepts inference (anumāna)?	Accepts scriptural authority?
Cārvāka	✓ No means of valid knowledge (<i>pramāṇa</i>) establishes him, and <i>svabhāva</i> suffices	✗ No	✗ No
Sāṃkhya	✓ Primordial material nature (<i>prakṛti</i>) explains evolution; a God is superfluous and would compromise <i>conscious witness (puruṣa)</i> 's inactivity	✓ Yes	✓ Yes
Mīmāṃsā	✓ The Veda is <i>apauruṣeya</i> and <i>apūrva</i> matures without a dispenser	✓ Yes	✓ Yes — supremely
Jainism	✓ The world is uncreated; action and moral consequence (karma) is material and self-operating; but godhood is attained by the liberated soul	✓ Yes	✗ Rejects Vedic authority
Buddhism	✓ Dependent origination explains arising; an immutable cause cannot yield succession	✓ Yes	✗ Rejects Vedic authority

 **The resulting single sentence, which is worth memorising:** *Cārvāka is the only Indian school whose atheism is generated by its epistemology rather than by its cosmology or its soteriology — which is why it also rejects the action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth and liberation that Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain.* Non-theism is common in Indian philosophy; **this-worldliness is Cārvāka's alone.**

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 The demand that a postulate be in principle checkable, and the treatment of unfalsifiable claims as unwarranted rather than merely unproved, is conceptually parallel to modern **scientific scepticism** and to verificationist criteria of meaning. ⚠ Offer this as a labelled conceptual parallel only, and be careful: the parallel is exactly what makes the 2024 "positivism" question tempting *and* what makes an unqualified "yes" to it wrong, since Cārvāka rejects the very inferential machinery on which modern science runs.

8. Ethics and the Political-Social Meaning — and Cārvāka versus Jaina Reality (2020, 15 marks)

Advanced refinement

⚠ **Was Cārvāka a social philosophy?** Two pieces of evidence, both from Chatterjee and Datta, suggest more than pure appetite: the incorporation of *daṇḍanīti* (political philosophy, the science of governance) and *vārttā* (economics, the science of livelihood) into the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas; and the report that some Cārvākas "regard the **king as God**". ⚠ The natural reading is a **secular theory of political authority**: order is guaranteed not by cosmic *dharma* or divine sanction but by the sovereign, and prosperity by the productive arts. ? The evidence is thin and doxographical, and must be presented as suggestive rather than established — but it is precisely the material that saves a Cārvāka answer from ending in caricature, and it directly supports the "secular" half of the 2024 label.

⚠ **A final ethical refinement.** Cārvāka's ethics lacks two things that every rival supplies: a **qualitative** distinction among pleasures (Sharma's "pleasure of the pig") and an account of **other-regarding** obligation. Vātsyāyana supplies a partial answer to the first through cultivation and the fine arts, and Chatterjee and Datta gesture at the second through the necessity of social discipline and the king. But neither is derived from the Cārvāka's own value theory; both are added to it. ⚠ **The honest verdict:** Cārvāka's ethics is a fully coherent theory of *prudence* and an incomplete theory of *morality*.

Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

 Cārvāka's grounding of value in embodied pleasure and pain, without supernatural sanction, is conceptually parallel to modern **secular and naturalistic ethics**; and the *dhūrta* / *suśikṣita* distinction mirrors the Western contrast between crude and refined, or quantitative and qualitative, hedonism. ⚠ Conceptual parallel only, offered in a clause; not a dated development, and never a substitute for *puruṣārtha*, *pleasure (kāma)*, *material well-being (artha)* and the Sanskrit sources.

9. Comparative Synthesis and Answer-Writing Architecture

3. Five verdicts you may safely defend

⚠ Each of these is defensible, criterion-named and examiner-friendly. Choose according to the question.

1. "Cārvāka's epistemology is more successful as a critique of certainty than as a theory of knowledge."
2. "Cārvāka's ontology is impeccably derived from its epistemology; its vulnerability is therefore located entirely in that epistemology, not in its metaphysics."

3. "Cārvāka wins the argument that finite observation cannot entail an unrestricted universal, and loses the argument that this abolishes inference as a means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*) — because Nyāya replaces the demand for omniscient certainty with a demand for disciplined warrant."
4. "Cārvāka denies the transcendence of the self while retaining its substantiality; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its moral continuity. The two denials are not species of one genus."
5. "Cārvāka is a complete theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality; its historical value is critical rather than constructive — it was, as Chatterjee and Datta put it, the touchstone on which every other system tested itself."

4. Is Cārvāka positivistic? — the full treatment of the 2024 demand

⚠ The question ("Do you think Cārvāka's philosophy is positivistic in nature? Give reasons and justifications") invites a **graded** answer. A flat yes or a flat no both lose marks. Structure it as three movements.

⚠ **Movement 1 — establish that the label is not imported by the examiner.** ✅ Chatterjee and Datta apply it themselves: "The Cārvāka theory on the whole may also be called **positivism**, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena." They also compare its view of inference to that of "the pragmatists and logical positivists". This is a decisive evidential point: you are not being asked to invent a comparison, you are being asked to test one already present in the tradition of exposition.

⚠ **Movement 2 — the case for the label:**

Respect	Cārvāka	Positivism
Criterion of the knowable	✅ Only what is presented in perception	Only what is empirically verifiable
Attitude to metaphysics	✅ Transcendent entities are rejected as unwarranted	Metaphysical statements are rejected as unverifiable
Attitude to theology	✅ God and afterlife have no <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i>	Theological statements are cognitively empty
Attitude to authority	✅ Scripture is not an independent source	Revelation is not evidence
Register of dismissal	⚠ Questions about rebirth and heaven become "meaningless" (Chatterjee and Datta's word)	Unverifiable statements are meaningless
Value theory	✅ Naturalistic, this-worldly, consequential	Naturalistic and anti-transcendent

⚠ **Movement 3 — the case against, and it is the stronger half:**

Respect	Cārvāka	Positivism
Inference	✅ Denied <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i>-status — the fatal divergence	Depends utterly on inference; science <i>is</i> systematised inference
Unobservables	✅ Refused	Freely admitted when they earn their explanatory keep

Respect	Cārvāka	Positivism
Programme	⚠️ Polemical minimalism; no method of confirmation	A constructive programme: unified science, criteria of significance, logical analysis
Tools	⚠️ None of formal logic, semantics or probability	Formal logic, verification and confirmation theory, language analysis
Comte's specific content	⚠️ Absent	Law of three stages, sociology, a philosophy of history
Fallibilism	⚠️ Demands indubitability, then finds nothing meets it	Accepts corrigible, revisable knowledge as the norm

⚠️ **The verdict formula.** *Cārvāka is positivistic in spirit — in its empiricist criterion, its anti-metaphysical temper and its suspicion of unverifiable authority, a resemblance Chatterjee and Datta themselves note. It is not positivistic in method, because positivism is built on the very inference Cārvāka refuses to certify, and possesses a constructive programme that Cārvāka wholly lacks. The safer and more accurate label is radical empiricism or naturalistic materialism; "positivism" is a useful analogy, not a historical identity.* ⚠️ Add the paradox from Subtopic 5: Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas positivism reaches its conclusions by a thoroughly inferential one.

5. India and the West — convergence and divergence

Western figure or movement	Convergence with Cārvāka ⚠️	Divergence ⚠️
Epicurus / Lucretius	Materialist atomism; this-worldly ethics; freedom from fear of the gods and of death	Epicurus offers <i>ataraxia</i> and a theory of prudent, qualitatively ordered pleasure; Cārvāka as transmitted offers no such refinement — though the <i>suśikṣita</i> strand approaches it
Hume	Induction cannot be rationally justified; causal relation is not perceived	Hume grounds inference in custom and treats it as psychologically indispensable, retaining it as knowledge; Cārvāka denies it <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i> -status outright
Logical positivism (Ayer)	Suspicion of unverifiable metaphysics; the "meaningless" register	Ayer preserves scientific inference and analyses meaning through formal tools absent in India
Comte	Rejection of theological explanation in favour of observable phenomena	Comte's positivism is a philosophy of history and a science of society; Cārvāka has neither
Contemporary physicalism	Consciousness as arising from material organisation	Modern physicalism is inference-driven and posits unobservables freely

⚠️ **Chatterjee and Datta's own comparative line, which is safe to quote in substance:** the criticism of inference put in the Cārvāka's mouth "reminds us of similar criticism made in modern times against the soundness of deductive logic", and the Cārvāka view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the pragmatists and logical positivists." They also compare the school's fate to that of the Epicureans of Greece, who "have been more hated than understood".

Canonical cross-school and answer-depth ledgers

6A. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER ⚠️

Doctrine	Presupposition	What collapses if denied
Perception as sole means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	Immediate presentation is the only secure mark of knowledge	The entire anti-inference and anti-scripture programme loses its foundation
Invariable concomitance (vyāpti) critique	Universality must be certain, not merely probable, to ground pramāṇa-status	Inference (anumāna) can be rehabilitated as disciplined fallible knowledge
Hidden limiting condition (upādhi) problem	Hidden conditions can always qualify observed regularities	Nyāya-style upādhi-elimination can secure reliable universals
Rejection of verbal testimony (śabda)	Words require independent proof of speaker competence and truth	Veda, reliable testimony, and social knowledge regain pramāṇa-status
Four bhūtas and rejection of ākāśa	Only perceptibly grounded elements are ontologically admissible	A fifth element can be inferred from sound or spatial accommodation
Bhūta-caitanya / emergent consciousness	Consciousness can arise from organized material elements	A non-material self or consciousness-substance becomes necessary
Rejection of action and moral consequence (karma) and rebirth	No unseen moral continuity is perceptually established	Dharma, rebirth, and liberation-soteriology regain metaphysical force
Explanation through natural properties (svabhāva-vāda)	Observable natures are enough to explain regularity	Divine will, adṛṣṭa, action and moral consequence (karma), or teleology may be invoked as deeper explanation
Hedonist ethics	Value must be anchored in embodied this-worldly experience	Dharma and liberation (mokṣa) can override pleasure (kāma) and material well-being (artha)
Rejection of liberation (mokṣa)	Bondage and liberation require an unproved self and post-mortem destiny	The whole puruṣārtha scheme beyond worldly life becomes defensible

6B. OPPONENT'S PRIMA-FACIE POSITION (pūrvapakṣa)–ESTABLISHED CONCLUSION (siddhānta) LEDGER ⚠️

Objector	Objection	Cārvāka reply	Residual force ⚠️
Nyāya	Self-refutation: rejection of inference is itself inferential. Invariable concomitance (vyāpti) is securable through upādhi-elimination, hypothetical reasoning (tarka) , and sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa . The self is proved because desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain, and cognition inhere in a substance.	Dogmatic wing: inference never reaches certainty because invariable concomitance (vyāpti) cannot be secured. Sceptical/Jayarāśi wing: the Naiyāyika's own definitions fail from within. ⚠️	Nyāya gives the strongest systematic defence of inference; Cārvāka must either soften or face self-refutation.

Objector	Objection	Cārvāka reply	Residual force ⚠
Buddhism	Action and moral consequence (karma) and rebirth are accepted without eternal enduring self (ātman); momentariness does not imply materialism. Buddhists also accept inference as valid.	⚠ Reconstructed reply: rebirth and action and moral consequence (karma) still outrun perception; momentary streams are as unseen as souls when used to explain post-mortem continuity.	Buddhism avoids eternal soul while preserving moral continuity, making it a subtler opponent than theism.
Jainism	Consciousness cannot be a property of elements because elements individually lack it; an emergent property needs a bearer.	⚠ Reconstructed reply: combinations may display novel properties absent in parts; positing individual self (jīva) adds an unperceived substance.	Emergence is asserted more than explained; Jaina pluralism exposes the bearer-problem.
Advaita / Vedānta	Consciousness is self-luminous; the body is known by consciousness, so it cannot be the source of consciousness.	⚠ Reconstructed reply: "self-luminosity" is a metaphysical description of experienced awareness, not proof of a disembodied enduring self (ātman).	The subject-object problem remains hard for materialist emergence.
Mīmāṃsā	The Veda's authority is intrinsic; ridicule of ritual is not an argument against apauruṣeyatva or dharma.	Dogmatic reply: intrinsic authority is not perceived; testimony needs proof, and ritual results are unseen. ⚠	Mīmāṃsā has a sophisticated theory of language and obligation; satire alone is insufficient.
Yoga / Sāṃkhya	Conscious witness (puruṣa) is distinct from primordial material nature (prakṛti); experience, agency, and liberation require a consciousness-principle beyond matter.	⚠ Reconstructed reply: conscious witness (puruṣa) is not perceived apart from embodied awareness; liberation is a projection from metaphysical dualism.	Cārvāka struggles to explain witness-consciousness, discipline, and the felt distinction between body and awareness.

6C. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING ⚠

A. Knowledge, self and continuity

School	Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)	Self	Consciousness	Action and moral consequence (karma)/rebirth
Cārvāka	Perception (pratyakṣa) alone in strict doctrine; lokasiddha inference only as practical habit ⚠	Body-self; no surviving enduring self (ātman)	Emergent bhūta-caitanya	Rejected
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	Perception, inference, comparison, testimony	Enduring ātman-substance	Quality of self, revealed through cognition	Accepted
Buddhism	Varies; perception and inference central in epistemological schools	No enduring self (ātman)	Stream of momentary consciousness/events	Accepted without eternal self

School	Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)	Self	Consciousness	Action and moral consequence (karma)/rebirth
Jainism	Multiple means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) with standpoint theory	Plural individual self (jīvas)	Intrinsic to individual self (jīva), obscured by action and moral consequence (karma)	Accepted
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	Perception, inference, reliable testimony	Conscious witness (puruṣa) distinct from primordial material nature (prakṛti)	Conscious witness (puruṣa) as pure consciousness	Accepted
Mīmāṃsā	Perception, inference, comparison, postulation, non-cognition, verbal testimony (śabda) in developed lists	Enduring self	Attribute/manifestation tied to self	Accepted
Advaita Vedānta	Six means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) commonly accepted, with śruti decisive for Brahman	Enduring self (ātman) identical with Brahman	Self-luminous consciousness	Empirical-level acceptance

B. Authority, value and liberation

School	Scripture	God	Puruṣārthas	Liberation
Cārvāka	Rejected as independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	Rejected	Pleasure (kāma) and material well-being (artha) emphasized; dharma/liberation (mokṣa) rejected	Rejected
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	Accepted as reliable testimony	Generally affirmed in later Nyāya	All four	Release (apavarga)
Buddhism	Buddhist teaching accepted within its framework	Creator-God denied	Path-oriented revaluation	Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa)
Jainism	Jaina teaching authoritative	Creator-God denied	Ethical-spiritual discipline	Liberation (mokṣa) of individual self (jīva)
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	Accepted	Classical Sāṃkhya non-theistic; Yoga admits Lord (Īśvara)	All four subordinated to release	Isolation (kaivalya)
Mīmāṃsā	Veda intrinsically authoritative	Creator-God not central	Dharma central	Often secondary to ritual/dharma, varies
Advaita Vedānta	Upaniṣadic śruti decisive	Lord (Īśvara) at empirical level	Liberation (mokṣa) supreme	Liberation through knowledge

School	Scripture	God	Puruṣārthas	Liberation
Why Cārvāka matters structurally. ⚠️ Cārvāka is the standing opponent's prima-facie position (pūrvapakṣa) of Indian philosophy. Nyāya clarifies invariable concomitance (vyāpti) by answering it; Mīmāṃsā sharpens Vedic authority against it; Buddhism and Jainism defend action and moral consequence (karma) without crude eternalism; Vedānta defends self-luminosity against body-materialism. Knowing Cārvāka well therefore improves answers on means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), scripture, action and moral consequence (karma), self, and liberation across the whole Indian syllabus.				

6D. CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON ⚠️

Western comparator	Point of contact	Decisive disanalogy
Hume	Both question whether observed conjunctions establish necessary universal connection; both are suspicious of metaphysical entities such as substance, soul, and God when they outrun impressions/perception.	Hume does not deny that we should reason inductively; he denies its rational-demonstrative foundation while treating custom as the great guide of life. Cārvāka draws the stronger normative conclusion that inference is not a means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa). Hume targets necessary connexion through impressions and ideas; Cārvāka targets invariable concomitance (vyāpti) through regress and hidden limiting condition (upādhi). Hume's bundle view of self differs from Cārvāka's positive conscious body as self (dehātmavāda), and Hume has a developed moral psychology unlike Cārvāka hedonism.

Western comparator	Point of contact	Decisive disanalogy
A.J. Ayer / logical positivism	Both reject metaphysics on experience-linked grounds and dismiss God, soul, and afterlife when not verifiable.	Ayer's claim is semantic: unverifiable metaphysics is meaningless, neither true nor false. Cārvāka's claim is epistemic/ontological: such entities are not known and therefore not admitted. Ayer preserves scientific theoretical statements through indirect/weak verifiability; strict Cārvāka anti-inference threatens science too. Ayer's verification principle is charged with self-refutation, paralleling the self-refutation charge against Cārvāka.
Epicurus / Lucretius	Materialism, rejection of fear-based religion, and this-worldly pleasure make the comparison tempting.	Epicurean pleasure is ascetic and calculative, aiming at ataraxia (tranquillity); Cārvāka hedonism is usually presented as straightforward embodied enjoyment, though a refined prudential reading is possible.
Pyrrhonism / Jayarāṣi	Jayarāṣi's sceptical wing and Pyrrhonism both allow ordinary life to continue after suspension or collapse of foundations.	Pyrrhonism seeks tranquillity through epochē (suspension), whereas Jayarāṣi works through pramāṇa-definition destruction within Indian debate; do not merge the traditions.
Feuerbach / Marx on religion's social function	Cārvāka's charge that ritual is the livelihood of priests anticipates a functional critique of religion as serving human/social interests.	Feuerbach and Marx build broader theories of projection, alienation, ideology, and society. Cārvāka offers sharp anti-ritual polemic without a historical-materialist theory.
Locke / general empiricism	Knowledge must be tied to experience; innate or purely speculative metaphysical claims are distrusted.	Locke and most empiricists accept abstraction, probability, testimony, and science-friendly inference. Cārvāka's strict pratyakṣa-only thesis is much narrower and more disruptive.

Rubric. ⚠️ Western parallels are illustrative only, never a substitute for the Indian argument, and belong in at most one or two lines **after** the Cārvāka case is complete. These are conceptual analogies, not historical influences. Writing "Cārvāka is the Indian Hume" without stating the disanalogies is a marked weakness.

6E. DIRECTIVE DECODER ⚠️

Directive	What the examiner is testing	Structural move for a Cārvāka answer	Closing verdict
Discuss	Breadth and balanced presentation	State doctrine → explain means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) basis → show metaphysical consequences → add one criticism	"Cārvāka is best read as radical epistemic economy, not mere denial."

Directive	What the examiner is testing	Structural move for a Cārvāka answer	Closing verdict
Examine	Internal logic	Trace how pratyakṣa-only leads to anti-inference and anti-transcendence	"The conclusion follows if its strict perceptual premise is accepted."
Critically examine	Doctrine plus objections	Present Cārvāka argument, then Nyāya/Vedānta/Mīmāṃsā objections and replies	"Powerful as critique, unstable as complete system."
Analyse	Component-wise causal logic	Break into means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), invariable concomitance (vyāpti), hidden limiting condition (upādhi), verbal testimony (śabda), ontology, ethics	"Its metaphysics is generated by epistemology."
Evaluate	Final judgement required	Weigh strengths, weaknesses, and contested source-history	"Valuable negative philosophy; limited positive account."
Compare	Relation with another school	Use fixed axes: means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), self, consciousness, action and moral consequence (karma), liberation	"Similarity at one point must not hide doctrinal difference."
Distinguish	Sharp contrasts	Define both terms/schools first, then contrast on 4–5 axes	"The safest answer is difference plus one connecting insight."
Elucidate / Comment / Bring out	Clarity of explanation	Give thesis, one argument, one example, one implication	"This shows why the doctrine matters in the larger system."
Do you agree?	Reasoned personal verdict	State qualified agreement/disagreement after doctrinal exposition	"Agree with its critique of unwarranted transcendence, not with its total means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) restriction."
"Cārvāka's rejection of X is self-refuting — critically examine"	Ability to handle the recurring self-refutation pattern	Show why the dogmatic wing is vulnerable; then introduce lokasiddha inference and Jayarāṣi's prasaṅga-style escape route	"The charge is decisive only against an absolute denial of all reasoning; it is weaker against refined empiricism or dialectical scepticism."

6F. GRADED VERDICT ON CĀRVĀKA ⚠️

Strong ✅ - A genuine early principle of epistemic economy: do not multiply unseen entities without warrant. - A real and still powerful problem about the warrant for universals and invariable concomitance (vyāpti). - A valuable naturalistic check on speculative metaphysics, ritualism, and unverifiable claims. - A functional critique of ritual religion as serving priestly livelihood rather than truth. - In Jayarāṣi, a serious dialectical scepticism that can challenge every pramāṇa-definition from within.

Weak ⚠️ - The self-refutation problem is serious for the dogmatic wing. - Explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda) gives no full account of why natures are stable. - Bhūta-caitanya asserts emergence but does not adequately explain subjectivity. - The ethics cannot easily distinguish prudence from impulse unless reconstructed charitably.

Genuinely contested ? - What the school actually held, because no primary systematic text of the materialist wing survives. - Whether dhūrta and suśikṣita Cārvāka name real internal schools or hostile doxographical types. - Whether yadṛcchāvāda belongs to Cārvāka or is a distinct aheturvāda option. - Whether Jayarāśi is properly a Cārvāka or an allied radical sceptic.

Ready verdicts. ⚠️ - **10 marks:** Cārvāka is strongest as an epistemological protest against unverifiable metaphysics, but weakest when its rejection of inference becomes absolute. - **15 marks:** Its pratyakṣa-only principle powerfully explains the rejection of enduring self (ātman), action and moral consequence (karma), Lord (Īśvara), and liberation (mokṣa); yet Nyāya's self-refutation and invariable concomitance (vyāpti) replies show why it cannot stand as a complete theory of knowledge. - **20 marks:** The best verdict is graded: dogmatic Cārvāka is vulnerable, refined Cārvāka is a coherent empiricist restriction on supersensible inference, and Jayarāśi's wing is a serious prasaṅga-style scepticism rather than crude materialism.

Anti-caricature warning. ✅ A strong UPSC answer presents Cārvāka as a serious epistemological position and standing opponent's prima-facie position (pūrvapakṣa), not as mere hedonism or a stock joke about pleasure.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

A. Source status

- The *Bṛhaspati-sūtra* is lost.
- Most doctrine survives through refutational doxographies.
- Convergence supports a recoverable core, but exact quotation requires caution.
- Jayarāśi is a sceptical witness associated with the stream, not a simple manual of standard doctrine.

B. Epistemic thesis

- Standard reconstruction: perception alone is an independent *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*).
- External and internal perception ground ordinary cognition.
- Testimony depends on prior trust and is not independently self-validating.
- Practical expectation may be admitted without granting certain inference.

C. Critique of inference

- Inference requires universal *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*).
- Perception cannot survey all times, places and cases.
- Inference cannot prove *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*) without circularity or regress.
- Testimony cannot rescue inference if testimony itself depends on inference.

D. Hidden limiting condition (upādhi) and self-refutation

- Hidden conditions defeat over-broad universals.
- The Socrates syllogism is formally valid but its universal premise remains epistemically contested.
- Absolute denial of inference appears self-refuting.
- A softened reading restricts secure inference, especially about supersensible entities.

E. Nyāya reply

- Repeated agreement and difference establish provisional concomitance.
- Elimination of suspected conditions and *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* strengthen *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)*.
- Universal-character perception and *parāmarśa* explain inferential cognition.
- Nyāya offers disciplined warrant, not omniscient enumeration.

F. Material reality

- Four perceptible elements: earth, water, fire and air.
- Ether is rejected because it is imperceptible.
- *Explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* explains natural processes without transcendent agency.
- Modern scientific materialism must not be read back into the ancient position.

G. Self and consciousness

- *Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)*: the conscious living body is the self.
- Consciousness emerges from material combination, often illustrated through fermentation or betel.
- Death ends the individual because no separable soul remains.
- The explanatory gap between matter and subjectivity remains a serious objection.

H. Transcendent denials

- No independently established enduring self (ātman), Lord (Īśvara), action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth, heaven, hell or liberation (mokṣa).
- Vedic authority and sacrificial claims fail the perceptual test.
- Withholding assent and categorical denial should be distinguished.
- The epistemology drives the metaphysical rejection.

I. Ethics

- *Material well-being (artha)* is the practical means and *pleasure (kāma)* the operative end.
- Pleasure is not automatically momentary recklessness; consequences are perceptible.
- Famous “borrow ghee” style verses require source caution.
- Cārvāka is a this-worldly ethic, not merely an invitation to vice.

J. Comparative map

Comparison	Cārvāka	Rival
Jainism	four-element materialism	many-sided realist pluralism
Buddhism	body-self materialism	no-self process theory
Nyāya	perception-only challenge	four means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) and inference defence
Vedānta	no transcendent self	self/Brahman as fundamental

K. Labels and evaluation

- “Positivistic” is defensible only as qualified anti-metaphysical empiricism.
- “Naturalistic” fits the rejection of supernatural explanation.
- “Materialist” is central; “scientific materialist” is anachronistic.
- The strongest achievement is epistemic protest; the weakest point is absolute anti-inferentialism.

L. Final answer discipline

1. Begin with the hostile-source qualification.
2. State the perception-only thesis precisely.
3. Reconstruct the *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)/hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* argument in steps.
4. Connect epistemology to materialism and transcendent denials.
5. Present the strongest version before criticism.
6. Add the Nyāya reply or relevant comparative school.
7. End with a graded verdict: powerful critique, incomplete positive epistemology.

Final judgement: Cārvāka is best read as a disciplined empiricist and materialist challenge to unsupported transcendence. Its historical source problem demands caution, and its absolute rejection of inference remains internally unstable.

Detailed inherited nine-subtopic register

Register-last rule satisfied. The first matrix separates what is required for a core answer from what is optional enrichment. The detailed nine-register legacy revision set follows, preserving source cautions, Sanskrit terminology, argument spines, comparisons, PYQ routes and rapid recall.

CORE BASIC versus OPTIONAL ADVANCED — nine-subtopic recall matrix

Subtopic	CORE BASIC — required for a competent answer	OPTIONAL ADVANCED — enrichment only

- | 1. Source problem | Lost *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*; hostile doxography; convergent core; cautious use of Jayarāśi. | Selective transmission; Cārvāka as structural *opponent's prima-facie position (pūrvapakṣa)* and critical touchstone. |
- | 2. Sole means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) | *Perception (pratyakṣa)* alone; external/internal perception; testimony derivative; practical expectation is not certainty. | Strong versus softened thesis; possible level-distinction is a repair, not secure historical doctrine. |
- | 3. Inference critique | *Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* cannot be secured by perception, inference or testimony; *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* threatens universality. | Problem of induction; perceptual redeemability; self-refutation repairs and residual pressure. |
- | 4. Nyāya defence | *Anvaya-vyatireka*, suspected-*hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* elimination, *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)*, *sāmānyalakṣaṇa*, *parāmarśa*. | Knowledge as disciplined warrant rather than entailment; Nyāya remains fallible, not indefeasible. |
- | 5. Materialism | Four *bhūtas*, no *ākāśa*; *bhūta-caitanya*; betel/fermentation; *svabhāva*. | Emergentism and explanatory gap; anti-inferential materialism differs from modern scientific materialism. |
- | 6. Body-self | *Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)*; conscious living body; first-person predicates; death ends the individual. | Personal identity, privacy, instrument-versus-cause objection, Buddhist process comparison and Puggalavāda foil. |
- | 7. Transcendent denials | No *enduring self (ātman)*, *Lord (Īśvara)*, *action and moral consequence (karma)*, *adṛṣṭa*, rebirth, heaven, hell, *liberation (mokṣa)* or Vedic authority. | Withholding versus denial; ritual reductios; epistemic atheism versus other Indian non-theisms. |
- | 8. Ethics/social meaning | *Material well-being (artha)* as means, *pleasure (kāma)* as end; refined versus crude hedonism; source caution for famous verses. | Prudence versus morality; *daṇḍanīti*, *vārttā*, king-as-God report; positivism and naturalism qualified. |
- | 9. Synthesis | ONE means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), FOUR elements, TWO operative aims, ZERO transcendent entities; reconstruct before criticising. | Cross-school positioning, controlled comparison, directive decoder and criterion-named graded verdicts. |

Rapid answer spine

SOURCE CAUTION

- > PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa) ALONE
- > INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (vyāpti) / HIDDEN LIMITING CONDITION (upādhi)

CRITIQUE

- > NYAYA REPLY
- > FOUR-ELEMENT MATERIALISM
- > BODY-SELF AND EMERGENT CONSCIOUSNESS
- > NO TRANSCENDENT ENTITIES
- > MATERIAL WELL-BEING (artha) AS MEANS, PLEASURE (kāma) AS END
- > COMPARISON + CRITERION-NAMED VERDICT

Rapid recall: ONE *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* · FOUR *bhūtas* · TWO operative aims · ZERO transcendent entities.

PYQ routes at a glance

Route	Verified primary-owned questions
Inference and consistency	2018 Q8(b); 2019 Q5(c); 2019 Q6(c); 2025 Q5(a)
Materialism and transcendence	2020 Q6(b); 2021 Q5(e)
Comparisons	2020 Q7(c), Cārvāka–Jainism; 2024 Q6(a), Cārvāka–Buddhism
Comparative label	2024 Q5(a), positivistic nature

KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

Term	Rapid meaning
<i>Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda</i>	Perception alone is an independent <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i>
<i>Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)</i>	Exceptionless relation required by inference
<i>Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)</i>	Hidden qualifying condition that defeats an over-broad universal
<i>Lokasiddha inference (anumāna)</i>	Practical, perception-redeemable expectation; not secure proof of transcendence
<i>Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)</i>	The conscious living body is the self
<i>Emergent consciousness from material elements (bhūta-caitanya-vāda)</i>	Consciousness emerges from organised elements
<i>Explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)</i>	Natural own-natures replace divine or unseen governance
<i>Yadṛcchāvāda</i>	Accidentalism; association with Cārvāka is contested
<i>Dhūrta / suśikṣita</i>	Opponent-preserved crude/refined differentiation; use cautiously
Answer sentence	Cārvāka's ontology is the consequence of restricting valid knowledge to perception

Detailed legacy consolidated register — preserved

Placement note: These register notes come **after** all teaching and practice, and cover **every one of the nine subtopics** taught in this session. They are the last-mile revision layer, not a substitute for the session above.

Register 1 — Sources, names and historical setting

Item	Register entry
Syllabus wording	✓ "Carvaka : Theory of Knowlegde; Rejection of Transcendent Entities" (printed wording retained)
Names	✓ Cārvāka (<i>carv</i> , to chew / <i>cāru-vāk</i> , sweet-worded) · Lokāyata (<i>lokāyata-mata</i> , view of common people) · Bārhaspatya (of Bṛhaspati)
Traditional founder	✓ Bṛhaspati; his <i>Sūtra</i> is lost; about a dozen <i>sūtras</i> survive as quotations
Transmission	✓ Known "chiefly" from works that state the views in order to refute them
Sharma's verdict on sources	✓ "The weak points ... are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture"
Key doxographies	✓ <i>Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha</i> (Mādhava) · <i>Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya</i> (Haribhadra) · <i>Prabodhacandrodaya</i> (a play, Kṛṣṇamiśra) · <i>Tattvasaṅgraha</i> (Śāntarakṣita) · <i>Vedāntasāra</i> (Sadānanda)
Only surviving text	✓ <i>Tattvopaplavasīmha</i> , Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa , c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — but he attacks perception too and admits not even the elements
Six transmitted <i>sūtras</i>	✓ four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness as intoxicating power · <i>caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ</i> · <i>pleasure (kāma) evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ</i> · <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>
<i>Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)</i> — exact sense	✓ Rejects the authority of the Veda (primary sense); also denies life after death (secondary sense); <i>Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)</i> in both
Historical anchors	✓ Ajita Kesakambalī (<i>Majjhima Nikāya</i> ; believed only in perception and four elements) · Pūraṇa Kassapa · Makkhali Gosāla · Saṅjaya Belaṭṭhiputta (<i>Sāmaññaphala-sutta</i>)
Causes of its rise (Sharma)	✓ Protest against monkdōm and ritual externals; Upaniṣadic idealism unsuited to commoners; exploitation and social crisis
Two standing verdicts	⚠ Chatterjee–Datta: the school was the touchstone of every system · Sharma: "Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought"
Mnemonic	🔑 ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO — one <i>means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)</i> , four elements, two <i>puruṣārthas</i> , zero transcendent entities

Register 2 — Epistemology

- ✓ **Thesis:** *pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda* — perception alone is a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*.
- ✓ "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend **logically** on their epistemology" (Chatterjee and Datta).
- ✓ **The standard demanded:** knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".

- ✓ **Both** external (*bāhya*) and internal (*mānasa*) perception are admitted.
- ✓ Consciousness **is** established by perception; what is denied is the inference from consciousness to an immaterial bearer.
- ✓ **The concession:** "in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference" — but "truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an **accident**, and a **separable** one."
- ⚠ **Laukika / vyāvahārika** inference (corrigible, perceptually redeemable) versus **alaukika / pāramārthika** inference (structurally uncheckable). The second is the real target.
- ✓ **Verbal testimony (śabda) in five steps:** words are heard, hence perceived → what they *mean* is unperceived → acceptance runs through "this authority is reliable; all reliable authority should be accepted" → that is inference → hence testimony is "as precarious as inference".
- ✓ **The Veda:** "the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous".
- ✓ Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*), "none would be able to infer anything by himself".
- ⚠ **One template kills the rest:** *comparison* (*upamāna*), *postulation* (*arthāpatti*) and *non-cognition* (*anupalabdhi*) each require an unperceived universal.
- ⚠ **Sharma's same-standpoint charge:** Śūnyavāda and Advaita reject the *ultimate* validity of **all means of valid knowledge** (*pramāṇas*) including perception while retaining empirical validity; the *vyāvahārika* / *pāramārthika* distinction is "unknown to the Cārvāka", so accepting perception and rejecting inference at one level is "a thoughtless self-contradiction".
- 🔑 **Ledger to reproduce:** Cārvāka 1 · Vaiśeṣika and Buddhism 2 · Sāṃkhya-Yoga 3 · Nyāya 4 · Prābhākara 5 · Bhāṭṭa and Advaita 6.

Register 3 — The critique of inference

- ✓ Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".
- ✓ The attack targets the **major premise** (*vyāpti*), never syllogistic form.
- ✓ **Door 1 — perception:** all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.
- ✓ **The class-character (*sāmānya*) exchange:** even *dhūmatva* cannot be perceptually known, since not all smokes are perceived; and a universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference. "The difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal ... remains here as before."
- ✓ **Door 2 — inference:** *petitio principii* or regress. Sharma: "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle. The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference."
- ✓ A **causal** relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.
- ✓ **Door 3 — testimony:** its own validity is inferred; and if inference depended on testimony, no one could infer by himself.
- ✓ **Hidden limiting condition (*upādhi*):** the wet-fuel condition — one who infers **smoke from fire** errs, because fire is attended with smoke only where fuel is wet. Unconditionality "cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden".
- ⚠ **Hidden limiting condition (*upādhi*)** is a problem of the **right variable**, not of sample size — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it, and why Nyāya must bring in *hypothetical reasoning* (*tarka*).
- ✓ **2019 Socrates syllogism:** the form is granted; "All men are mortal" is the *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*); it fails the three doors; the deduction merely re-states an unestablished universal.

-  **Self-refutation (Sharma):** the denial is itself a universal; thoughts, ideas and other minds are never perceived; "the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy".
-  **Three replies:** *vitaṇḍā* / no-thesis · softened certainty-thesis (strongest) · level-distinction (a repair, not a historical doctrine).
-  **Sharma's tu quoque:** flat earth, static earth, small solar disc — perception errs and is corrected *by inference*; and mere sensation is not knowledge "unless conception or thought has arranged into order ... the loose threads of sense-data" (*Tattvasaṅgraha*).
-  **Verdict formula:** the Cārvāka may be **consistent** or **radical**, but not both.

Register 4 — The Nyāya defence

-  **The eight-stage ladder:** *bhūyodarśana* → *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)*-elimination → *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* → *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* → *vyāptigraha* → *liṅga-darśana* → *parāmarśa* → *anumiti*.
-  **Agreement in presence (anvaya)** (wherever *hetu*, there *sādhya*) and **agreement in absence (vyatireka)** (where no *sādhya*, no *hetu*) — the joint method; systematic search for negative cases, not mere counting.
-  **Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)** is a condition that pervades the *sādhya* but not the *hetu*; a defective universal is **restated** at the correct level — "fire joined with wet fuel".
-  **Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)** is *pramāṇa-anugrahaka*, not a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*; it assumes the contradictory and exhibits *aniṣṭa-prasaṅga*, removing the doubt that blocks *vyāptigraha*.
-  **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa:** the universal is presented through the particular — Nyāya's direct answer to the class-character objection.
-  **Parāmarśa:** the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance is the *karaṇa* of *anumiti* — hence, for Nyāya, no "leap" occurs at all.
-  **Nirvikalpaka / savikalpaka:** determinate perception is already conceptually qualified, so the Cārvāka's "pure given" is either pre-cognitive or not pure.
-  **The decisive move:** replace **omniscient certainty** with **disciplined rational warrant**. "The Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice."
-  **Honest residue:** *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* proves nothing alone; *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* presupposes realism about universals; only **suspected upādhis** can be eliminated.
-  **Cross-school survey (2018 Q8(b)):** Nyāya, Sāṃkhya-Yoga, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain inference; Advaita retains it *vyāvahārikaally* while denying ultimate validity to all *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)*.
-  **Verdict:** Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as **warranted**, not as **indubitable**.

Register 5 — Metaphysics and materialism

-  **Bridging principle:** ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)*. Name it as a **presupposition**.
-  *prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — four *bhūtas*; *tatsamudāye śāñrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.
-  Living organisms too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.
-  **The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish** (Sharma). Hence Cārvāka is a **realist** materialism, not a flux doctrine.

- ✓ **Ākāśa rejected** "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate is refused.
- ⚠ Cārvāka's most defensible line on sound: naturalise it into the perceptible air, rather than abandon the substance–quality scheme he uses for the four elements.
- ✓ *kiṇvādirbhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.
- ✓ **Betel** (leaf, lime, nut → red): **compositional** emergence. **Fermentation** (*guḍa* → intoxicant): **transformational** emergence. Two analogies, two distinct objections answered.
- ✓ Consciousness is an "**epiphenomenon** or bye-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile".
- ⚠ **Explanatory gap:** redness and intoxication are public, third-person qualities; consciousness is private and first-personal. Best Cārvāka reply: the soul-hypothesis **renames** the gap rather than closing it.
- ✓ **Pot and potter:** clay is the material cause and the potter the efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with *svabhāva* — "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design".
- ✓ **Three labels from the textbook:** naturalism (*svabhāvavāda*) · mechanism (*yadr̥cchāvāda*) · **positivism** ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").
- ⚠ **Two uses of *svabhāva*:** deflationary (regularity, with "neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future") and substantive (nature in place of God). The "empty label" objection bites only on the second.
- ✓ **Sadānanda's *Vedāntasāra*:** four materialist schools identify the self with the gross body, the senses, the vital breaths, or *sensory mind* (*manas*). Śāntarakṣita reports *Kambalāśvatara* holding that consciousness arises from the body **associated with vital breaths**.
- ⚠ Cārvāka reaches materialism by an **anti-inferential** route; modern materialism by a thoroughly **inferential** one.

Register 6 — Self, body and consciousness

- ✓ *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ / caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā* — the person is the **living** body qualified by consciousness. Not the corpse; not "no self at all"; not identity with any single element.
- ✓ **Negative argument:** "the non-material soul is **never perceived**".
- ✓ **Positive argument:** "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — if the "I" were different from the body these would be **meaningless**.
- ✓ **Covariation:** injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness.
- ✓ **Consequence:** "death of the body means the end of the individual"; questions of previous life, after-life, rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- ✓ **Sharma's objection battery:** self-consciousness versus animal life · swoon, fits, epilepsy and dreamless sleep = body without consciousness · dreams = consciousness "without the living body", and the waking dreamer disowns the dream-body but **owns** the dream-consciousness · subject cannot be reduced to object · **co-existence is not causation** (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard" · consciousness is **private** · the self-manifestation regress · the non-existence of a surviving soul is equally undemonstrable.
- ⚠ **Best evaluative line:** the evidence establishes **dependence**; dependence is compatible with the body being the **instrument** rather than the cause.

-  **Memory:** Nyāya/Vedānta invoke *enduring self (ātman)* · Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity of one organism · Buddhism invokes *santāna, pratisandhāna* and (Yogācāra) *ālaya-vijñāna* carrying *bījas*.
-  **2024 core contrast:** Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into process. Substance retained versus substance abolished.
-  **Grounds:** Cārvāka's is epistemic (never perceived); Buddhism's is ontological (*pratītyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda*) and soteriological (self-belief breeds *trṣṇā*).
-  **Aftermaths:** Cārvāka ends the moral narrative at death; Buddhism preserves action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth and *cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa)* without an owner.
-  **The decisive refinement:** *rūpa* is itself one of the five *skandhas*, so Buddhist *anātman* rules out the Cārvāka body-self **by name**.
-  **Foils: Puggalavāda** (Vātsīputrīya) inside Buddhism; **Sadānanda's four materialisms** inside Cārvāka.

Register 7 — Rejection of transcendent entities

-  **The template:** X is imperceptible → only inference or testimony could reach X → neither is a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* → X is unwarranted → X is rejected.
-  Note the gap between **withholding assent** and **denying**; the doxographies attribute denial ("the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism"), the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
-  **God falls twice:** epistemically (no *pramāṇa*) and explanatorily (*svabhāva* suffices; the world's objects are "fortuitous products of the elements").
-  **Adṛṣṭa** is named among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like *adṛṣṭa*)". Its very name means "the unseen", making it the perfect test case.
-  **Transmigration requires** a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three. Cārvāka cuts every one.
-  **Heaven and hell** are "the inventions of the priests"; *svarga* rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
-  **The liberation dilemma:** freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) · freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain) · residue: *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ*, which "no wise man would willingly work for".
-  *Maraṇam eva apavargaḥ* is a **reductio of the concept of liberation (mokṣa)**, not a recommendation of death.
-  **Three ritual reductios:** *śrāddha* and the traveller's food · food downstairs feeding a person upstairs · *jyotiṣṭoma* — "why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents?" The last is an argument from **revealed preference**.
-  *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*: the Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes were "made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons".  Quote with a source-caution.
-  **Cārvāka's uniqueness:** Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are also non-theistic. Cārvāka alone derives its atheism from its **epistemology**, and alone discards *action and moral consequence (karma)*, rebirth and liberation as well.
-  Internal tension worth flagging: *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* grounds regularity in fixed natures; *yadṛcchāvāda* calls the world "fortuitous".

Register 8 — Ethics and social meaning

- ✓ *pleasure (kāma) evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — enjoyment is the only end; **material well-being (artha) is its means**; *dharma* and *liberation (mokṣa)* are rejected.
- ✓ *Dharma* falls on **epistemic** grounds: "virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- ✓ **Criterion**: a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- ✓ **Dhūrta** (cunning / crude) versus **suśikṣita** (cultured / refined) Cārvākas — "the Cārvākas were not all of the same gross, uncultured type".
- ✓ **Evidence for refinement**: sixty-four fine arts (*catuḥ-śaṣṭi-kalāḥ*) · *daṇḍanīti* and *vārttā* incorporated into Lokāyata · some Cārvākas "regard the **king as God**", implying faith in society and its head.
- ✓ **Vātsyāyana** is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism", but he "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term" — one who explains higher phenomena by lower.
- ✓ **Vātsyāyana's regulation**: *brahmacarya*, urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*), education of the senses through the arts; and the prudential argument that refusing to defer "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds".
- ✓ Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is **not compatible with social discipline**."
- ⚠ **Sharma's counterweight**: "crude individual hedonism"; the school's downfall lay in "the denial of all human values"; "**the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher**."
- ? **The "debt and ghee" verse** — "let him feed on ghee even though he runs in debt" — is preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*, an opponent's compendium. Use with an explicit source-caution; its buried argument concerns the rationality of deferral under a finite horizon, and Vātsyāyana himself answers it.
- ⚠ **Verdict**: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of **prudence** and an incomplete theory of **morality** — it supplies no qualitative ordering of pleasures and no independent account of other-regarding obligation.

Register 9 — Comparative synthesis and answer craft

Item	Register entry
2020 Jainism axes	✓ 1 means of valid knowledge (<i>pramāṇa</i>) vs fivefold knowledge · 4 <i>bhūtas</i> vs 6 <i>dravyas</i> · <i>ākāśa</i> rejected vs accepted · no soul vs infinite <i>individual self (jīvas)</i> with consciousness as inseparable essence · no <i>constituent quality (guṇa)</i> – <i>paryāya</i> vs <i>utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya</i> · single standpoint vs <i>anekānta, naya, syādvāda</i> · no action and moral consequence (<i>karma</i>) vs material action and moral consequence (<i>karma</i>), split into <i>bhāva-bandha</i> and <i>dravya-bandha</i> · no liberation vs <i>liberation (mokṣa)</i> and <i>kevala-jñāna</i>
Shared ground with Jainism	✓ Both <i>Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)</i> ; both realists about the perceptible world; both reject a creator God
2024 positivism verdict	⚠ Positivistic in spirit (empiricist criterion, anti-metaphysics, "meaningless" register — and the textbook itself applies the word), not in method (positivism runs on inference and has a constructive programme). Safer labels: radical empiricism, naturalistic materialism

Item	Register entry
The paradox to quote	⚠ Cārvāka reaches materialism by an anti-inferential route; modern materialism by an inferential one
Western convergences	⚠ Epicurus and Lucretius (materialism, this-worldliness) · Hume (induction unjustifiable) · Ayer (unverifiable metaphysics) · Comte (observable phenomena). Chatterjee and Datta themselves compare the Cārvāka view of inference to "the pragmatists and logical positivists" and the school's reputation to that of "the Epicureans of Greece"
10-mark spine	Thesis → three doors → one sharp addition (<i>upādhi</i> or self-refutation) → verdict linking epistemology to the denial asked about
15-mark spine	Frame with the source caution → full anti-inference argument → the rival's positive case → Cārvāka's best reply and its cost → graded verdict with a named criterion
20-mark spine	Classify (epistemology generating metaphysics) → theory of knowledge in full → ontological consequences → the demanded comparison on named axes → two objections with replies and residual pressure → criterion-named verdict
PYQ centre of gravity	✅ 5 of 9 owned parts concern inference ; 2 the self and transcendent entities; 1 the Jaina comparison; 1 the positivism label
Criteria to name in verdicts	⚠ Evidential economy · explanatory adequacy · internal consistency · perceptual redeemability · moral sufficiency · historiographical reliability
The five safe verdicts	⚠ Critique of certainty, not a theory of knowledge · ontology impeccably derived, so vulnerability lies in the epistemology · wins on entailment, loses on <i>means of valid knowledge</i> (<i>pramāṇa</i>)-status · relocation versus dissolution of the self · complete prudence, incomplete morality
Final memory spine	🔑 ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO · three doors · wet fuel · betel and fermentation · "I am fat, I am lame, I am blind" · <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i> · <i>dhūrta</i> and <i>suśikṣita</i> · touchstone

End of the complete learning session.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/12: Identity, names and the source problem

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/12: Identity, names and the source problem

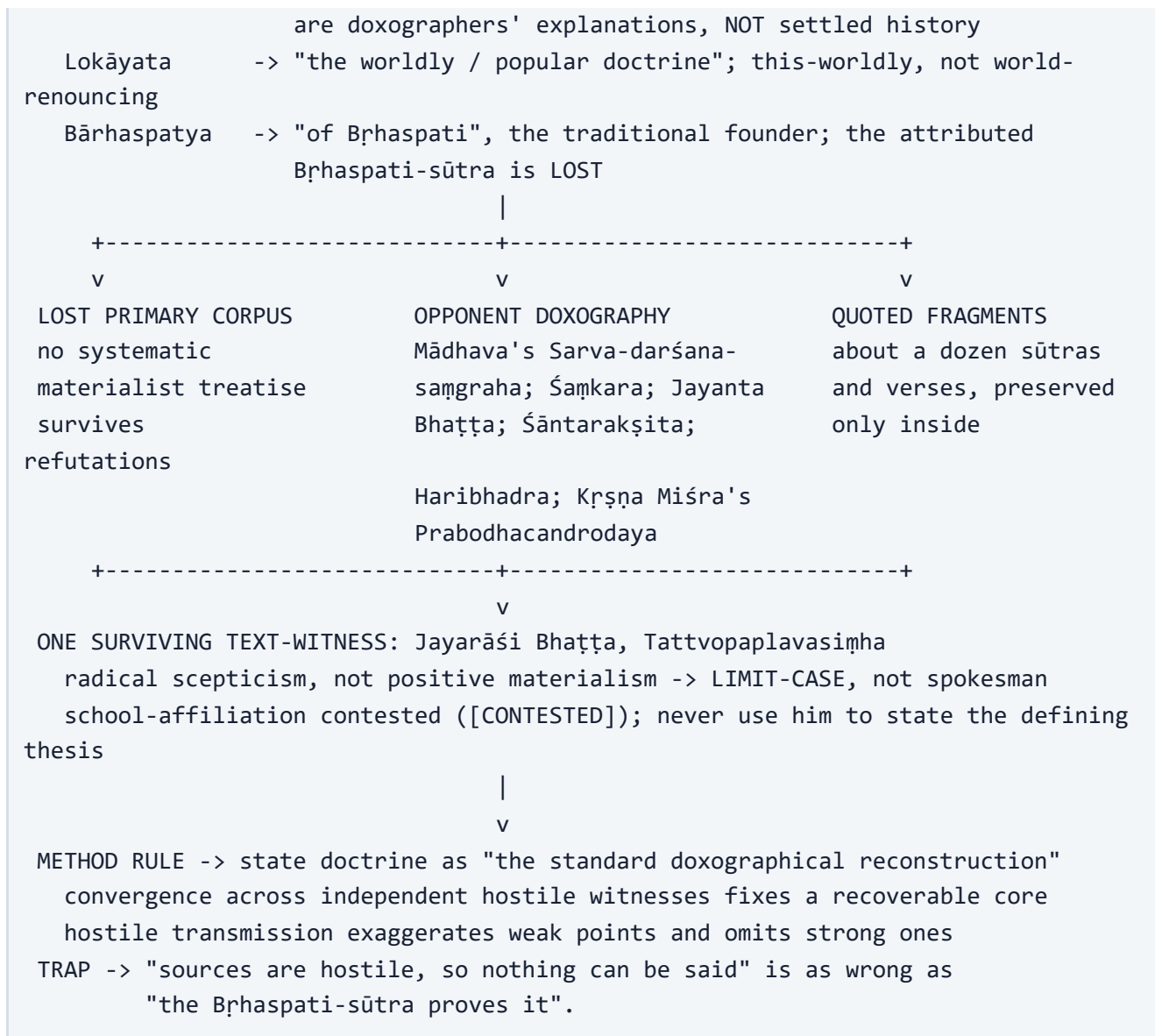
CENTRAL QUESTION: what may be affirmed about a school whose own books are lost?

|

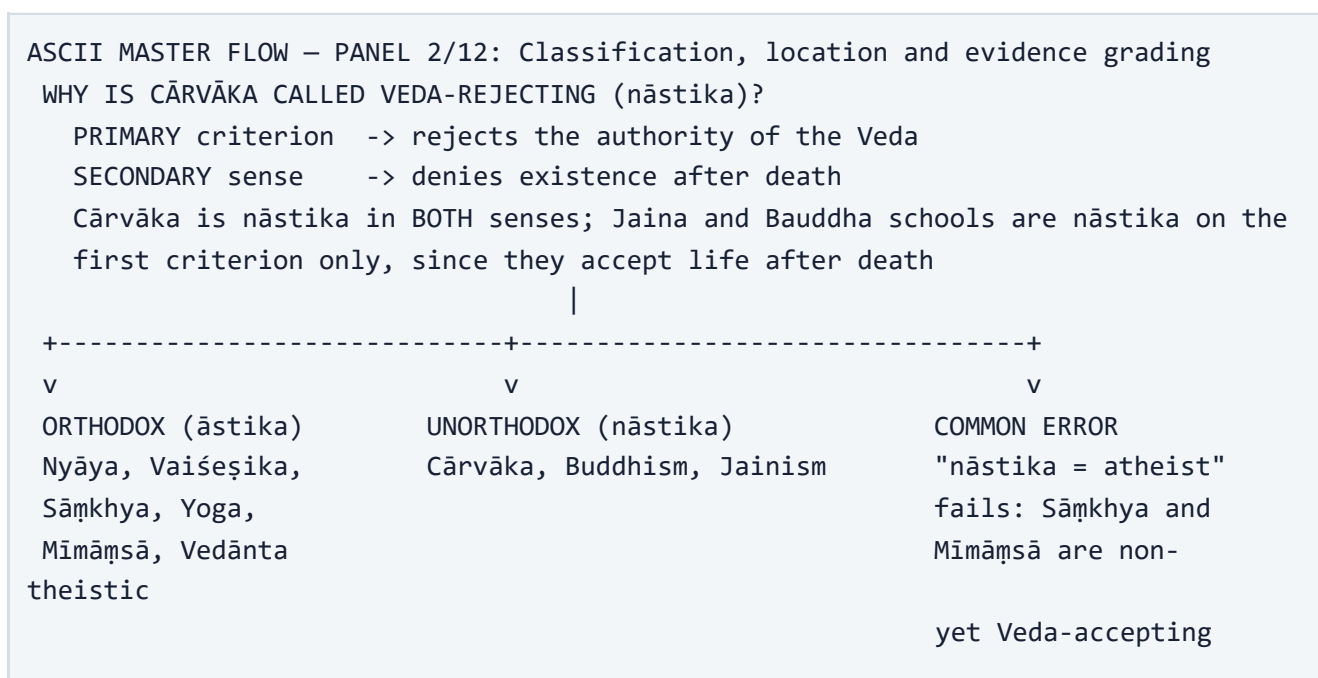
v

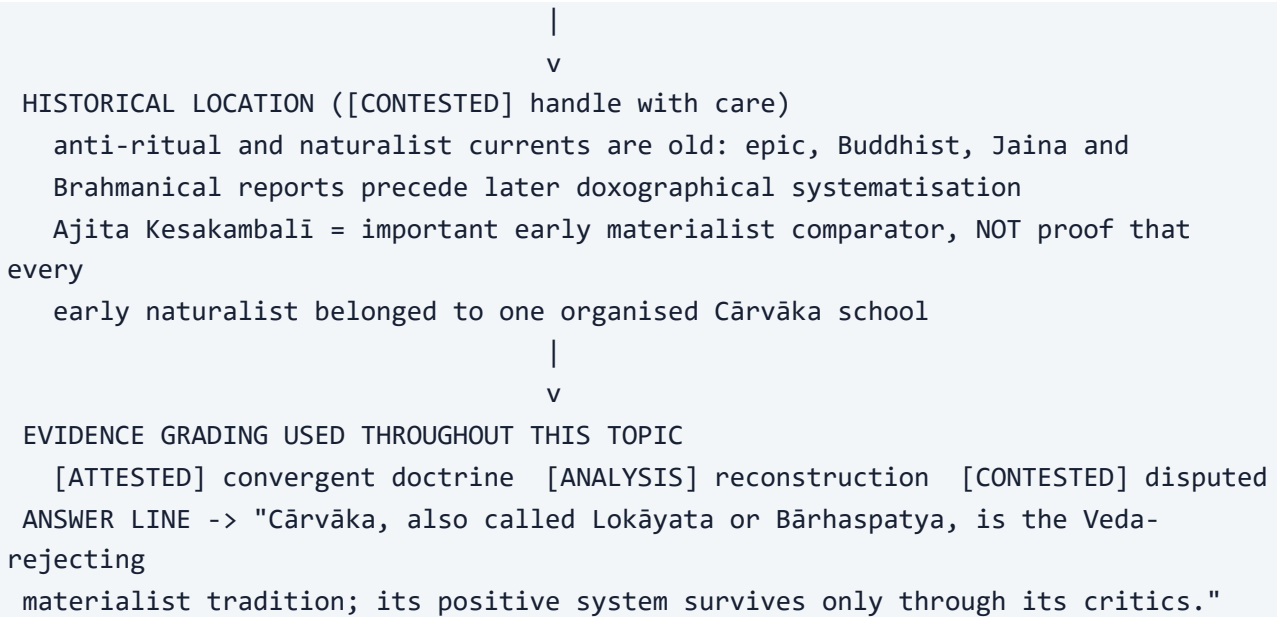
NAMES OF ONE TRADITION (all three are used of the same materialist stream)

Cārvāka -> standard school label; etymologies from "to chew" / "pleasant speech"

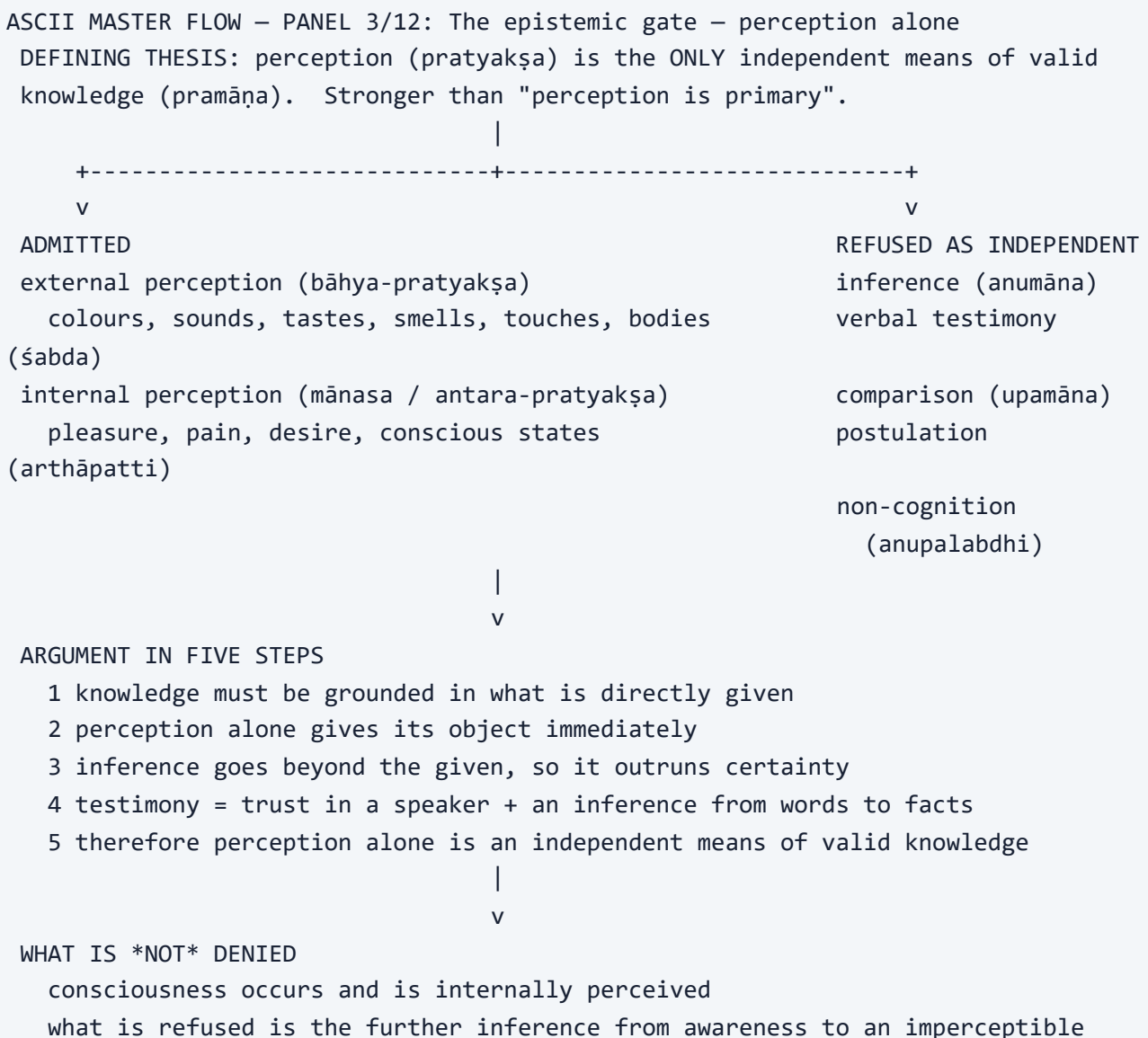


ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 2/12: Classification, location and evidence grading





ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 3/12: The epistemic gate — perception alone



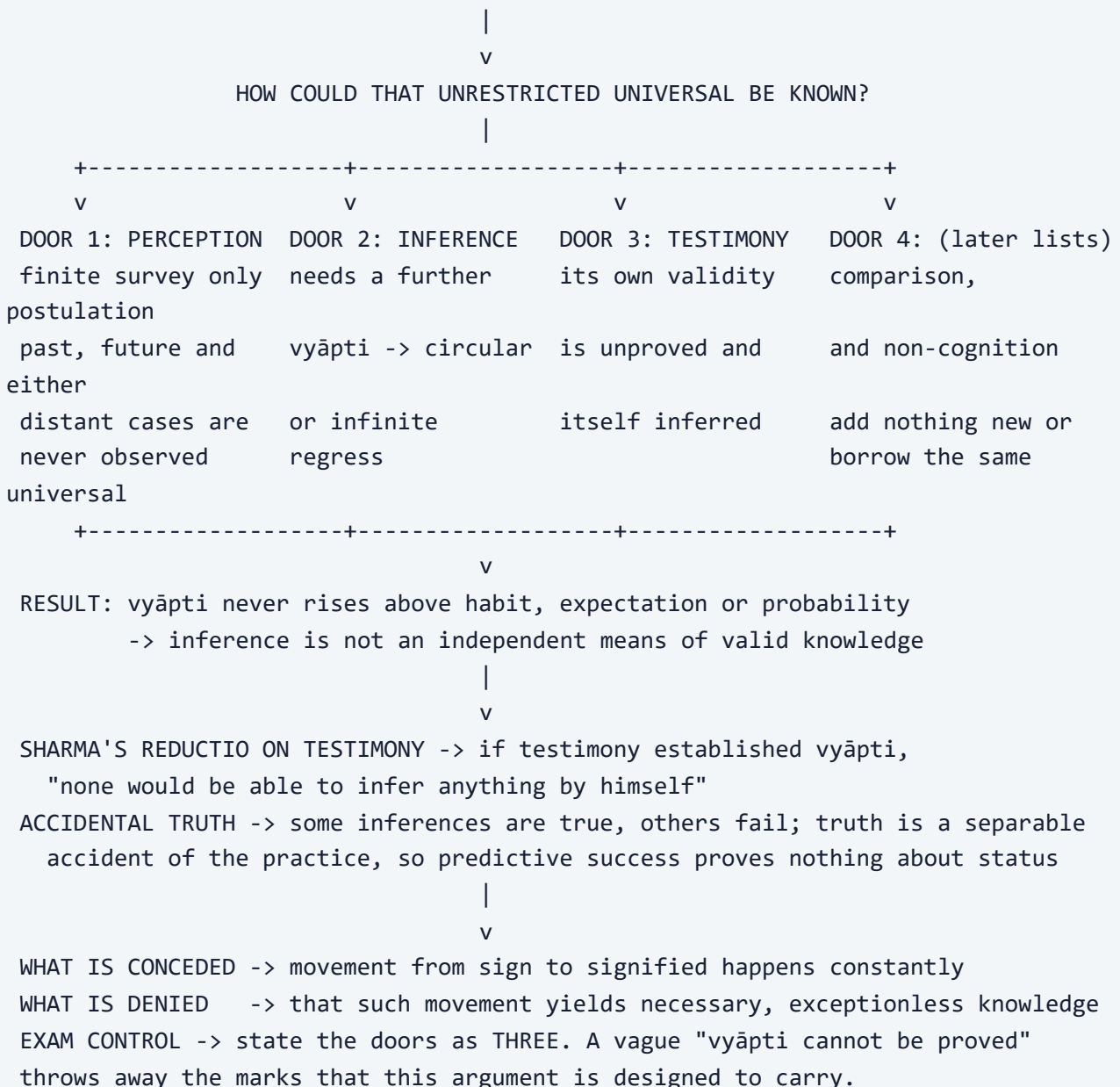
bearer

TRAP -> "Cārvāka denies consciousness" is FALSE; it denies a transcendental self
PRESUPPOSITION [ANALYSIS] -> epistemic access fixes ontological commitment: admit
into being
only what can in principle be presented in perception.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 4/12: The attack on inference — three closed doors

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 4/12: The attack on inference — three closed doors

EVERY INFERENCE NEEDS INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (vyāpti): "wherever smoke, there
fire"



ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 5/12: Hidden limiting condition and self-refutation

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 5/12: Hidden limiting condition and self-refutation
HIDDEN LIMITING CONDITION (upādhi)

observed: smoke with fire, many times -> hasty universal: smoke proves fire
 but what was constant may have been fire-PLUS-WET-FUEL, or combustion under an
 unnoticed qualifier -> the supposed universal was too broad all along
 STRUCTURAL, not quantitative: it survives however many cases are collected
 TRAP -> upādhi is NOT the same as "too few instances observed"

|
v

THE SOCRATES SYLLOGISM (2019, 15 marks) – where the objection lands

"All men are mortal / Socrates is a man / therefore Socrates is mortal"

FORM is conceded valid. The target is the MAJOR PREMISE, which is a vyāpti:

no one has perceived all men; relocating the relation to man-ness and mortality
 does not help, because class-characters are not perceived either

VERDICT -> valid but epistemically empty: it transmits a certainty never
 acquired

|
v

SELF-REFUTATION CHARGE (2019, 2025)

1 "no inference is a means of valid knowledge" quantifies over all inferences

2 no single perception delivers a universal

3 so the thesis is inferred (self-defeating) or undefended (unassertable)

4 Sharma presses further: thoughts and other minds are never perceived, so the
 Cārvāka "can understand others only through inference"

|

+-----+-----+
 v v v

REPLY A: vitaṇḍā
 distinction

assert nothing, only
 destroy the opponent –

–
 but four elements and a
 body-self ARE asserted
 Cārvāka"

REPLY B: softened thesis

deny apodictic certainty,
 especially about the

transcendent – a weaker
 but defensible doctrine

REPLY C: level-

concede practical
 validity, deny ultimate

but that distinction is
 "unknown to the

v

VERDICT [ANALYSIS] -> radical or consistent, but not both.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 6/12: The Nyāya defence and a balanced verdict

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: The Nyāya defence and a balanced verdict

NYĀYA REBUILDS INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE WITHOUT OMNISCIENT SURVEY

agreement in presence (anvaya) -> repeated positive co-observation

agreement in absence (vyatireka) -> no counter-instance where the probandum
 is absent

elimination of suspected upādhis -> known qualifiers identified and excluded

hypothetical reasoning (tarka) -> denial of the relation makes experience
 incoherent; tarka removes doubt but is

perception of the universal	NOT itself a means of valid knowledge
the mark as qualified (parāmarśa)	-> sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa in later Nyāya
	-> no "leap" occurs; the sign is cognised together with the concomitance

|
v

THE REAL LOCUS OF THE DISPUTE

BOTH sides agree finite observation cannot ENTAIL an unrestricted universal

Cārvāka: entailment fails -> no knowledge -> no means-of-valid-knowledge status

Nyāya : entailment fails -> warrant does not require entailment -> status

stands

So the quarrel is about the CONCEPT OF KNOWLEDGE, not about the logic of induction

+-----+
v

WHY NYĀYA WINS AGAINST THE STRONG THESIS
[ANALYSIS]

universal denial is itself a universal;
other minds and ideas are never perceived;
the school still asserts elements and a self

SUSPECTED

none

HONEST RESIDUE AGAINST NYĀYA

tarka establishes nothing alone;
sāmānyalakṣaṇa works only inside
Nyāya realism about universals;
elimination removes only

conditions, never proves that

remains

v

GRADED VERDICT -> justified against the strong thesis, but Nyāya answers by replacing omniscient certainty with disciplined, defeasible warrant – which concedes the Cārvāka's logical point while refusing his epistemological conclusion.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 7/12: Testimony, the wider list, and the school ledger

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Testimony, the wider list, and the school ledger

WHY VERBAL TESTIMONY (śabda) IS REFUSED

1 testimony reports only that someone uttered something

2 the step from utterance to truth assumes competence and honesty

3 that assumption is not in the words; it is inferred

4 inference is already denied independent status -> testimony collapses

5 Vedic authorlessness and infallibility are not perceptually available

NOT DENIED -> ordinary communication; language may guide action until perception checks it. Usefulness is separated from means-of-valid-knowledge status.

|
v

THE SAME CRITERION APPLIED TO THE LATER LIST [ANALYSIS] (systematic

reconstruction)

- | | |
|-----------------------------|--|
| comparison (upamāna) | -> resemblance is perceived; the stable word-kind relation needs generalisation |
| postulation (arthāpatti) | -> the postulated fact is unperceived and needs a universal rule excluding alternatives |
| non-cognition (anupalabdhi) | -> "if it existed here it would be perceived" is a universal conditional, not one perception |

|

v

LEDGER OF ADMITTED MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE – CĀRVĀKA FIXES THE LOWER BOUND

- | | |
|---------------------------|--------------------|
| 1 Cārvāka | perception |
| 2 Vaiśeṣika, Buddhism | + inference |
| 3 Sāṃkhya-Yoga | + testimony |
| 4 Nyāya | + comparison |
| 5 Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā | + postulation |
| 6 Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, Advaita | + non-apprehension |

STRUCTURAL POINT -> every richer epistemology must justify its additions against Cārvāka; that is why he is the standing pūrvapakṣa of Indian philosophy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 8/12: Material ontology — four elements and own-nature

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Material ontology – four elements and own-nature
ONTOLOGICAL MINIMALISM: admit only what perception can present

|

v

FOUR ELEMENTS (bhūtas): EARTH + WATER + FIRE + AIR

eternal material bases; their combination and dissolution produce bodies, sense organs, objects and living organisms

ĀKĀŚA IS REJECTED -> it is not perceived; the Nyāya inference from sound to an imperceptible substratum inherits the disputed vyāpti problem

TRAP -> writing "five elements" is the single most punished factual slip here

PYQ ANCHOR -> 2020 Q6(b), 15 marks: rejection of ākāśa + criticism of transmigration

|

+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+

v

v

OWN NATURE (svabhāvavāda) [ATTESTED]
[CONTESTED]

fire burns, water flows down, thorns are sharp, the peacock is variegated, stone is hard
REGULARITY IS REAL; only TRANSCENDENT causation is denied – no karma, no adṛṣṭa, no divine will doxographers

explanation stops at an OBSERVABLE nature and

ACCIDENTALISM (yadṛcchāvāda)

events occur by chance, with no determining cause at all
DETERMINATE CAUSATION IS DENIED; listed by

among ahetuvāda positions

attacked by Buddhists,

Jainas

and Naiyāyikas alike;
the Cārvāka link is

CONTESTED

v

OBJECTION -> "burns by its own nature" is a refusal to explain, not an explanation

REPLY [ANALYSIS] -> every explanatory chain terminates somewhere; "God willed it" is also

terminal and far less observable. RESIDUAL FORCE [ANALYSIS] -> the school still gives no

account of WHY natures stay stable, which is precisely what vyāpti-theory supplies.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/12: Self, body and emergent consciousness

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/12: Self, body and emergent consciousness

THE LIVING BODY IS THE SELF (dehātmavāda)

1 conscious life is only ever met with as embodied

2 no self is perceived apart from bodily states

3 so an extra substance called ātman is an unwarranted addition

4 explain awareness instead as a property of the bodily complex

IDENTITY-LANGUAGE ARGUMENT -> "I am stout", "I am thin" predicate bodily properties

directly of the person. Opponent: "my body" separates possessor from possessed.

Reply: possessive grammar alone does not prove a separable substance.

EVIDENCE -> injury, intoxication, age, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness

|

v

CONSCIOUSNESS FROM THE ELEMENTS (bhūta-caitanya)

betel analogy -> leaf + lime + areca nut give a RED not present in any part

fermentation -> kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam: intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents that lack it separately

CLAIM -> an organised whole can display a NOVEL property absent from ingredients

NOT the claim that consciousness is identical with any one element

|

+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+

v

v

FOUR MATERIALIST SELF-MODELS [CONTESTED] (Sadānanda, Vedāntasāra) OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

gross body (sthūla-śarīra) / senses (indriya) /
vital processes (prāṇa) / mental organ (manas)
bearer

Jaina: an emergent
property needs a

SHARED CORE -> none survives bodily dissolution	Advaita: consciousness
is	
BOUNDARY -> this is NOT the crude/refined contrast	self-luminous; the
body	
	is known BY it
positing an	Reply [ANALYSIS] ->
	immaterial soul
renames	
	rather than explains
v	
HONEST LIMIT [ANALYSIS] -> emergence is asserted, not explained: redness and	
intoxicating	
power are third-personal, whereas awareness is first-personal.	

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/12: The rejection of transcendent entities

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: The rejection of transcendent entities					
ONE TEMPLATE, APPLIED REPEATEDLY					
X is imperceptible -> only inference or testimony could reach X -> neither is					
an					
independent means of valid knowledge -> X is not admitted					
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
v	v	v	v	v	v
immortal	rebirth	karma as	heaven	creator	Vedic infallibility
soul	and	unseen	and hell	God	and priestly authority
	trans-	moral	(unseen	(world	
	migration	force,	ritual	needs no	
		adṛṣṭa	result)	planner)	
+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+-----+					
v					
LIBERATION (mokṣa) IS CANCELLED, NOT REDESCRIBED					
opponent-preserved formula [CONTESTED] "death itself is liberation"					
(maraṇam eva apavargaḥ) -> dissolution ends the person and so ends suffering;					
it describes no positive post-mortem state					
v					
RITUAL CRITIQUE -> sacrifice and ancestral offerings promise unseen results that					
cannot be verified; the satire that ritual sustains priestly livelihood is					
SUPPLEMENTARY to the epistemological argument, never a substitute for it					
e.g. the mocking challenge that if the sacrificial victim goes to heaven, the					
sacrificer should offer his own father – a polemical fragment, not a treatise					
v					
OBJECTION -> without karma and rebirth the moral order collapses					

REPLY [ANALYSIS] -> morality need not be underwritten by cosmic bookkeeping;
 pleasure,
 pain, prudence and social consequence are enough for conduct
 STRUCTURAL VERDICT -> Cārvāka is the only Indian school whose atheism follows
 from
 its EPISTEMOLOGY rather than from cosmology or soteriology; non-theism is common
 in
 India, but this-worldliness is Cārvāka's alone. PYQ ANCHOR -> 2021 Q5(e).

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/12: Ethics, society and anti-caricature control

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/12: Ethics, society and anti-caricature control
 THE FOUR HUMAN ENDS, FILTERED

dharmā -> rejected where it rests on scriptural command or unseen reward
 mokṣa -> rejected: it presupposes a separable self and a post-mortem
 destiny

artha -> ADMITTED as the INSTRUMENT

kāma -> ADMITTED as the END

HIERARCHY MATTERS -> pleasure is the end, wealth its means; they are not co-equal

|
 v

PRUDENTIAL STRUCTURE, NOT RECKLESS APPETITE

husk-and-grain image -> do not discard grain because it carries a husk;
 secure pleasure while limiting foreseeable pain

traditional verse [ANALYSIS] "as long as one lives, let one live happily"

(yāvat jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet) -> cite as a DOXOGRAPHICAL verse associated with the
 school's image, never as a line from an extant primary text

|

+-----+-----+

v

SOCIAL AND POLITICAL SIDE [CONTESTED] (thin evidence)
 [CONTESTED]

statecraft (daṇḍanīti) and livelihood (vārttā)
 reported inside the Lokāyata curriculum;
 some Cārvākas "regard the king as God"

practical

READING [ANALYSIS] -> a secular theory of authority:
 (lokaśiddha), and is

order comes from the sovereign, not from cosmic
 dharma; prosperity from the productive arts

and

v

CRUDE vs REFINED

dhūrta -> the caricatured,
 everything-is-body version
 suśikṣita -> allows

inference

the strongest reply to the
 self-refutation charge

BOUNDARY -> doxographical

indirect; NOT two documented
 schools with surviving texts

v

EVALUATION [ANALYSIS] -> two things the rivals supply are missing: a QUALITATIVE

ranking of
 pleasures and an account of OTHER-REGARDING obligation. Honest verdict: a coherent
 theory of PRUDENCE and an incomplete theory of MORALITY.
 CONTROL -> call it naturalistic hedonism or this-worldliness; do not reduce a serious epistemological school to a slogan about eating and drinking.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/12: Comparative map, PYQ rail and answer spine

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/12: Comparative map, PYQ rail and answer spine

COMPARATIVE AXES — USE THESE FIVE, NEVER A VAGUE "MATTER vs SPIRIT"

AXIS	CĀRVĀKA	NYĀYA	BUDDHISM	JAINISM
knowledge	perception only	four means	perception +	many means
+				
self	living body	enduring ātman	inference	standpoints
jīvas			no substantial	plural
causation	observed nature	real relation	dependent orig.	persisting
transcendent	all denied	God, soul, karma	karma, no creator	karma as
matter				
liberation	death ends person	apavarga	nirvāṇa	mokṣa of
jīva				

KEY DISTINCTIONS -> Cārvāka denies TRANSCENDENCE but keeps a MATERIAL BEARER; Buddhism denies SUBSTANTIALITY but keeps MORAL CONTINUITY, and rules out the body-self by name, since material form is itself an aggregate declared not-self.

|
v

DIRECTLY OWNED PYQ RAIL (Paper I, Section B)

2018 Q8(b) 15	cross-school acceptability of the rejection of inference
2019 Q5(c) 10	consistency of the rejection of inference
2019 Q6(c) 15	what is wrong with the Socrates syllogism
2020 Q6(b) 15	rejection of ākāśa + criticism of transmigration
2020 Q7(c) 15	Cārvāka and Jaina conceptions of reality
2021 Q5(e) 10	bearing of epistemology on the rejection of transcendent
entities	
2024 Q5(a) 10	is the philosophy positivistic?
2024 Q6(a) 20	Cārvāka refutation of self vs Buddhist rejection of ātman
2025 Q5(a) 10	grounds for rejecting inference
SUPPORTING 2022 Q7(c) 15 (Nyāya-owned):	the Naiyāyika reply to these objections

|
v

ANSWER SPINE -> define + flag reconstruction -> perception-only thesis -> three doors + upādhi -> Nyāya reply -> derive ontology (four elements, body-self, emergent awareness) -> transcendent denials -> ethics -> ONE comparison -> QUALIFIED VERDICT: a rigorous empiricist protest and a decisive standing pūrvapakṣa, but not a complete theory of knowledge, since the exclusive

perceptual

criterion is narrower than the reasoning needed to defend it.

Canonical authority control

The canonical owner confirms the governing distinctions used throughout this package: *pratyakṣa* alone is the standard Cārvāka *pramāṇa*; the critique of *anumāna* targets the certainty of *vyāpti* and hidden *upādhi*; consciousness is accepted as embodied awareness rather than denied; *bhūta-caitanyavāda* is an emergent materialist account; *svabhāvavāda* must not be collapsed into purposeless chance; and attributed verses, Jayarāśi's affiliation, and the *dhūrta/suśikṣita* distinction remain contested rather than direct Cārvāka self-testimony.